
MOVEMENTAL · ONBOARDED LEADER RESEARCH

Neil Cole

Movement leader research dossier — profile, content catalog, digital presence, fragmentation story, and onboarding materials.

Generated June 09, 2026 · 33 sections · Slug: neil-cole

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Research Index

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Neil Cole — research sidebar manifest

Canonical paths aligned with Author Profile `/profile` navigation.

Sidebar slug	File	Status
author-profile	profile/identity.md	populated
author-profile	network/organizations.md	populated
biography	profile/biography.md	populated
theological-profile	profile/theology.md	populated
vocational-profile	summary.md	populated
vocational-profile	profile/calling-profile.md	empty
voice-editorial-identity	profile/voice-analysis.md	populated
bibliography	content/books.md	populated
frameworks	content/frameworks.md	populated
articles-blog-posts	content/articles.md	populated
audio-podcast	content/audio.md	populated
video-content	content/videos.md	populated
content-audit	content/content-audit.md	populated
academic-work	content/academic.md	populated
courses-training	content/courses.md	populated
audience-profile	analysis/audience-analysis.md	populated
where-you-publish	digital-presence/websites.md	populated
where-you-publish	digital-presence/platforms.md	populated
where-you-publish	digital-presence/newsletters.md	populated
social-media	digital-presence/social-media.md	populated
the-fragmentation-story	fragmentation-story.md	populated
a-letter	reflected-understanding/neil-cole.md	populated
(onboarding)	welcome-letter.md	populated

Staff-only research lives in `_staff/` ; collateral in `_misc/` .

At a Glance — Summary

`docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/neil-cole/summary.md`

Neil Cole

Neil Cole is a church-multiplication practitioner and author whose calling has been, from the beginning, to recover the church's smallest reproducible unit — the disciple in relationship to another disciple — and to release it to multiply. Born and raised in Los Angeles in 1960, trained as a fine artist and a New Testament student, and shaped by a season as an ocean lifeguard, he left a conventional Grace Brethren pastorate in Alta Loma, California in 1999 to start a different kind of church in the smoking section of a Long Beach coffeehouse. That community, Awakening Chapel, and the organization it seeded — Church Multiplication Associates — became the seedbed for two operational technologies that have shaped a generation of planters: the Life Transformation Group, a two-or-three-person unit of Scripture, confession, and prayer, and the Organic Church Planters' Greenhouse training cycle. His conviction, repeated across his corpus, is that "the highest potential of the church is in its smallest unit." Across a remarkable nine-year publishing run (2005–2014) he became one of the most-cited North American voices in the missional, simple-church, and organic-church conversation — Organic Church (2005) named the category; Church 3.0 (2010), Search & Rescue (2008), Church Transfusion (2012), and Primal Fire (2014) deepened it. He co-founded 100 Movements in 2015 with Alan Hirsch, Dave Rhodes, Will Mancini, and Jessie Cruickshank. Then, by his own account, God told him to stop; he kept a thirteen-year public silence and re-emerged in 2024 as an elder voice received by the next generation of microchurch leaders. His significance is that he built rapid, decentralized, low-bar/high-cost discipleship multiplication into a repeatable, exported practice — and then spent more than a decade living the anti-platform argument his books had always made.

Calling

Cole's calling is to **make disciples who make disciples**, and to design the simplest possible structures that let that multiplication run. He is not a builder of institutions or a celebrity-pastor brand — both Organic Leadership (2009) and Primal Fire (2014) are structurally arguments against hierarchy and the concentration of leadership. His instinct is agricultural rather than industrial: church grows from a living seed that already contains its whole DNA, rather than being assembled from a kit. His irreducible operating principle, carried into Starling Initiatives, is "Listen to Jesus and do what He says."

Body of Work

- **Discipleship technology** — the Life Transformation Group (Cultivating a Life for God, 1999) and the Organic Church Planters' Greenhouse (with Paul Kaak): the practical machinery of reproducible discipleship.
- **The organic-church canon** — Organic Church (2005), Church 3.0 (2010), Church Transfusion (with Phil Helfer, 2012): naming and operationalizing decentralized, household-scale church.
- **Discipleship and leadership** — Search & Rescue (2008), Ordinary Hero (2011), Organic Leadership (2009), Journeys to Significance (2011).
- **Fivefold ministry** — Primal Fire (2014), his APEST book, written with four co-thinkers each carrying one of the five gifts.
- **Late, interior writing** — Rising Tides (2018), Pray (2019), VIRAL (2021), Journeys (2024), self-published under Starling Initiatives, narrating a theology of obscurity and intimacy with Christ.

Significance

Cole is consistently cited as a bridge between the simple/organic-church stream and the global Disciple-Making Movement (DMM) / Church Planting Movement (CPM) stream; his LTG was adapted by the International Mission Board into a tool called CHAT, and practitioners like Curtis Sergeant and Steve Addison treat his work as foundational. His frameworks run parallel to and are mutually endorsed with Alan Hirsch's mDNA and APEST work, which is part of why 100 Movements could draw on both. His late-career witness — thirteen years of chosen obscurity by a high-output author — gives unusual weight to his core claim that intimacy with Christ produces fruit that platform-building cannot.

Institutional Anchors (current)

- **Starling Initiatives** — global collective, training, and self-publishing imprint (Long Beach, founded ~2018).
- **Kairos Pacific University** — Professor of Church Development.
- **100 Movements** — co-founder (current operational involvement unknown).

Author Profile — Identity

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/neil-cole/profile/identity.md

Identity Verification: Neil Cole

Status: Complete (with documented open items)

Last updated: 2026-04-29

Skill: /author-profile-discovery

Confidence: HIGH on identity fingerprint, education, organizations, and bibliography; MEDIUM on personal biographical detail; LOW on current social-media volumetrics (login-gated).

Canonical Identity

Field	Value	Confidence	Source
Full Legal Name	Neil Cole	VERIFIED	All publisher author pages, all academic and conference bios
Known As / Goes By	Neil Cole	VERIFIED	All platforms
Spouse	Dana Cole	VERIFIED	Audible bio ("married over 37 years to Dana"); DTS Voice contributor page ("married 39 years"); Starling Initiatives About ("with wife Dana")
Children	Three adult children	VERIFIED	Audible, Starling Initiatives, Goodreads bio
Grandchildren	Five (per Audible 2026 bio; "three grandchildren" per Starling Initiatives older copy)	VERIFIED	Most recent count: Audible (5), DTS Voice (5)
Born	1960	LIKELY	Internet Archive cataloguer's birth-year tag on Cultivating a Life for God (1999) — "Cole, Neil, 1960-"
Hometown	Los Angeles, CA	VERIFIED	Audible bio, Goodreads bio
Location (current)	Long Beach, CA	VERIFIED	Starling Initiatives, DTS Voice, all current bios
Personal Email	UNKNOWN — not publicly listed	UNKNOWN	—
Twitter / X Handle	@Neil_Cole	LIKELY (this is his persona; activity status post-silence UNCONFIRMED)	x.com/neil_cole — bio reads "Follower of Christ, husband, father and author of Organic Church and several other books"; SERP shows ~10.6K posts
Facebook (personal)	facebook.com/neil.cole.92	LIKELY	SERP returned this URL on Neil-Cole-organic-church queries
Facebook (org)	facebook.com/CMAResources (Signal Hill, CA)	VERIFIED	SERP and direct URL; ~8,300 likes per SERP snippet
Facebook (org #2)	Starling Initiatives private community group	VERIFIED	starlinginitiatives.com navigation links to a private FB group
LinkedIn	linkedin.com/in/neil-cole-8462654	VERIFIED	SERP confirms; titled "Neil Cole - CMA"; also listed elsewhere as "Author at Tyndale House Publishers"

Field	Value	Confidence	Source
YouTube (current org channel)	youtube.com/@starlinginitiatives (UCx750SRUAGYM2g9DzINxBFg)	VERIFIED	Linked from starlinginitiatives.com
YouTube (legacy personal)	youtube.com/user/neilcole	LIKELY	SERP m.youtube link to /user/neilcole/playlists
YouTube (teaching playlist)	"Neil Cole Organic Church teaching" — youtube.com/playlist?list=PLBZUcLU88MIA36Clw00-YyF8S5ucGiwuS	VERIFIED	SERP and direct URL
Instagram	UNKNOWN — handle not surfaced; presence may not exist	UNKNOWN	—
Blog (personal)	cole-slaw.blogspot.com — dormant since June 2017	VERIFIED	Direct fetch confirms last post 2017-06-07
SoundCloud	soundcloud.com/neil_cole	LIKELY	SERP; tracks not directly verified
Mailing Address	UNKNOWN — Long Beach, CA inferred; CMA was registered in Signal Hill, CA per Facebook page	PARTIAL	—

Disambiguation

"Neil Cole" is **not** a unique string on the internet. Disambiguation matters:

- **Neil Cole** (this subject) — Christian author, founder of Church Multiplication Associates, Long Beach CA.
- **Neil Cole** — actor/producer/writer (IMDb [nm1685643](https://www.imdb.com/name/nm1685643/)). **Not the same person.**
- **Neil Cole** — former CEO of Iconix Brand Group; subject of a Steptoe legal-news article on a vacated conviction. **Not the same person.**
- **Neil Cole** — actor on Kairos University TikTok / various LinkedIn profiles (not the church-development professor).
- **Neil Cole** — Australian-based "neilcolesy" Twitter handle. **Not the same person.**
- **Neil Cole** — multiple LinkedIn profiles ([/in/neil-cole/](https://in.linkedin.com/company/neil-cole/), [/in/neil-cole-92493624/](https://in.linkedin.com/company/neil-cole-92493624/), etc.) for individuals in marketing, retail, and other fields. **Not the same person.**

Search modifiers that reliably isolate the subject: "Neil Cole" + any of: organic church, Church Multiplication Associates, CMA Resources, Awakening Chapel, Long Beach, Life Transformation Group, LTG, Starling Initiatives, Phil Helfer, Paul Kaak.

Education

Institution	Degree	Field	Year	Source
California State University, Long Beach (CSULB)	B.A.	Fine Art	UNKNOWN — likely early-to-mid 1980s	Starling Initiatives , Kairos Pacific University
Grace Theological Seminary, Winona Lake, IN	Master of Divinity (M.Div.)	New Testament	UNKNOWN — likely late 1980s / early 1990s	Starling Initiatives , Kairos Pacific University
America Evangelical University, Gardena, CA	Doctor of Divinity (DD)	—	UNKNOWN	Kairos Pacific University

Conversion: Cole became a Christian while studying at CSULB (Audible bio, Goodreads bio).

Note on the doctorate: America Evangelical University is a small institution affiliated with the Korean-American evangelical community. The DD's nature (honorary vs earned) and date is **UNKNOWN — needs research**. Cole is consistently styled "Dr. Neil Cole" only on the Kairos Pacific University team page; most popular bios (Audible, Goodreads, conference programs, podcast intros) do not use the "Dr." prefix.

Career Timeline

Year(s)	Role	Organization	Source
~mid-1980s	Ocean lifeguard	Los Angeles County Beaches	Starling Initiatives ; referenced in Search & Rescue book promotion
1989-1999 (approx.)	Pastor	Grace Brethren church, Alta Loma, CA	GraceConnect / Charis Fellowship ; confirmed in Charisma Magazine feature description
1998-1999 (approx.)	Founder & Executive Director	Church Multiplication Associates (CMA)	Starling Initiatives , DTS Voice — both describe CMA founding "in the late 1990s"
1999	Founding pastor	Awakening Chapel , Long Beach, CA — launched in the smoking section of "The Coffee Tavern" (TCT)	Charisma Magazine feature; CMA Resources legacy node 458; multiple secondary sources
1999-~2018	Executive Director	CMA / CMAResources.org (Signal Hill, CA)	Verge Network speaker bio , all 2005-2014 book author bios
2015-present	Co-founder / Design Team	100 Movements (with Alan Hirsch, Dave Rhodes, Will Mancini, Jessie Cruickshank)	Will Mancini blog post, Nov 28, 2015
~2011/2012-~2024/2025	"13 years of silence"	Self-described God-imposed period of no public speaking, blogging, or social media in the U.S.	KCU Upside Down Kingdom, Aug 2025 ; Shifting Culture Ep. 178, April 2024
~2018-present	Founder	Starling Initiatives (global collective + self-publishing imprint)	starlinginitiatives.com
Current	Professor of Church Development	Kairos Pacific University	kairos.aeu.edu/team/neil-cole
Current	Author	Tyndale House (per LinkedIn title); previously Jossey-Bass / Wiley, Baker Books, Thomas Nelson, ChurchSmart	LinkedIn "Author at Tyndale House Publishers"; book contracts
2024-present	Re-emerging public voice (post-silence)	Guest appearances on Shifting Culture (April 2024), reChurch Eps 13-14 (Dec 2024 / Jan 2025), KC Underground Upside Down Kingdom (Aug 2025)	Episode pages

Note on the silence period

In Shifting Culture Ep. 178 (April 26, 2024) and on KC Underground's Upside Down Kingdom (Aug 2025), Cole describes a 13-year season in which God told him to stop speaking publicly in the U.S., refrain from social media, and cease blogging. The Cole-Slaw blog goes dormant after June 7, 2017; his last big-house trade publishing release is One Thing (Thomas Nelson, Nov 2015). Self-published books continue to appear under Starling Initiatives (Rising Tides 2018, Pray 2019/2022, VIRAL 2021, Journeys 2024, Primal Fire re-issue 2025) but the public-platform/teaching/conference cadence drops sharply during this window. His own characterization on the KCU episode: "I never felt like Jesus left me. Everyone else did — but He never did."

The exact start date is not stated. Working hypothesis: silence began ~2011–2012 and concluded ~2024 (consistent with the Shifting Culture re-emergence and the KCU appearance), making 13 years.

Family & Personal

- **Wife:** Dana Cole. Married 37+ years (Audible bio, ~2022); 39+ years per DTS Voice (~2022); making marriage year ~1985.
 - **Children:** Three adult children.
 - **Grandchildren:** Five (most recent count, 2026 Audible bio).
 - **Hometown:** Born and raised in Los Angeles, CA.
 - **Lives:** Long Beach, CA.
 - **Religious identification:** Originated in the Fellowship of Grace Brethren Churches (now "Charis Fellowship"). Now operates outside denominational structure (organic-church / non-denominational).
 - **Pre-ministry career:** Ocean lifeguard for Los Angeles County beaches. He has used this background as the central metaphor in Search & Rescue: Becoming a Disciple Who Makes a Difference (Baker, 2008).
 - **Artistic background:** BA in Fine Art from CSULB; "artist" is included in his Starling Initiatives self-description ("experienced church planter, author, artist, and pastor").
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Published Works (summary)

Books authored, co-authored, edited, or contributed chapter/foreword to: 17+ confirmed.

Major trade-house titles (verified):

- Cultivating a Life for God: Multiplying Disciples Through Life Transformation Groups (ChurchSmart Resources, 1999) — ISBN 978-1889638065

- Beyond Church Planting with Robert E. Logan, Holly Morgan, Julie Becker, Michelle Dodd (ChurchSmart, Sept 2005) — ISBN 978-1889638492
- Organic Church: Growing Faith Where Life Happens, foreword by Leonard Sweet (Jossey-Bass / Leadership Network Series, 2005) — ISBN 978-0787981297
- Search & Rescue: Becoming a Disciple Who Makes a Difference (Baker Books, April 2008) — ISBN 978-0801013096
- Organic Leadership: Leading Naturally Right Where You Are (Baker Books, Feb 2009) — ISBN 978-0801013102 (also Shapevine paperback ISBN 978-0801072383)
- Church 3.0: Upgrades for the Future of the Church, foreword by Francis Chan (Jossey-Bass / Leadership Network Series, Jan 26, 2010) — ISBN 978-0470529454
- Journeys to Significance: Charting a Leadership Course from the Life of Paul (Jossey-Bass / Leadership Network Series, 2011) — ISBN 978-0470529447
- Ordinary Hero: Becoming a Disciple Who Makes a Difference (Baker Books, Jan 1, 2011) — ISBN 978-0801072772
- Church Transfusion: Changing Your Church Organically — From the Inside Out with Phil Helfer (Jossey-Bass / Leadership Network Series Book 63, 2012) — ISBN 978-1118131282
- The Black Swan Effect: A Response to Gender Hierarchy in the Church, contributor (with Felicity Dale, Peggy Batcheller-Hijar, Jan Diss, Katie Driver, Dave Ferguson, Michael Frost, Alan Hirsch, Suzette Lambert, Floyd McClung; ed. Felicity Dale) (House2House / CreateSpace, 2014) — ISBN 978-1497300187
- Primal Fire: Reigniting the Church with the Five Gifts of Jesus (Tyndale Momentum, April 2014) — ISBN 978-1414385501; 2025 reissue under Starling Initiatives (ISBN 9798992152609)
- One Thing: A Revolution to Change the World with Love (Thomas Nelson, Nov 5, 2015) — ISBN 978-0718032869

Self-published / Starling Initiatives Publication Series (verified):

- Rising Tides: Finding a Future-Proof Faith in an Age of Exponential Change (Starling Initiatives, June 11, 2018) — ISBN 978-0990660484
- Pray: Finding Ways for Ordinary People to Connect with God in All of Life (Starling Initiatives, 2019/2022) — ISBN 978-1792352003
- VIRAL: Hearing God's Voice in a Global Pandemic... and Beyond (Starling Initiatives, Oct 25, 2021) — ISBN 978-0578257181
- Journeys: Discovering God's Paths of Spiritual Formation Building to a Strong Finish (Starling Initiatives, 2024) — ISBN 9798218377076

Other known/short-form (per Goodreads):

- Cultivating a Life for God second edition (Starling Initiatives, ISBN 978-0984862184)
- Truth Quest Facilitator's Guide: The Search for Spiritual Understanding
- Stability in Mind (2012)

- Colonel Surrey's Insanity (2010) — fiction (genre/role UNKNOWN)
- Raising Leaders for the Harvest (co-authored with Robert E. Logan)
- Organic Church Planters' Greenhouse (with Paul Kaak; training manual rather than trade book)

(See [content/books.md](#) for the full bibliography with ratings and reviews.)

Biography

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/neil-cole/profile/biography.md

Biography: Neil Cole

Status: Complete (with documented open items)

Last updated: 2026-04-29

Confidence: HIGH on overall arc and verified facts; MEDIUM on early-career years and the exact start of the silence period; LOW on personal-life detail (he has chosen to keep most of it out of the public record).

A Coffee Shop, a Lifeguard, an Artist, and a Pastor Who Walked Away

Neil Cole was born and raised in Los Angeles in 1960. By his own telling, he came to faith in Jesus while studying at California State University, Long Beach, where he completed a BA in Fine Art. Before ministry — and the mark this would leave on his later work is not incidental — he was an ocean lifeguard for Los Angeles County beaches. The lifeguard frame becomes the controlling metaphor of *Search & Rescue: Becoming a Disciple Who Makes a Difference* (Baker Books, 2008): the church is not a chapel for the saved, it is a search-and-rescue operation for the drowning.

After CSULB he went east to Indiana for an M.Div. in New Testament at Grace Theological Seminary in Winona Lake, the educational center of the Fellowship of Grace Brethren Churches (now "Charis Fellowship"). He returned to Southern California and pastored a Grace Brethren congregation in Alta Loma, California, through the 1990s. By outward measure he was on the standard evangelical pastorate track.

Then in **1999** he walked away. Cole left the Alta Loma pastorate and started a different kind of church in **the smoking section of a Long Beach coffeehouse called The Coffee Tavern**. He named it **Awakening Chapel**. From that single Long Beach community he and a small group of friends developed two operational technologies that would define his career: a 2- or-3-person same-gender accountability/Scripture/prayer unit he called the **Life Transformation Group (LTG)**; and a training cycle he and Paul Kaak called the **Organic Church Planters' Greenhouse** (Story 1 and Story 2). The 1999 manual on the LTG, *Cultivating a Life for God: Multiplying Disciples Through Life Transformation Groups* (ChurchSmart Resources), was his first book. He simultaneously founded **Church Multiplication Associates (CMA)**, the umbrella that turned Awakening Chapel from a single church into a planting network. By 2003, CMA was claiming roughly four new church starts every week.

The 2005-2014 Run: Becoming One of the Faces of the Missional Conversation

In a remarkable nine-year window between **2005 and 2014**, Neil Cole became one of the half-dozen most-cited North American voices in the missional / simple-church / organic-church conversation. The trade-house run is striking:

- **2005** — Beyond Church Planting with Bob Logan (ChurchSmart). His first co-author was Robert E. Logan, executive director of CoachNet, Fuller Seminary teaching faculty, and a leading evangelical church-planting voice; Cole later names Logan as a mentor in his 2010 Christianity Today response piece.
- **2005** — Organic Church: Growing Faith Where Life Happens, with a foreword by Leonard Sweet, in the Jossey-Bass / Leadership Network Series. This is the book that put the term "organic church" into the missional vocabulary alongside Hirsch and Frost's The Shaping of Things to Come. Alan Hirsch's endorsement on the back cover calls Cole "one of the foremost thinkers and practitioners [of] organic forms of church."
- **2008** — Search & Rescue (Baker Books).
- **2009** — Organic Leadership (Baker Books / Shapevine series, with Reggie McNeal contributing) — his book on leading without hierarchy.
- **2010** — Church 3.0: Upgrades for the Future of the Church (Jossey-Bass), foreword by Francis Chan. The "next-step" book to Organic Church.
- **2010** — Public conversation with Frank Viola (joint Keith Giles interview, Beyond Evangelical). Cole and Viola overlapped audiences but disagreed on multiplication speed (Cole = rapid; Viola = mature-disciples-first).
- **2010** — Mark Galli's Christianity Today "Long Live the Organic Church" piece prompts Cole's published response on christianitytoday.com (Jan 12, 2010).
- **2011** — Journeys to Significance (Jossey-Bass) and Ordinary Hero (Baker).
- **2012** — Church Transfusion with Phil Helfer (Jossey-Bass) — how to transition a conventional church toward organic patterns.
- **2014** — The Black Swan Effect contributor alongside Hirsch, Frost, Ferguson, McClung, the Dales, and others (House2House, ed. Felicity Dale).
- **2014** — Primal Fire: Reigniting the Church with the Five Gifts of Jesus (Tyndale Momentum). His APEST book — written alongside Dezi Baker (prophetic), Ed Waken (evangelistic), Phil Helfer (shepherding), and Paul Kaak (teaching), with Cole carrying the apostolic chair.

Across this same window he was **on the Verge / Exponential / Saturate / 100Movements / DTS / Mosaix-adjacent conference circuit constantly**. Verge Network's speaker page lists him as a presenter ("What Is a Missional Community?" 2010; Exponential 2011 "On the Verge"; Verge teaching segments through 2013). Steve Addison's books cite him as a CPM/DMM peer; Curtis Sergeant credits him as a foundational voice for the IMB's church-planting strategy (the IMB adapted LTG into a tool called **CHAT**).

Co-founding 100 Movements (2015)

In **November 2015**, Will Mancini publicly announced the launch of **100 Movements**, a new non-profit consultative training organization built around six "movement competencies." The named design team was: **Alan Hirsch, Neil Cole, Dave Rhodes, Will Mancini, and Jessie Cruickshank** (Harvard-trained learning expert). Mancini's blog post explicitly calls Cole "perhaps [having] led a multiplication movement more than any single practitioner in the United States." This is the first explicit, formal, public collaboration between Hirsch and Cole — a fact that the master `network/network-map.md` currently undercounts (it carries only the mutual-endorsement edge).

This is also, almost exactly, the moment the public Cole begins to thin out.

The Silence (~2012--~2024)

In multiple 2024–2025 interviews Cole has described **a 13-year season in which God told him to stop speaking publicly in the U.S., refrain from social media, and cease blogging**. The quote KC Underground's Upside Down Kingdom surfaces from him: "I never felt like Jesus left me. Everyone else did — but He never did." His other framing, on Shifting Culture, sums up the period this way: "His whole work can be summed up in this: listen to Jesus and do what He says."

The visible evidence:

- The **Cole-Slaw blog** — active 2007 through 2017, with a posting rhythm that thins after 2013, a final cluster of posts in March–April 2016, one post on June 7, 2017, and silence after.
- **Big-house trade publishing stops at One Thing** (Thomas Nelson, Nov 2015). Tyndale, Jossey-Bass, Baker, and Thomas Nelson do not publish another Cole book between 2015 and 2026.
- **CMA Resources lapses**. The `cmaresources.org` domain at some point was lost or expired and is now serving a Sydney-lottery prediction page; the CMAResources Twitter and Facebook still nominally exist but are not actively maintained.
- The conference appearance cadence is much harder to verify in this window. He resurfaces in **November 2022** at DTS for the Missions and Evangelism Lectureship (three chapel sessions), but otherwise the catalogued public-speaking record between roughly 2016 and 2023 is thin.

What he did publish in that window came out under his own self-publishing imprint, **Starling Initiatives Publication Series**, on Amazon: *Rising Tides* (2018), *Pray* (2019/2022), *VIRAL* (2021), then *Journeys* (2024) and a *Primal Fire* reissue (2025). These books carry the same intellectual program as the earlier work but have not had the trade-house reach. He narrates the audiobooks himself.

Re-emergence (2024-2025)

By **April 2024** he returns to the guest-podcast circuit. Shifting Culture Ep. 178 is the public marker — Cole talking about Journeys and the season of silence. Then **December 2024 / January 2025**: two episodes on the reChurch Podcast (hosted by Justin and Brooke Knoop), titled "The 100K Ministry Mistake That Opened My Eyes Forever" (Ep. 13) and "The REAL Reason Church Leadership is Broken" (Ep. 14). In **August 2025** he sits down with Brian Johnson and Cory at **KC Underground's Upside Down Kingdom podcast** — a significant placement, because KC Underground is Rob Wegner's organization, which means the founder of CMA is being received as an elder voice by the next generation of microchurch operators (Wegner, Pulley, Sanders' lineage).

His current institutional anchors as of 2026:

- **Starling Initiatives** — global collective, monthly Zoom trainings, private Facebook community, online courses ("coming soon"), audiobook publication. Headquarters Long Beach.
- **Kairos Pacific University** — Professor of Church Development.
- **100 Movements** — co-founder relationship; current operational involvement UNKNOWN.

Goodreads still ranks him at **2,062 ratings, 3.99 average across 60 distinct works**, with Primal Fire as his highest-rated title (4.21).

What This Biography Is Not

It is not a biography of how a movement scaled. The CMA "thousands of churches in 50 states and 50+ nations" claim is the organization's self-report. **Independent verification is not possible from public sources.** The Internal-Mission-Board adaptation of LTG (CHAT) is the strongest external confirmation; Greenhouse cohorts at Frisco TX 2011, Virginia Mennonite Conference 2012, and others are the strongest documented training-event traces; and the citation density across other authors' books (Hirsch, Stetzer, Sweet, Sanders, Wegner, Ford, Halter, Sergeant, Addison) is the strongest reception evidence.

It is also not the biography of a celebrity-pastor brand. Cole has actively rejected that posture, both in his content (Organic Leadership is structurally an anti-hierarchy book; Primal Fire decentralizes leadership across five gifts) and in his behavior (the silence period is, in effect, a 13-year argument against the influence economy). The Movemental fit treats him accordingly — see analysis/movemental-fit.md.

Open Biographical Questions

1. **Exact dates** of the Alta Loma Grace Brethren pastorate (start year ~1989?, end 1999).
2. **Year of marriage to Dana** (~1985 inferred from "37 years married" Audible bio circa 2022).
3. **Doctorate** — DD from America Evangelical University: honorary or earned? Date unknown.

4. **Exact start date of the 13-year silence.** Working hypothesis: 2011-2012.
5. **CMA's incorporation, dissolution, or merger** — public records search would settle this.
6. **The Awakening Chapel current status** — is it still meeting, dissolved, or absorbed elsewhere?
7. **Travel and ministry pattern during the silence** — publicly, almost no record exists between 2016 and 2022; the Journeys book is the most likely place where he tells this story in his own words.

Theological Profile

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/neil-cole/profile/theology.md

Theology: Neil Cole

Status: Complete

Last updated: 2026-04-29

Confidence: HIGH on framework structure (the public corpus is large and consistent); MEDIUM on Cole's positions on contested doctrinal questions outside the ecclesiology lane; LOW on systematic theology proper (Cole rarely operates in dogmatic categories).

Christological Center

Cole's theological frame is **radically Christocentric** in a way that is closer to the Anabaptist / Mennonite stream than to the Reformed-confessional stream of his Grace Brethren origin. His most-repeated definition of the church names this directly:

"Church is not an event, a place or an organization; it is a family on mission together."
"The presence of Jesus among His people, called out as a spiritual family to pursue His mission on this planet."
([Frank Viola joint interview, 2010](#))

He distills the entire ministry program of his organization down to one sentence: **"Listen to Jesus and do what He says."** This is the foundational rule of Starling Initiatives ([starlinginitiatives.com](#)) and is repeated nearly verbatim across the Cole-Slaw blog and his recent podcast interviews.

The DNA Framework — D, N, A

Cole's most cited contribution to missional vocabulary is the **DNA of the Body of Christ**:

- **Divine Truth** (faith) — Scripture-based revelation, learned through participatory Bible engagement. He was an early adopter of what is now widely called Discovery Bible Study.
- **Nurturing Relationships** (love) — authentic family-level community and accountability.
- **Apostolic Mission** (hope) — sent-ness; outward orientation; multiplication.

Cole insists that all three must be present in every cell of the body: "all components of the DNA must be in every part of the church from the smallest unit of disciple in relation to another disciple... the components should not be supplanted, supplemented or separated"

(paraphrased from Organic Church). This is structurally parallel to Alan Hirsch's **mDNA** framework in *The Forgotten Ways* — and the parallel is mutually acknowledged in their endorsements of each other's books.

Multiplication-First Ecclesiology

The single most-quoted Cole sentence in the missional canon:

"If we cannot multiply disciples, we will never multiply leaders. If we cannot multiply leaders, we will never multiply churches. If we cannot multiply churches, we will never see a movement of God." (Organic Church, 2005, repeated in *Search & Rescue*, 2008, and *Cultivating a Life for God*, 1999)

Three theological commitments are embedded in that sequence:

1. **Disciples are the irreducible unit.** Programmatic church-growth language ("more attenders," "more giving units") is not the right level of analysis. Without multiplied disciples, every other layer is hollow.
2. **Leadership emerges, it is not appointed from outside.** Organic Leadership (2009) is a sustained argument that Christian leadership is best understood as a function that emerges naturally inside the body, not a credential certified by an institution. ("Leadership that rests on title is weak. Leadership that rests in a cause and inspires others to follow is strong." — Organic Church.)
3. **The lowest reproducible unit must already contain the whole DNA.** This is why the Life Transformation Group is two or three people: the smallest viable cell that contains all of D, N, and A.

This makes Cole's ecclesiology **actively low-bar**. Church 3.0 (2010) is upfront about this:

"I have intentionally lowered the bar of how church is done so that anyone can do it, and raised the bar of what it means to be a disciple so that not just anyone will do it." (paraphrased; cited in 9Marks review)

APEST / Five-Fold Ministry

Primal Fire: Reigniting the Church with the Five Gifts of Jesus (Tyndale Momentum, 2014) is Cole's APEST book — the apostle/prophet/evangelist/shepherd/teacher framework derived from Ephesians 4:11. The book's structural conceit is that the five gifts of Jesus are explicitly modeled by Cole and his four co-thinkers:

- **Apostle** — Neil Cole
- **Prophet** — Dezi Baker
- **Evangelist** — Ed Waken

- **Shepherd** — Phil Helfer
- **Teacher** — Paul Kaak

This is structurally parallel to (and slightly distinct from) Alan Hirsch's APEST treatment in The Permanent Revolution and 5Q. Cole and Hirsch's APEST treatments are mutually compatible, which is part of why 100 Movements (2015) was able to draw on both authors' frameworks without conflict.

Cole's posture on APEST distinctives:

- He affirms all five as ongoing offices/functions in the contemporary church (against cessationist readings).
- He treats them as **gifts of Jesus, not gifts of the Spirit** — they remain Christ's gifts to the body (Eph 4:11), not interchangeable with the Romans 12 / 1 Corinthians 12 spiritual gifts inventories.
- He frames them as **decentralizing** — they are gifts, not titles, and they emerge across the body rather than concentrating in a senior pastor.

The Black Swan Effect — Gender Hierarchy

Cole is a **named contributor** to The Black Swan Effect: A Response to Gender Hierarchy in the Church (Felicity Dale, ed., 2014), alongside Hirsch, Frost, Ferguson, McClung, and the Dales. The book argues, from inside the missional / simple-church / organic-church stream, **for women's full participation and leadership** in the body of Christ — including in apostolic, leadership, and teaching capacities. Cole's contribution to that volume is consistent with his broader anti-hierarchical posture in Organic Leadership.

Disciple-Making Movement (DMM) and Church Planting Movement (CPM) Compatibility

Cole's LTG and Greenhouse training pre-date the contemporary DMM / CPM vocabulary by nearly a decade. He is consistently cited as a **bridge** between the simple/organic-church stream and the DMM / CPM stream:

- The IMB (International Mission Board) adapted LTG into their **CHAT** discipleship tool.
- **Curtis Sergeant** ("The Only One"; former IMB strategist) treats Cole's work as foundational.
- **Steve Addison** (Pioneering Movements, The Rise and Fall of Movements) consistently includes Cole in the lineage.
- **Jim Montgomery's DAWN movement** — Michael Steele, the North American director of DAWN, recommended Organic Church.

Cole's compatibility with the DMM stream is not a footnote — it is the reason his work has had as much global reach as it has, especially through the IMB and Saddleback's PEACE Plan ecosystem (Curtis Sergeant was Saddleback's director of church planting).

Theology of Obscurity

This is the distinctive late-career addition. In Shifting Culture Ep. 178 (2024) and KC Underground's Upside Down Kingdom (2025), Cole describes a 13-year season of imposed silence — no public speaking in the U.S., no blogging, no social media. The theological grammar he uses for that season:

"You'd be amazed what people will do for Jesus that they won't do for your mission statement." (Upside Down Kingdom, KCU, Aug 2025)

"I never felt like Jesus left me. Everyone else did — but He never did." (same episode)

The cumulative argument of his late writings (Pray, VIRAL, Journeys) is that **intimacy with Christ produces fruit that platform-building cannot** — and that obscurity is a positive spiritual category, not a failure mode.

This sits in a recognizable theological lineage — Henri Nouwen, Eugene Peterson, the desert tradition — but Cole arrives at it from the inside of the high-output church-multiplication and platform-author world, which makes the witness particularly weighty. It is also the reason the Movemental fit must not be framed as "build his platform back."

Sacraments, Polity, and Doctrinal Commitments

This is where Cole is **least developed** as a public theologian, and where his Reformed critics (notably **9Marks**: Mark Dever / Jonathan Leeman) push hardest:

- **Polity / governance**: Cole's ecclesiology is loose on formal eldership, ordination, and church discipline. Organic Church dedicates a full chapter to leadership without engaging 1 Timothy 3 or Titus 1 substantively (per the 9Marks review).
- **Sacraments**: he affirms the practice of communion and baptism, but treats them as embedded in the life of the LTG and the household-church gathering rather than as sacraments administered by ordained ministers. The Reformed critique is that this risks a sacramental thinness.
- **Doctrinal definition of the church**: his "presence of Jesus among His people" definition is Christocentric and warm, but does not include the classical Protestant marks (right preaching of the gospel, right administration of the sacraments, church discipline). This is a deliberate prioritization — not an oversight — but it is what the 9Marks reviews flag.

Cole's response posture to this critique is consistently **patient and irenic**, not polemical. He has not, to public-record knowledge, written a sustained reply to 9Marks; instead, his approach has been to keep doing the work and let the body of practice speak.

Distinctive Theological Vocabulary

A non-exhaustive glossary that recurs across Cole's corpus:

- **Organic** — life-shaped, not factory-shaped; growing from a seed rather than being assembled from a kit.
- **DNA** — the irreducible D/N/A package present in every cell.
- **LTG / Life Transformation Group** — the 2-or-3-person reproducing discipleship cell.
- **Greenhouse** — the training environment that prepares organic church planters (Story 1 = "Foundations for Organic Church Planting"; Story 2 = field application).
- **Movement** — the network-of-networks effect when disciples, leaders, and churches all multiply.
- **Apostolic / Apostolic Mission** — sent-ness; the "A" in the DNA framework; also the apostolic gift in Primal Fire.
- **Cultivating** — the dominant agricultural metaphor; Cultivating a Life for God — discipleship as farming, not factory.
- **Family on mission** — the relational category Cole uses for the church.
- **Listen to Jesus and do what He says** — the irreducible operating principle of Starling Initiatives.
- **Church 1.0 / 2.0 / 3.0** — Cole's eras: 1.0 = pre-Constantinian organic church; 2.0 = post-Constantinian institutional church; 3.0 = the contemporary recovery of organic patterns.
- **From institution to organic** — the transition movement; Church Transfusion is the practical guide.

Where Cole Differs from Adjacent Voices

Voice	Point of agreement	Point of difference
Alan Hirsch	Fully aligned on mDNA / DNA, APEST, missional-incarnational, decentralization	Hirsch is more explicitly system-theory/ missiological; Cole is more practitioner/ coffee-shop-grade
Frank Viola	Christocentric, organic, anti-institutional	Viola = mature-disciples-first, slow multiplication; Cole = rapid multiplication. Public friction in 2010
Felicity & Tony Dale (House2House)	Simple/house church, women's leadership, decentralized	Dales emphasize the local home as the irreducible unit; Cole emphasizes the LTG / 2-or-3 cell as the irreducible unit
Mark Dever / 9Marks	Christ-centered preaching, costly discipleship	9Marks holds tightly to formal ecclesiology, sacraments, and Reformed polity; Cole intentionally leaves these loose
Curtis Sergeant / Steve Addison	DMM/CPM compatible, multiplication-shaped	Sergeant/Addison frame from missions strategy; Cole frames from local Long Beach pastoring outward
Robert (Bob) E. Logan	Coaching, church-planting catalysis, mentor relationship	Logan is more institutional / Fuller Seminary / coach-ed; Cole is more pioneer / artist-pastor
Brian Sanders (Underground Network)	Decentralized microchurch, apostolic, sending-shaped	Sanders organizes around city-microchurch ecosystems; Cole organizes around LTG-as-the-cell
Rob Wegner (KC Underground)	Microchurch multiplication, decentralized leadership	Wegner is downstream of Cole and explicitly receives him as an elder voice in 2025

Bottom Line

Cole is a **practitioner-theologian of decentralized discipleship multiplication**. His theological grammar is Christocentric, agricultural, low-hierarchy, and small-cell. He is doctrinally conservative (orthodox Christology, biblical authority, complementarian-and-egalitarian coexisting in his work but personally landing in the egalitarian-friendly camp via Black Swan Effect), but ecclesially low-church to the point of irritating Reformed critics. The late-career theology of obscurity is what makes him an unusually credible voice now — he has spent 13 years living the anti-platform argument his books made all along.

Vocational Profile

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/neil-cole/profile/calling-profile.md

status: empty

sidebar: vocational-profile

Voice & Editorial Identity

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/neil-cole/profile/voice-analysis.md

Voice Analysis: Neil Cole

Status: Complete

Last updated: 2026-04-29

Confidence: HIGH — voice signals are remarkably consistent across 17+ books, the Cole-Slaw blog (~250 posts), and recent 2024–2025 podcast appearances.

Tonal Fingerprint

Cole's voice is **practitioner-pastoral, agriculturally-metaphorical, and irenic**. He does not write polemics; he tells stories and then unpacks them. He does not deploy academic citation; he names people and places. He does not signal credentials; he names lifeguarding and coffeehouses.

The single strongest tonal signature: he keeps describing **the Church through living, biological, growing imagery** rather than through architectural, institutional, or programmatic imagery. Organic Church is the manifesto title; Cultivating is the discipleship verb; DNA is the framework; Search & Rescue is the lifeguard metaphor; Primal Fire is the elemental-energy metaphor; Rising Tides is the oceanographic metaphor; Awakening Chapel is the awakening metaphor. The man who studied Fine Art at CSULB is visibly still doing visual / metaphorical work in his prose.

Sentence-Level Voice Markers

Recurring rhetorical moves:

1. **The flipped expectation.** "Instead of bringing people to church so that we can then bring them to Christ, let's bring Christ to people where they live." (Organic Church) — chiasmic, accessible, immediately memorable.
2. **The escalating sequence.** "If we cannot multiply disciples, we will never multiply leaders. If we cannot multiply leaders, we will never multiply churches. If we cannot multiply churches, we will never see a movement of God." (Repeated across his corpus, in three to four sentences.) — a logical staircase that becomes near-liturgical for his readers.
3. **Subverting the impressive case.** "Attendance on Sundays does not transform lives; Jesus within their hearts is what changes people." (Organic Church) — refuses the megachurch metric.

4. **The agricultural / lifeguard reframe.** "We would do much better as leaders in the Church to learn at the feet of the farmer rather than study with the CEO of a corporation." (Organic Church) — pulls leadership out of business-school grammar.
5. **The disarmament.** "Yikes, this reads like a tombstone!" (Cole-Slaw blog about-me bio after listing his accomplishments) — self-deprecating, disinclined to inflate his own résumé.

Direct-Quote Bank (attributable; for citation use)

Eleven direct quotes with sources, suitable for use in Movemental copy, dossier excerpts, or social-media features.

1. **"Church is not an event, a place or an organization; it is a family on mission together."**
Source: [Frank Viola joint interview, Beyond Evangelical, Sept 7, 2010](#)
2. **"The presence of Jesus among His people, called out as a spiritual family to pursue His mission on this planet."**
Source: same; recurring across all Cole's books, public talks, and the Verge Network speaker page.
3. **"If we cannot multiply disciples, we will never multiply leaders. If we cannot multiply leaders, we will never multiply churches. If we cannot multiply churches, we will never see a movement of God."**
Source: Organic Church (Jossey-Bass, 2005); paraphrased on [Josh Hunt's "The Organic Pioneer of Multiplying Groups," April 9, 2025](#).
4. **"Attendance on Sundays does not transform lives; Jesus within their hearts is what changes people."**
Source: Organic Church (2005), via [Goodreads quotes](#).
5. **"Instead of bringing people to church so that we can then bring them to Christ, let's bring Christ to people where they live."**
Source: Organic Church (2005), via [Goodreads quotes](#).
6. **"We would do much better as leaders in the Church to learn at the feet of the farmer rather than study with the CEO of a corporation."**
Source: Organic Church (2005), via [Goodreads quotes](#).
7. **"Leadership that rests on title is weak. Leadership that rests in a cause and inspires others to follow is strong."**
Source: Organic Church (2005), via [Goodreads quotes](#).
8. **"The church is at its best in two's or three's — not in two or three hundreds or two or three thousands."**
Source: Organic Church (2005), via [Goodreads quotes](#).

9. **"Every church throughout history whose members were willing to surrender their lives for the sake of Christ witnessed dramatic and spontaneous growth."**

Source: Organic Church (2005), via Goodreads quotes.

10. **"You'd be amazed what people will do for Jesus that they won't do for your mission statement."**

Source: KC Underground Upside Down Kingdom podcast, August 2025, hosted by Brian Johnson and Cory (kcunderground.com/podcast/upside-down-kingdom-neil-cole).

11. **"I never felt like Jesus left me. Everyone else did — but He never did."**

Source: same KCU Upside Down Kingdom episode (Aug 2025).

Plus, from Shifting Culture Ep. 178 (April 26, 2024), summarizing his life:

1. **"His whole work can be summed up in this: listen to Jesus and do what He says."**

Source: [Shifting Culture Ep. 178](#).

Voice Across Eras

The voice has stayed remarkably stable across nearly three decades, but two adjustments are visible:

Pre-2015 voice (the trade-publishing run). Confident, system-building, evangelistic-on-behalf-of-the-organic-church-thesis. Deploys examples of CMA's growth claims, names Bob Logan as a mentor, cites Hirsch and Frost as peers. Slightly more polemic against the institutional church than the post-2015 voice. Church 3.0's subtitle ("Upgrades for the Future of the Church") is the most aggressive title he's ever used.

Post-2018 / Starling Initiatives voice. Quieter, more contemplative, more first-person. Pray, VIRAL, and Journeys are noticeably more interior than Organic Church and Church 3.0. The agricultural metaphor remains; the platform-building rhetoric does not. The 2024–2025 podcast voice is **explicitly self-correcting** — he tells the reChurch hosts he spent \$100,000 on a church plant that quickly failed, and uses that as the lesson rather than the success story.

This is not a man trying to sell you the next thing.

What Movemental Editors Should Know About Editing Cole

- **Don't sand down the agricultural metaphors.** They are the bone structure of his voice. Replacing "cultivating" with "developing" or "DNA" with "essence" loses him.
- **Don't add credential-flagging.** Cole's bio works because it doesn't lead with the doctorate. Leading with "Dr. Neil Cole" makes him sound more institutional than his theology allows.
- **Do let him be irenic.** When he disagrees with Frank Viola or with 9Marks, he disagrees softly. Don't sharpen those disagreements for him.

- **Don't ask him to retell the CMA growth-stats story.** That story belongs to a different season of his voice. The 2024–2025 voice is about silence, intimacy, listening, and obscurity.
- **Do ask him about the 13-year silence.** He has been telling that story selectively to KCU and Shifting Culture; Movemental can be a third trusted surface for that telling.
- **Do treat him as a peer of Hirsch, not a downstream of Hirsch.** They co-founded 100 Movements together; Organic Church (2005) and The Forgotten Ways (2006) are essentially contemporaneous; Hirsch's endorsement of Organic Church uses the language "one of the foremost thinkers and practitioners."
- **Don't put him on a "next-gen movement leaders" panel.** He is 66 years old in 2026 and has been doing this since 1999. Patriarch / elder framing fits.

Voice Anti-Patterns to Avoid

- **"Megachurch escapee" framing.** Cole's pre-1999 pastorate was a Grace Brethren church in Alta Loma — not a megachurch. The actual story is a regular evangelical pastor leaving a regular pastorate.
- **"Underground prophet" framing.** Cole was deeply inside the missional / Leadership Network / Jossey-Bass establishment from 2005 through 2015. He was published by Wiley, Baker, Tyndale, and Thomas Nelson. He was not on the margins; he was a featured voice.
- **"Organic vs. attractional" zero-sum framing.** Cole's Church Transfusion is explicitly written for conventional / attractional churches that want to integrate organic patterns. He is not a blow-it-all-up author.
- **"Influencer comeback" framing.** The re-emergence is real but understated. He is not building a 100K-follower platform; he is appearing on a few trusted-host podcasts and writing for Starling Initiatives. Treat the comeback at the right scale.

Bibliography

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/neil-cole/content/books.md

Books: Neil Cole

Status: Complete

Last updated: 2026-04-29

Confidence: HIGH on the major trade-house catalog and Starling Initiatives publication series; MEDIUM on minor titles, study guides, fiction, and translations (Goodreads lists 60 distinct works but counts translations and short pieces).

Master Bibliography (chronological)

1999

Cultivating a Life for God: Multiplying Disciples Through Life Transformation Groups

- Publisher: ChurchSmart Resources, Carol Stream, IL
- ISBN: 978-1889638065 (1889638064)
- Pages: 125
- Source: archive.org/details/cultivatinglifef0000cole
- Significance: His **first book**. Functions as the operating manual for the Life Transformation Group (LTG). Pre-dates Organic Church by 6 years. Re-issued by Starling Initiatives under ISBN 978-0984862184 (date unconfirmed).
- Goodreads: 164 ratings.

2005

Beyond Church Planting: Pathways for Emerging Churches (with Robert E. Logan, Holly Morgan, Julie Becker, Michelle Dodd; contributing authors Mike Perkinson and Tom Johnston)

- Publisher: ChurchSmart Resources
- ISBN: 978-1889638492
- Date: September 1, 2005
- Significance: First major co-authorship — Bob Logan was Cole's most-cited mentor (named in his 2010 CT response). Logan brought CoachNet/Fuller Seminary credibility; Cole brought organic-church practitioner content.

Organic Church: Growing Faith Where Life Happens (foreword by Leonard Sweet)

- Publisher: Jossey-Bass / Leadership Network Series
- ISBN: 978-0787981297 (078798129X)
- Date: 2005
- Significance: **The book that put "organic church" into the missional vocabulary.**

Cole's signature work. Endorsed by Alan Hirsch as "one of the foremost thinkers and practitioners [of] organic forms of church." Foreword by Leonard Sweet places it firmly inside the Leadership Network / emergent-adjacent stream of the era.

- Goodreads: 996 ratings, 3.90 avg — his single best-known book by a wide margin.

2008

Search & Rescue: Becoming a Disciple Who Makes a Difference

- Publisher: Baker Books

- ISBN: 978-0801013096 (0801013097)

- Date: April 1, 2008

- Pages: 240

- Significance: The **lifeguard-metaphor disciple-making book**. Weaves Cole's pre-ministry LA County lifeguard career with the LTG framework. Re-titled in some editions as Search and Rescue: An Urgent Call to Make and Multiply Disciples.

- Goodreads: 71 ratings.

2009

Organic Leadership: Leading Naturally Right Where You Are

- Publisher: Baker Books (later in Shapevine series)

- ISBN: 978-0801013102 (0801013100); paperback ISBN 978-0801072383

- Date: February 1, 2009

- Pages: 314

- Significance: Cole's **anti-hierarchy leadership book**. Reggie McNeal contributed (Goodreads/Christianbook list him alongside Cole). Argues leadership emerges naturally from the body rather than being credentialed in.

- Goodreads: 164 ratings, 3.83 avg.

2010

Church 3.0: Upgrades for the Future of the Church (foreword by Francis Chan)

- Publisher: Jossey-Bass / Leadership Network Series, Vol. 49

- ISBN: 978-0470529454 (0470529458)

- Date: January 26, 2010

- Pages: 304

- Significance: The **next-step book to Organic Church**. Tackles practical objections (finances, children, heresy, leader training, rituals/ordinances) that Organic Church had left aside. Highest-controversy of his trade catalog — drew the 9Marks critical review.

- Goodreads: 223 ratings, 4.00 avg.

Colonel Surrey's Insanity (fiction)

- Publisher: UNKNOWN
- Date: 2010
- Significance: Fiction outlier in his catalog. Goodreads: 2 ratings. Genre and status UNKNOWN — possibly self-published.

2011

Journeys to Significance: Charting a Leadership Course from the Life of Paul

- Publisher: Jossey-Bass / Leadership Network Series
- ISBN: 978-0470529447 (047052944X)
- Date: 2011
- Significance: Five-stage Pauline-leadership-development model. Foreshadows the later Journeys (2024) book by 13 years.
- Goodreads: 62 ratings.

Ordinary Hero: Becoming a Disciple Who Makes a Difference

- Publisher: Baker Books
- ISBN: 978-0801072772 (0801072778)
- Date: January 1, 2011
- Pages: 237
- Significance: Re-packaged disciple-making content with the lifeguard frame. Companion to Search & Rescue.
- Goodreads: 17 ratings.

2012

Church Transfusion: Changing Your Church Organically — From the Inside Out (with Phil Helfer)

- Publisher: Jossey-Bass / Leadership Network Series Book 63
- ISBN: 978-1118131282
- Date: 2012
- Significance: **Practical transition guide for conventional churches** that want to integrate organic-church patterns. Co-authored with Phil Helfer, Cole's CMA co-founder and pastor of Los Altos Grace Church. The "we're not anti-attractional, we're transitionally pro-organic" book.
- Goodreads: 37 ratings.

Stability in Mind

- Publisher: UNKNOWN — likely self-published
- Date: 2012
- Significance: Smaller / self-published title; details UNKNOWN.
- Goodreads: 2 ratings.

2014

The Black Swan Effect: A Response to Gender Hierarchy in the Church (contributor; ed. Felicity Dale; co-contributors Peggy Batcheller-Hijar, Jan Diss, Katie Driver, Dave Ferguson, Michael Frost, Alan Hirsch, Suzette Lambert, Floyd McClung, and others)

- Publisher: House2House / CreateSpace independent
- ISBN: 978-1497300187
- Date: 2014
- Significance: Cole's **chapter contribution alongside Hirsch, Frost, Ferguson, McClung, the Dales** to a coordinated egalitarian response to gender hierarchy. One of the densest single-volume snapshots of the simple/organic/missional voices of the era.

Primal Fire: Reigniting the Church with the Five Gifts of Jesus (with Dezi Baker [prophetic], Ed Waken [evangelistic], Phil Helfer [shepherding], Paul Kaak [teaching])

- Publisher: Tyndale Momentum
- ISBN: 978-1414385501
- Date: April 2014
- Significance: Cole's **APEST book**. Cole writes from the apostolic chair; the four co-thinkers each carry a different gift. Functionally Cole's parallel to Hirsch's 5Q / Permanent Revolution.
- Goodreads: 112 ratings, **4.21 avg — his highest-rated major book**.
- 2025 reissue under Starling Initiatives ISBN 9798992152609.

2015

One Thing: A Revolution to Change the World with Love

- Publisher: Thomas Nelson
- ISBN: 978-0718032869 (0718032861)
- Date: November 5, 2015
- Pages: 224
- Significance: His **last major trade-house book before the silence period**. Pivot toward more interior, love-shaped material; foreshadows the post-silence Starling Initiatives books.
- Goodreads: 22 ratings.

2018

Rising Tides: Finding a Future-Proof Faith in an Age of Exponential Change

- Publisher: Starling Initiatives Publication Series (self-published)
- ISBN: 978-0990660484 (0990660486)
- Date: June 11, 2018
- Significance: **First Starling Initiatives book**. Explicitly a self-published imprint; marks the beginning of the post-trade-house era. Subject: navigating exponential cultural and technological change.
- Goodreads: 16 ratings.

2019 / 2022

Pray: Finding Ways for Ordinary People to Connect with God in All of Life

- Publisher: Starling Initiatives
- ISBN: 978-1792352003 (179235200X)
- Original publication 2019; audiobook 2022 (narrated by Neil Cole, 3 hrs 42 min)
- Significance: Interior / contemplative book on prayer; representative of the post-silence voice.
- Goodreads: 29 ratings.

2021

VIRAL: Hearing God's Voice in a Global Pandemic... and Beyond

- Publisher: Starling Initiatives
- ISBN: 978-0578257181
- Date: October 25, 2021
- Significance: COVID-era reflection on hearing God in disruption. Continues the silence-period theology.
- Goodreads: 2 ratings.

2024

Journeys: Discovering God's Paths of Spiritual Formation Building to a Strong Finish

- Publisher: Starling Initiatives
- ISBN: 9798218377076
- Date: 2024
- Audiobook: 2024, 6 hrs 54 min, narrated by Neil Cole
- Significance: **The first major post-silence book.** Discussed at length on Shifting Culture Ep. 178 (April 2024). Re-engages the Pauline-journey frame from Journeys to Significance (2011) but from inside the lessons-of-silence era.

2025

Primal Fire (Starling Initiatives reissue)

- Publisher: Starling Initiatives Publication Series
- ISBN: 9798992152609
- Date: 2025/2026
- Audiobook: 2026, 10 hrs 14 min, narrated by Neil Cole
- Significance: Re-issue of the 2014 Tyndale Momentum book under his own imprint, presumably after Tyndale rights reverted.

Ancillary / Smaller Works

Title	Publisher	Notes
Truth Quest Facilitator's Guide: The Search for Spiritual Understanding	UNKNOWN	Companion / training guide; Goodreads 2 ratings
Raising Leaders for the Harvest (with Robert E. Logan)	UNKNOWN — likely ChurchSmart	Co-authored with Logan
Organic Church Planters' Greenhouse (with Paul Kaak)	UNKNOWN — likely CMA Resources	Training manual rather than trade book; foundation for Greenhouse Story 1 / Story 2 cohorts
Cultivating a Life for God (Starling re-issue)	Starling Initiatives	ISBN 978-0984862184
Cherishing the Bride of Christ	UNCONFIRMED	Mentioned in the dossier brief; not surfaced as a published book in this audit. May be a working title, an essay, or a forthcoming book; status UNKNOWN.

Audiobooks (Audible)

Title	Year	Narrator	Length
Organic Church	2009	Marc Cashman	8h 26m
Church 3.0	2020	Brad Smith	9h 12m
Pray	2022	Neil Cole	3h 42m
Journeys	2024	Neil Cole	6h 54m
Primal Fire (re-issue)	2026	Neil Cole	10h 14m

Source: [audible.com/author/Neil-Cole/B001JSBY7A](https://www.audible.com/author/Neil-Cole/B001JSBY7A)

Aggregate Metrics

- **Total major books:** 17 confirmed (12 trade-house + 5 Starling self-published).
- **Goodreads cumulative ratings:** 2,062 across 60 distinct works (counts translations and study guides).
- **Highest-rated:** Primal Fire (4.21 avg).
- **Most-read:** Organic Church (996 ratings).
- **Publishers:** 5 trade houses (Jossey-Bass / Wiley, Baker, Tyndale Momentum, Thomas Nelson, ChurchSmart) + 1 self-published imprint (Starling Initiatives).
- **Languages:** At least English, French (Une Bible, du café, des disciples — Publications Chrésiennes Quebec edition of Organic Church-adjacent content), and almost certainly

Spanish, Portuguese, Korean, and Mandarin (per typical Jossey-Bass / Tyndale international rights). Translation inventory is **UNKNOWN — needs research**.

Open Questions on the Bibliography

1. **"Cherishing the Bride of Christ"** — this title appears in the dossier brief but did not surface in any retailer or Goodreads search. Is it a forthcoming book, an unpublished manuscript, or a misremembered title?
2. **Translations** — full international translation inventory has not been compiled; multiple languages are likely.
3. **Greenhouse training manuals** — beyond the Story 1 / Story 2 cycle, multiple smaller curriculum documents (ReTooling Leadership series with Ed Waken; Foundations of Organic Leadership audio; Apostolic Leadership in Organic Church Movements with Ross Rohde) exist on the legacy CMA Resources archive.
4. **Editor / contributor credits on others' books** — beyond The Black Swan Effect (Dale, ed.), The Forgotten Ways (Hirsch endorser), and Underground Church (Sanders endorser), Cole's broader endorsement / foreword footprint is under-catalogued.

Frameworks

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/neil-cole/content/frameworks.md

Frameworks: Neil Cole

The signature frameworks, operating principles, and conceptual models that recur across Neil Cole's corpus. Each is grounded in his published work; see [profile/theology.md](#) and [content/books.md](#) for sources.

Life Transformation Group (LTG)

Field	Value
Introduced	1999 (Cultivating a Life for God: Multiplying Disciples Through Life Transformation Groups, ChurchSmart)
Components	Two or three people, same gender; weekly rhythm of Scripture reading, mutual confession of sin, and prayer for the lost
Function	The smallest reproducible discipleship cell — the irreducible unit that already contains the whole DNA of the church
Reception	Adapted by the International Mission Board into a tool called CHAT
Source	Cultivating a Life for God

The Life Transformation Group is Cole's foundational discipleship technology: a two-or-three-person, same-gender weekly unit of Scripture, confession, and prayer that makes disciple-making simple enough that anyone can reproduce it.

DNA — Divine Truth, Nurturing Relationships, Apostolic Mission

Field	Value
Introduced	2005 (Organic Church: Growing Faith Where Life Happens, Jossey-Bass)
Components	D ivine Truth (faith) · N urturing Relationships (love) · A postolic Mission (hope)
Rule	All three must be present in every cell of the body; they should not be supplanted, supplemented, or separated
Parallel	Structurally parallel to Alan Hirsch's mDNA in The Forgotten Ways (mutually acknowledged)
Source	Organic Church

DNA is Cole's three-strand definition of a healthy church — Divine Truth, Nurturing Relationships, and Apostolic Mission — which he insists must all be present in even the smallest unit of the body.

Organic Church

Field	Value
Introduced	2005 (Organic Church, Jossey-Bass / Leadership Network Series), foreword by Leonard Sweet
Definition	"Church is not an event, a place or an organization; it is a family on mission together"
Posture	Life-shaped rather than factory-shaped; grown from a seed rather than assembled from a kit
Multiplication chain	"If we cannot multiply disciples, we will never multiply leaders... leaders... churches... we will never see a movement of God"
Source	Organic Church

Organic Church reframes the church as a living, reproducing family on mission rather than an institution, growing decentralized faith where everyday life happens.

Church 1.0 / 2.0 / 3.0

Field	Value
Introduced	2010 (Church 3.0: Upgrades for the Future of the Church, Jossey-Bass), foreword by Francis Chan
Components	1.0 = pre-Constantinian organic church · 2.0 = post-Constantinian institutional church · 3.0 = contemporary recovery of organic patterns
Design rule	"Lowered the bar of how church is done so that anyone can do it, and raised the bar of what it means to be a disciple so that not just anyone will do it"
Source	Church 3.0

Church 3.0 frames church history as a versioning sequence and casts the present moment as an upgrade back toward the reproducible, organic patterns of the earliest church.

Organic Church Planters' Greenhouse

Field	Value
Introduced	~1999-2000 (developed at Church Multiplication Associates with Paul Kaak)
Components	Story 1 = "Foundations for Organic Church Planting" · Story 2 = field application
Function	The training environment that incubates and multiplies organic church planters
Source	Starling Initiatives

The Greenhouse is the two-story training cycle Cole built with Paul Kaak to form and reproduce organic church planters at scale.

Five Gifts of Jesus (APEST)

Field	Value
Introduced	2014 (Primal Fire: Reigniting the Church with the Five Gifts of Jesus, Tyndale Momentum)
Components	Apostle (Neil Cole) · Prophet (Dezi Baker) · Evangelist (Ed Waken) · Shepherd (Phil Helfer) · Teacher (Paul Kaak)
Distinctive	Treated as gifts of Jesus (Eph 4:11), not gifts of the Spirit; decentralizing — gifts, not titles
Parallel	Compatible with Alan Hirsch's APEST treatment (The Permanent Revolution, 5Q)
Source	<u>Primal Fire</u>

Primal Fire reads Ephesians 4's fivefold ministry as five gifts of Jesus distributed across the body — modeled by Cole and four co-thinkers, each carrying one gift — rather than concentrated in a senior pastor.

Theology of Obscurity

Field	Value
Articulated	2024–2025 (Journeys, 2024; interviews on Shifting Culture Ep. 178 and KC Underground's Upside Down Kingdom)
Components	A thirteen-year God-imposed season with no public U.S. speaking, blogging, or social media
Core claim	Intimacy with Christ produces fruit that platform-building cannot; obscurity is a positive spiritual category
Signature line	"I never felt like Jesus left me. Everyone else did — but He never did"
Source	<u>Upside Down Kingdom, KCU</u>

The theology of obscurity is Cole's late-career conviction, lived across thirteen years of chosen silence, that hidden faithfulness to Jesus bears fruit that visibility and platform never could.

Articles & Blog Posts

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/neil-cole/content/articles.md

Articles & Blog Posts: Neil Cole

Status: Complete (with documented gaps)

Last updated: 2026-04-29

Confidence: HIGH on the major-platform articles surfaced; LOW on full Cole-Slaw blog inventory and on legacy CMA Resources article archive (CMA domain lapsed; Wayback Machine fetch not exhaustively performed).

Major Platform Articles (third-party, attributed)

Christianity Today

"Long Live the Organic Church: A Response" — Neil Cole, January 12, 2010

- URL: christianitytoday.com/ct/2010/januaryweb-only/12-21.0.html

- Context: Response to Mark Galli's "Long Live Organic Church!" SoulWork column.

- Key themes: Defines success as "finding out what God wants you to do and doing it" (attributing the phrase to **Bob Logan** — Cole's named mentor); quotes Ralph Winter on risk; argues that legacy is examples and cultural shifts, not permanent institutional structures.

DTS Voice (Dallas Theological Seminary, 2022 Missions and Evangelism Lectureship)

Three articles published as part of his guest lectureship series, all dated late October / early November 2022:

1. **"The Harvest Starts with Compassion and Prayer"** — November 1, 2022 — voice.dts.edu (and chapel video link voice.dts.edu/chapel/the-harvest-starts-with-compassion-prayer-neil-cole)
2. **"Jesus' Instructions for Global Missions"** — November 3, 2022
3. **"Making Disciples Worth Multiplying"** — November 4, 2022

These are the most institutionally-credentialed pieces in his article footprint — DTS is a seminary stalwart of the conservative-evangelical academic circuit.

Frank Viola / Beyond Evangelical (joint interview)

"Missional/Organic Church — An Interview with Neil Cole and Frank Viola"

(interviewer: Keith Giles) — September 7, 2010

- URL: frankviola.org/2010/09/07/missional-organic-church-an-interview-with-neil-cole-frank-

viola/

- Significance: One of the only direct public conversations between Cole and Viola, surfacing both the agreement (Christocentric, organic, family-on-mission) and the disagreement (Cole = rapid multiplication; Viola = mature-disciples-first).

Verge Network (talks and printables)

- **"What Is a Missional Community?"** (printable) — December 29, 2010 — vergenetwork.org/2010/12/29/neil-cole-what-is-a-missional-community-printable/
- **"Why Churches Grow"** (video) — vergenetwork.org/why-churches-grow-neil-cole-video/
- **"How to Identify Good Soil That Produces Movements"** (YouTube) — youtube.com/watch?v=loMpeWbsJlk

Outreach Magazine

"The Church Needs Skunk Works" — featured Cole's perspective; cited in Google Books indexing alongside Church Transfusion content. Status: confirmed via SERP.

Faith Radio

myfaithradio.com/authors/neil-cole/ — Cole has an author/contributor index on Faith Radio; specific article inventory **UNKNOWN — needs deeper indexing**.

Charisma Magazine

Featured profile (date approximately mid-2000s) — referenced via the GraceConnect post **"Grace Brethren Pastor Neil Cole Featured in Charisma Magazine"** (graceconnect.us). The original Charisma article is the source for the "smoking section of The Coffee Tavern" Awakening Chapel founding detail. The exact issue and date are **UNKNOWN — needs research**.

Leadership Network

A Leadership Network feature ran on Cole — reported via GraceConnect's **"Neil Cole Featured by Leadership Network"** post (graceconnect.us). Direct article URL UNKNOWN.

Personal Blog: Cole-Slaw (cole-slaw.blogspot.com)

Status: Dormant since 2017-06-07.

Total posts: ~250 across 2007–2017.

Tagline: "Cole — Raw, Shredded, Mixed-up, and served cold... with a short shelf life."

About-me: "Follower of Jesus, father of three, husband of one, church planter, author and coach. Yikes, this reads like a tombstone!"

Recent / final visible posts

Date	Title
2017-06-07	More Than Meets The Eye
2016-04-11	A Kingdom Outpost: More Than A Meeting
2016-04-04	A New Trend in the Kingdom of God
2016-03-25	Finding My Cross With Another Man Upon It
2016-03-21	0.01% of the Flesh is Deadly
2016-03-17	Doing Good Can Be The Enemy Of Being Good
2016-03-15	The Invasion Of Do-It-Yourself Spirituality
2015-12	What is an Organic Church? Part One: Multiplication Organizing

Notable thematic pieces (sampled across the archive)

- **2010-01** — three-part series "**Long Live Organic Church! A Response**" (parts 1, 2, 3) — Cole's response thread to Mark Galli's CT piece.
- **2010-09** — "**Frank Viola & Neil Cole Interviewed Together By Keith Giles About Organic Church**" (Parts 1 and 2) — paired with the frankviola.org version.
- **2010-05** — "**The REAL Dirt on Organic Church**" — Cole's open response to critics.
- **2012-08** — "**What is at the heart of the organic church movement?**" — DNA framework summary.
- **2014-04** — "**Why Primal Fire?**" — companion blog post for the Tyndale book launch.
- **2015-12** — "**What is an Organic Church?**" — late-career synthesis post.

Volume estimate

A blog with ~10 years of activity averaging ~25 posts/year would yield ~250 posts; this matches the manual sample. The post-2014 cadence is visibly sparser than 2008-2013, consistent with the start of the silence period.

Legacy CMA Resources Articles (cmaresources.org)

Before the domain lapsed, CMA Resources hosted hundreds of articles, MP3s, videos, and downloadable PDFs. SERP-surfaced examples (URLs are now broken):

- "**What is a Missional Community?**" — cmaresources.org/article/what-is-a-missional-community_neil-cole
- "**Foundations of Organic Leadership**" — Cole + Phil Helfer audio set
- "**Apostolic Leadership in Organic Church Movements**" — Cole + Ross Rohde MP3

- **"Why Didn't I Take the Blue Pill? The Dark Side of Organic Church"** — Cole video; from 2007 Organic Church Movements Conference
- **"Tools and Trainings from Church Multiplication Associates"** — Constant Contact archive

The Wayback Machine remains the best single source for recovering this archive.

Forewords & Endorsements Given

(Cross-listed in [network/endorsements.md](#); included briefly here.)

- **Foreword / endorsement** of Alan Hirsch's *The Forgotten Ways* (updated edition, 2016) — "a road map for missional movements... been updated with even more insight and ten more years of learning"
- **Endorsement** of Brian Sanders' *Underground Church* (Zondervan, 2019)
- **Endorsement** of *The Forgotten Ways* original (2006) — "a seminal work that will change our thinking, our vocabulary, and hopefully our way of being the church"
- **Contributor chapter** in Felicity Dale (ed.), *The Black Swan Effect* (2014)

Aggregate Volume

- **Articles on third-party platforms:** 4 confirmed major (CT × 1, DTS Voice × 3); plus Verge talks/printables; plus Outreach/Charisma/Leadership Network features (counts UNKNOWN).
- **Personal blog posts:** ~250 (Cole-Slaw, dormant).
- **Legacy CMA Resources articles:** probably hundreds; total UNKNOWN.
- **Recent Starling Initiatives articles:** NONE catalogued in this audit; the Starling site does not visibly host a blog/journal section.

Open Questions

1. Charisma Magazine feature exact issue/date and article author?
2. Leadership Network feature URL and date?
3. Faith Radio author-index article count?
4. Outreach Magazine article URL and date?
5. Wayback Machine inventory of the legacy CMA Resources article archive — full count UNKNOWN.
6. Has Cole written for Lausanne Movement / Mission Frontiers / Christianity Today / Outreach since 2015? No post-2015 articles surfaced beyond the DTS Voice Lectureship.

Audio & Podcast

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/neil-cole/content/audio.md

Audio: Neil Cole

Status: Complete (with documented gaps)

Last updated: 2026-04-29

Confidence: HIGH on the catalogued podcast appearances and audiobooks; MEDIUM on legacy CMA Resources audio archive (now domain-lapsed).

Audiobooks (Audible)

Title	Year	Narrator	Length
Organic Church	2009	Marc Cashman	8h 26m
Church 3.0	2020	Brad Smith	9h 12m
Pray	2022	Neil Cole	3h 42m
Journeys	2024	Neil Cole	6h 54m
Primal Fire (re-issue)	2026	Neil Cole	10h 14m

Source: audible.com/author/Neil-Cole/B001JSBY7A

Pattern: Cole hands the mic to professional narrators for the trade-house era books (Cashman for Organic Church, Brad Smith for Church 3.0); he narrates his own Starling Initiatives audiobooks (Pray, Journeys, the Primal Fire re-issue). The shift is consistent with the post-silence move toward greater intimacy and personal voice.

Podcasts Hosted

None confirmed. Cole does not host his own podcast. (Some search results reference "The Neil Cole Show" / theneilcoleshow.com as a "broadcaster" tag, but the structure of that surface — a separate domain rather than an episode catalog under his name — suggests it is an external producer's branding rather than a Cole-hosted show. Status UNCLEAR; needs follow-up.)

Podcast Guest Appearances (catalogued)

1. Shifting Culture — Episode 178: "Neil Cole Returns: Journeys of Spiritual Formation"

- Date: April 26, 2024

- Host: Joshua Johnson
- URL: shiftingculturepodcast.com/episodes/episode-178-neilcole
- Topics: Journeys book; Paul's missionary journeys; institutional vs. organic; hearing God's voice; finishing well; the 13 years of silence
- Key quote: "His whole work can be summed up in this: listen to Jesus and do what He says."

2. reChurch Podcast — Episode 13: "The 100K Ministry Mistake That Opened My Eyes Forever ft. Neil Cole"

- Date: December 31, 2024
- Hosts: Justin and Brooke Knoop
- URL: rechurchpodcast.buzzsprout.com/2400837/episodes/16356101; also on Spotify, Apple Podcasts, YouTube
- Topics: A failed \$100,000 church plant; how that failure shaped his discipleship approach; Great Commission

3. reChurch Podcast — Episode 14: "The REAL Reason Church Leadership is Broken (we've been lied to) ft. Neil Cole"

- Date: January 7, 2025
- Hosts: Justin and Brooke Knoop
- URL: youtube.com/watch?v=7D7fj8tt5K8
- Topics: Hierarchy in church leadership; "Senior Pastor" not in the Bible; decentralized models

4. KC Underground — The Upside Down Kingdom: "Organic Leadership with Neil Cole"

- Date: August 2025
- Hosts: Brian Johnson and Cory (KC Underground Network)
- URL: kcunderground.com/podcast/upsidedown-kingdom-neil-cole
- Topics: Jesus-centered leadership; the 13-year season of silence; flattening hierarchies; servant leadership; relationships sustaining movements better than institutions
- Key quotes (catalogued in [profile/voice-analysis.md](#)):
- "I never felt like Jesus left me. Everyone else did — but He never did."
- "You'd be amazed what people will do for Jesus that they won't do for your mission statement."
- Significance: KCU is Rob Wegner's organization; this places Cole back inside the contemporary Underground / KCU / NewThing / 100M ecosystem as a trusted-voice elder.

5. The Church Digital Podcast — Episode 269: "Applying Church 3.0 to Digital Churches"

- Date: April 24, 2023
- Host: Jeff Reed
- Co-guest: Jason Morris (Resi Media)
- URL: be.thechurch.digital/blog/ep269-neil-cole-applying-church-30-to-digital-churches
- Topics: Digital ministry application of organic / micro-church concepts; Life Transformation Groups in digital settings

6. The More Disciples Podcast — "Neil Cole: Organic Leadership and Discipleship"

- Date: UNKNOWN — likely 2022–2024
- URL: podtail.com/podcast/the-more-disciples-podcast/neil-cole-organic-leadership-and-discipleship
- Topics: Church planting, discipleship training, organic leadership, servanthood vs. hierarchical authority

7. Dare to Multiply (formerly DMM's Frontier Missions) — Episode 60: "What in the World is APEST? Interview with Neil Cole"

- Date: UNKNOWN
- Host: Cynthia
- URL: dmmsfrontiermissions.com/episode-60-what-in-the-world-is-apest-interview-with-neil-cole
- Topics: APEST (Apostle, Prophet, Evangelist, Shepherd, Teacher) framework from Primal Fire

8. The Team Leadership Podcast — "Neil Cole on APEST and Microchurches"

- Date: ~2022
- URL: podcasts.apple.com/us/podcast/neil-cole-on-apest-and-microchurches/id1611392774
- Topics: APEST; planting a movement of microchurches

9. FUSE Life: 42 — "Exploring Church as we know it, with Neil Cole"

- Date: UNKNOWN
- URL: fuselife.libsyn.com/exploring-church-as-we-know-it-with-neil-cole

10. Special Guests — Ep. 2 / Episode 86: "Journeys to Significance — Neil Cole"

- URL: open.spotify.com/episode/2CL8hDLNNDJ24gJeJsRTIM
- Topic: Journeys to Significance (2011 book)

Legacy CMA Resources Audio

The lapsed cmaresources.org historically hosted a substantial library of Cole audio:

- **"Foundations of Organic Leadership"** — Cole + Phil Helfer
- **"Apostolic Leadership in Organic Church Movements"** — Cole + Ross Rohde MP3
- Multiple "Greenhouse" training audio sessions — UNKNOWN counts
- **"ReTooling Leadership" series** by Ed Waken (Cole's CMA colleague) — referenced 7+ articles/audio entries

Most of these URLs now 404 or redirect to the gambling-prediction site. The Wayback Machine remains the only stable access path.

SoundCloud

- URL: soundcloud.com/neil_cole
- Status: LIKELY EXISTS (per SERP); direct fetch failed (CORS or auth gate)
- Track count, follower count, latest track UNKNOWN

Aggregate Volume

- **Audiobooks:** 5 confirmed (Audible)
- **Podcast guest appearances catalogued:** 10
- **Podcast guest appearances likely existing but uncatalogued:** an additional 10–20 plausible (smaller niche shows; pre-silence appearances on Exponential / Verge / Mosaix / Catalyst / Saturate-adjacent podcasts; legacy CMA Resources internal podcast/audio)

Implications for Movemental

1. The 2024–2025 podcast cluster (Shifting Culture, reChurch, KCU) is the **right format** for Cole's voice now — long-form, host-led, listening-shaped. Movemental's own audio program should pattern after this.
2. **Re-narrating the older trade books** as Starling Initiatives audiobooks (Cole self-narrating Organic Church / Church 3.0) would be a high-value content asset; he has now established that narrating-himself is part of his post-silence rhythm.

3. **Recovering the legacy CMA Resources audio archive** (LTG explanations, Greenhouse training, the Cole + Helfer / Cole + Rohde audio sets) is an under-leveraged re-publication opportunity.

Open Questions

1. Total combined Audible listening hours across his 5 audiobooks (sales data login-gated)?
2. Pre-2015 podcast guest appearances (Exponential, Verge, Catalyst, etc.) full inventory?
3. Status of theneilcoleshow.com — is this a Cole-controlled surface or a third-party producer's branding?
4. SoundCloud track inventory and the canonical channel for legacy CMA audio that has migrated off the broken cmaresources.org domain?

Video Content

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/neil-cole/content/videos.md

Videos: Neil Cole

Status: Partial (login-gated and channel-fragmented)

Last updated: 2026-04-29

Confidence: HIGH on channel inventory; LOW on view counts, total video counts, and most-recent upload dates (login-gated; multiple channels exist with unclear canonical relationships).

Channel Inventory

Primary current channel — Starling Initiatives

- URL: youtube.com/@starlinginitiatives
- Channel ID: UCx750SRUAGYM2g9DzINxBFg
- Linked from: starlinginitiatives.com
- Subscriber count: UNKNOWN — login-gated
- Video count: UNKNOWN
- Most recent upload: UNKNOWN

Legacy personal channel — youtube.com/user/neilcole

- URL: m.youtube.com/user/neilcole/playlists
- Status: Legacy; canonical relationship to Starling Initiatives channel UNKNOWN. May be the older channel that has been superseded by [@starlinginitiatives](https://youtube.com/@starlinginitiatives), or a parallel channel.

"Neil Cole Organic Church teaching" playlist

- URL: youtube.com/playlist?list=PLBZUcLU88MIA36ClwO0-YyF8S5ucGiwuS
- Hosted on: an unconfirmed channel (the playlist surfaces in SERP but the parent channel was not directly verified)
- Significance: Curated playlist of Cole's teaching videos on organic church.

Catalogued individual videos (third-party hosting)

Title	Source	Year	Notes
"How to Identify Good Soil That Produces Movements"	Verge Network YouTube	~2010-2013	youtube.com/watch?v=loMpeWbsJlk
"Why Churches Grow"	Verge Network	~2010-2013	vergenetwork.org/why-churches-grow-neil-cole-video/
"What Is a Missional Community?" (printable + companion video)	Verge Network	December 29, 2010	vergenetwork.org/2010/12/29/neil-cole-what-is-a-missional-community-printable/
"Why Didn't I Take the Blue Pill? The Dark Side of Organic Church"	CMA Resources video (legacy)	February 2007	From the Organic Church Movements Conference; URL now broken (cmareources.org lapsed)
"Foundations of Organic Leadership" (audio set)	CMA Resources (legacy)	UNKNOWN	With Phil Helfer; URL cmareources.org/index.php?q=foundations-organic-leadership_Neil-Cole-Phil-Helfer
"Apostolic Leadership in Organic Church Movements" (MP3)	CMA Resources (legacy)	UNKNOWN	With Ross Rohde
"Organic Church Interview with Ed Waken" (video)	CMA Resources (legacy)	UNKNOWN	URL now broken
"The Truth About Church Every Christian Needs to Hear ft. Neil Cole" (#reChurch Ep. 13)	reChurch Podcast YouTube	December 31, 2024	youtube.com/watch?v=7kpHQF17I2w
"The REAL Reason Church Leadership is Broken (we've been lied to) ft. Neil Cole" (#reChurch Ep. 14)	reChurch Podcast YouTube	January 7, 2025	youtube.com/watch?v=7D7fj8tt5K8
"The 100K Ministry Mistake That Opened My Eyes Forever ft. Neil Cole"	reChurch Podcast (Buzzsprout/ Spotify/YouTube)	December 31, 2024	Same as Ep. 13 above with alternate title
"The Upside Down Kingdom — Organic Leadership with Neil Cole"	KC Underground Network	August 2025	Audio + video; kcunderground.com/podcast/upsidedown-kingdom-neil-cole
"The Harvest Starts with Compassion and Prayer" (DTS chapel)	DTS Voice	November 1, 2022	voice.dts.edu/chapel/the-harvest-starts-with-compassion-prayer-neil-cole/

Aggregate Estimate

Without login-gated metrics, conservative estimate:

- **Channels with Cole as primary uploader:** 2 (Starling Initiatives, legacy [/user/neilcole](#)); plus the "Neil Cole Organic Church teaching" playlist on a third channel.
- **Total Cole videos across all surfaces (his channels + third-party guest spots + conference recordings):** low hundreds, plausibly 200–500.
- **Combined view count:** UNKNOWN. Most prolific single video is likely Organic Church / Church 3.0 keynote talks from the 2010–2014 conference circuit.

Conference / Event Video (third-party-hosted)

- **DTS 2022 Missions and Evangelism Lectureship:** 3 chapel sessions (Nov 1, 3, 4, 2022), all available on DTS Voice and DTS YouTube.
- **Verge Conference talks** (multiple years 2010–2013): hosted on Verge Network YouTube and [vergenetwork.org](#).
- **Exponential 2011 ("On the Verge")** keynote(s): probably preserved in the Exponential YouTube archive; specific URLs UNKNOWN.
- **Organic Church Movements Conference 2007:** Cole's "Why Didn't I Take the Blue Pill? The Dark Side of Organic Church" talk; legacy CMA Resources video.
- **Simple Church Conference 2013:** appearance confirmed via SERP; specific recording UNKNOWN.

Implications for Movemental

1. **The "Neil Cole video catalog" is one of the most fragmented in the missional ecosystem.** Multiple personal channels, multiple third-party channels (KCU, Verge, DTS, Exponential, reChurch), legacy CMA recordings now broken-linked, no single curated index.
2. **A Movemental-curated playlist** consolidating Cole's strongest 10–20 talks across all surfaces (with permission from Verge / DTS / KCU / reChurch) would substantially solve discoverability.
3. **The 2007 "Dark Side of Organic Church" talk** is one of the strongest pieces of self-critical content in the missional canon and is currently essentially unfindable. Recovering it from the CMA Wayback archive and re-hosting (with permission) is a high-value low-effort move.

Open Questions

1. Canonical YouTube channel — is [@starlinginitiatives](#) the successor of [/user/neilcole](#), or do both maintain independent activity?
2. Total subscriber count across Cole's controlled channels?

3. Is the "Neil Cole Organic Church teaching" playlist hosted on Cole's own channel, on a fan/disciple's channel, or on the legacy CMA channel?
4. Is the Exponential 2011 / 2012 / 2013 keynote video archive still publicly accessible?
5. Did Cole record video sessions during the silence period (2012–2024)? Stage absences are easier to verify than total content silence.

Content Audit

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/neil-cole/content/content-audit.md

Content Audit: Neil Cole

Status: Complete
Last updated: 2026-04-29
Confidence: HIGH on framework and theme extraction across the 17+ books and ~250 blog posts; MEDIUM on the legacy CMA Resources audio archive (much of which is now URL-broken).

The Three Layers of Cole's Body of Thought

Layer 1 — The Tools (operational frameworks)

The reproducible technologies Cole has placed into the hands of practitioners.

Tool	Year introduced	Primary book	Function
Life Transformation Group (LTG)	1999	Cultivating a Life for God	2-or-3-person discipleship cell; Scripture, accountability, prayer for non-Christians
Organic Church Planters' Greenhouse	early 2000s	Beyond Church Planting (2005) + training manual with Paul Kaak	Two-stage cohort training for organic church planters (Story 1 + Story 2)
DNA framework	early 2000s	Organic Church (2005)	The irreducible D / N / A package required for any "cell" of the church to be a church
Church 1.0 / 2.0 / 3.0 typology	2010	Church 3.0	Pre-Constantinian / post-Constantinian / contemporary-recovery typology
Five-fold APEST gift treatment	2014	Primal Fire	Apostle / Prophet / Evangelist / Shepherd / Teacher framework with five named co-thinkers
Six movement competencies	2015	(100 Movements design team)	Identity Declaring + 5 others
"Listen to Jesus and do what He says"	~2018	Starling Initiatives ethos	Foundational rule of the post-silence collective

Layer 2 — The Theological Spine

Theme	Key books	Anchor language
Christocentric ecclesiology	Organic Church, Church 3.0, One Thing	"The presence of Jesus among His people"
Multiplication-first sequencing	Organic Church, Search & Rescue, Cultivating a Life for God	"If we cannot multiply disciples..."
Anti-hierarchy leadership	Organic Leadership, Church Transfusion	"Leadership that rests on title is weak"
APEST / five-fold ministry	Primal Fire	Apostle / Prophet / Evangelist / Shepherd / Teacher
Egalitarian gender posture	Black Swan Effect contribution	Female apostolic and leadership inclusion
Spiritual formation / interior life	One Thing, Pray, VIRAL, Journeys	Love-shaped, intimacy-shaped, listening-shaped
Theology of obscurity	Pray, VIRAL, Journeys, post-silence interviews	"I never felt like Jesus left me. Everyone else did."
Pauline leadership development	Journeys to Significance, Journeys (2024)	Five-stage development; finishing well

Layer 3 — The Mature Voice (post-silence, 2018-present)

The Starling Initiatives publication series narrows the focus from movement-building to interior-listening:

- Rising Tides (2018) — navigating exponential change.
- Pray (2019/2022) — connecting with God in all of life.
- VIRAL (2021) — hearing God's voice in pandemic disruption.
- Journeys (2024) — discovering God's paths of spiritual formation; lessons from 13 years of silence.
- Primal Fire (2025 reissue) — bringing the APEST book back under his own imprint.

This third layer is **distinct in tone** from the first two and reflects a man who has become something other than the rapid-multiplication CMA executive director of 2008. The contemporary audience that picks up Cole today is most likely to enter through this layer first, and would be poorly served by a "buy Organic Church first" recommendation strategy.

Recurring Metaphor System

Metaphor	Where it shows up	What it does
Agriculture / farming / cultivation	Cultivating a Life for God, Organic Church, "good soil that produces movements" Verge talk	Slow, patient, life-shaped growth
Lifeguarding / search and rescue	Search & Rescue, Ordinary Hero	Disciple-making as urgent rescue, not church-growth
DNA / biology / genetic code	Organic Church, Primal Fire, Church Transfusion	Smallest reproducible unit must contain the whole
Fire / primal / elemental	Primal Fire	Recovery of original five-fold ministry
Tides / oceanography / exponential	Rising Tides	Future-proof faith in disruptive change
Family / household	"Family on mission together"	Ecclesial relational frame
Coffeehouse / Coffee Tavern	Founding of Awakening Chapel; Cultivating a Life for God origin story	Church happens where life happens
Coleslaw (raw, shredded, mixed-up, served cold)	Cole-Slaw blog tagline	Self-deprecating metabolism of his own thinking

Recurring Counterpoints

What Cole consistently argues against:

Counter-position	Where named
Attractional / megachurch / "Sundays as the metric"	Organic Church, Church 3.0, Church Transfusion
Hierarchy-as-leadership ("Senior Pastor" framing)	Organic Leadership, reChurch Ep. 14
Permanent institutional structures as the test of legacy	Church 3.0, 2010 Christianity Today response
Slow-multiplication / mature-disciples-first	Frank Viola joint interview 2010
CEO / corporation grammar for church leadership	Organic Church, Organic Leadership
Title-based authority	Organic Church, Primal Fire
Platform-building economy	Post-silence interviews 2024-2025
Cessationist readings of APEST	Primal Fire

Themes That Have Aged Well (worth surfacing for 2026 audiences)

1. **The "lower the bar of how church is done, raise the bar of discipleship"** framing. This sentence is 16 years old and still cuts.
2. **The Life Transformation Group.** Two or three people, weekly, Scripture + accountability + prayer for non-Christians. It works as well in 2026 as it did in 1999, and is structurally identical to what contemporary microchurch and DMM practitioners are recommending.
3. **The DNA framework.** Lightweight; memorable; reproducible.
4. **Theology of obscurity.** The single most-resonant theme for the post-burnout / post-deconstruction generation.
5. **The KCU + Cole bridge.** The 2025 Upside Down Kingdom episode is doing real generational repair-work and Cole's contribution to it is fresh.

Themes That Have Aged Less Well (handle with care)

1. **CMA's "thousands of churches in 50+ nations"** statistical framing reads as 2008-era megachurch-style PR-by-numbers; Cole's 2024–2025 voice has self-corrected away from this; Movemental copy should as well.
2. **The "Constantine was the fall, organic is the recovery"** historical sweep. The 9Marks critique on this point is fair.
3. **Some of the Church 3.0 polemic against the institutional church.** The 2024–2025 voice is gentler and more inviting; lifting the older polemic into contemporary copy would mis-fit the subject.
4. **The 2010 organic-vs-attractional dichotomy.** Church Transfusion (2012) already softened this; Cole now consistently positions as integrative rather than oppositional.

Content Velocity Across Eras

Era	Books / year	Blog cadence	Public-event cadence
1999	1 (debut)	none	low
2005–2010	~1.5	high (Cole-Slaw 2007–)	very high
2011–2014	~1.5	high	very high
2015	1 (last trade-house book)	declining	high
2016–2017	0	tail-end (last post 2017-06-07)	declining
2018–2022	~0.4 (Starling self-published only)	0	very low
2023–2025	1+ (Journeys 2024; Primal Fire reissue 2025)	0	rebuilding (DTS 2022, podcast cluster 2024–2025)

The visible "shape" of his content output is a **classic productivity bell curve with a long quiet tail and a recent re-emergence** — exactly the shape Movemental's ecosystem layer is designed to serve.

Implications for Movemental

1. **The right entry book for new readers in 2026 is Primal Fire or Organic Leadership, not Organic Church.** Organic Church is the historically important book; Primal Fire and Organic Leadership are the books that age best.
2. **The right secondary entry is Journeys (2024)** because it integrates the silence narrative with the Pauline-leadership-development frame.
3. **The most reproducible single asset is the LTG card.** Modernized, mobile-friendly, cross-platform, with a 5-minute video walkthrough by Cole — it is plug-and-play discipleship technology and would be a near-universal recruiting asset.
4. **The strongest editorial framing is "patriarch elder voice" not "next-generation thought leader."** Cole's contemporary voice is wisdom-toned, not platform-toned.

Open Questions

1. Are there published Cole frameworks beyond the catalog above that this audit has missed?
2. Is the "six movement competencies" of 100 Movements documented in a stable public-facing source, or only inside the 100 Movements training cohorts?
3. Has Cole written publicly about deconstruction or post-evangelicalism — themes adjacent to the burnout-recovery audience?
4. What does Cole's Journeys (2024) book say specifically about the silence period? (The book is the most likely place where the timeline and detail are written down in Cole's own voice.)

Academic Work

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/neil-cole/content/academic.md

Academic Output: Neil Cole

Status: Complete (with documented gaps)

Last updated: 2026-04-29

Confidence: HIGH on credentials and the DTS lectureship; LOW on peer-reviewed publication record (none surfaces in this audit; Cole has not been an academic-press author).

Credentials

Institution	Degree	Field	Date	Confidence
California State University, Long Beach (CSULB)	B.A.	Fine Art	UNKNOWN — likely early-to-mid 1980s	VERIFIED (Starling Initiatives , Kairos Pacific)
Grace Theological Seminary, Winona Lake, IN	M.Div.	New Testament	UNKNOWN — likely late 1980s / early 1990s	VERIFIED
America Evangelical University, Gardena, CA	Doctor of Divinity (DD)	—	UNKNOWN	LIKELY (Kairos Pacific faculty page ; not corroborated elsewhere). Honorary vs. earned status UNKNOWN.

Faculty Appointments

- **Kairos Pacific University** — Professor of Church Development. Course load and current academic year UNKNOWN.

Lectureships and Visiting Engagements

- **Dallas Theological Seminary (DTS) — 2022 Missions and Evangelism Lectureship**
- Three chapel sessions: Nov 1, 3, and 4, 2022.
- Topics: "The Harvest Starts with Compassion and Prayer," "Jesus' Instructions for Global Missions," "Making Disciples Worth Multiplying."
- All three articles published on DTS Voice (voice.dts.edu/contributor/neil-cole).
- This is the most institutionally-credentialed academic engagement in his recent record.

Peer-Reviewed Output

None surfaced in this audit.

- No journal articles in Missiology, Journal of the Evangelical Theological Society, Themelios, Pneuma, Trinity Journal, International Journal of Frontier Missiology, Mission Frontiers, Evangelical Missions Quarterly, or Evangelical Quarterly under his name.
- No dissertation indexed in ProQuest Dissertations & Theses (consistent with an M.Div. — typically a non-thesis professional degree — and a DD that may be honorary or non-research-based).
- No academic chapters in edited volumes from IVP Academic, Baker Academic, Eerdmans, or Zondervan Academic that this audit could surface.

Citation Density (where Cole's work shows up academically)

Despite the absence of peer-reviewed publication, Cole is widely **cited** in academic and academic-adjacent missiology literature:

- **Steve Addison**, Movements That Change the World (IVP, 2011); Pioneering Movements (IVP, 2015); The Rise and Fall of Movements — Cole referenced as a foundational practitioner in the disciple-making-movements lineage.
- **Curtis Sergeant**, The Only One — extensive use of LTG and reproducible-discipleship principles directly traceable to Cole.
- **Alan Hirsch**, The Forgotten Ways (Brazos, 2006) and updated edition (2016) — mutual endorsement; Cole's framework cited in companion materials.
- **Brian Sanders**, Underground Church (Zondervan, 2019) — Cole as named endorser; Cole's organic / decentralized framework underwrites Sanders' microchurch ecosystem.
- **Lance Ford & Rob Wegner & Alan Hirsch**, The Starfish and the Spirit (Zondervan Reflective, 2021) — decentralized leadership content downstream of Cole's Organic Leadership.
- **Frank Viola**, Reimagining Church (David C. Cook, 2008) — explicit conversation partner, with frictions noted.
- **9Marks** review series — three critical reviews of Organic Church, Church 3.0, and Church Transfusion (Reformed-ecclesiology critique).
- **Doctoral dissertations** — Cole's books are routinely cited in D.Min. and Ph.D. dissertations on missional ecclesiology, simple/house church, and disciple-making movements; comprehensive index UNKNOWN.

Academic-adjacent Volumes He Contributes To

- The Black Swan Effect: A Response to Gender Hierarchy in the Church (House2House / CreateSpace, 2014; ed. Felicity Dale) — chapter contributor alongside Hirsch, Frost, Ferguson, McClung, Lambert.

- Beyond Church Planting: Pathways for Emerging Churches (ChurchSmart, 2005) — co-author with Robert E. Logan, Holly Morgan, Julie Becker, Michelle Dodd, plus Mike Perkinson and Tom Johnston.

Implications for Movemental

1. Cole's academic profile is **practitioner-on-faculty**, not researcher-publishing-in-journals. Treat him in Movemental copy as a master-craftsman / elder-practitioner, not as an academic missiologist.
2. **A formal Movemental Fellowship at Kairos Pacific University** (where Cole already has a faculty seat) would be a low-friction way to formalize his ecosystem-layer relationship with Movemental without imposing scholarship demands he has not historically pursued.
3. **The DTS Lectureship template is the right institutional shape** for a Cole-Movemental academic engagement: 3 sessions, conversational, published as articles afterward, with audio + transcript + book-quality essay.

Open Questions

1. Has Cole supervised any D.Min. or M.A. theses at Kairos Pacific or elsewhere?
2. Is the DD from America Evangelical University honorary or earned? What was the dissertation/project (if any)?
3. What other guest lectureships has Cole delivered across his career? (Fuller, Talbot, Western Seminary, Trinity Evangelical Divinity School, Bethel Seminary, Asbury all plausible; none catalogued in this audit.)
4. Is there a comprehensive academic-citation index for Cole's work? (Google Scholar lists him under multiple personas; disambiguation needed.)

Courses & Training

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/neil-cole/content/courses.md

Courses & Training Programs: Neil Cole

Status: Complete (with documented gaps)

Last updated: 2026-04-29

Confidence: HIGH on the core LTG and Greenhouse frameworks; MEDIUM on legacy CMA Resources curriculum inventory; LOW on Starling Initiatives' upcoming online courses (the website states they are "coming soon" without a launch date).

Signature Frameworks (training tools, not academic courses)

Life Transformation Group (LTG)

- **What:** 2-or-3-person same-gender accountability/Scripture/prayer cell; meets weekly; uses a one-page card with reading plan, accountability questions, and prayer for non-Christians.
- **When introduced:** Operational at Awakening Chapel from 1999; codified in Cultivating a Life for God (1999).
- **Cole's claim:** "thousands of churches in 50 states and 50+ nations" have used the LTG framework (CMA promotional copy).
- **External adoption:** IMB (International Mission Board) adapted it as **CHAT**; cited in Curtis Sergeant, Steve Addison, and DMM-stream literature; widely used in Saddleback's PEACE Plan church-planting work.
- **Materials:** a card and the Cultivating a Life for God book + facilitator guide.

Organic Church Planters' Greenhouse

- **What:** Two-stage cohort training for organic church planters.
- **Story 1** — "Foundations for Organic Church Planting" (initial cohort weekend / multi-session intensive): Foundations, Cultivating the Soil of People's Hearts, Sowing the Kingdom Seed, Growing the Life of the Kingdom.
- **Story 2** — Field-application stage; ongoing coaching and church-multiplication mechanics.
- **Co-author / co-architect:** **Paul Kaak** (Cole's CMA partner; brought into the framework as the "Teaching" gift in Primal Fire).
- **Documented cohorts:**
 - **Frisco, TX (January 2011)** — ~75 participants; trainers Cole + **Ed Waken** (Phoenix/LA-based CMA leader).
 - **Virginia Mennonite Conference (September 2012)** — Greenhouse training session.

- Multiple Long Beach / Southern California cohorts across the 2000s and 2010s.
- **Status:** dormant under CMA Resources branding (domain lapsed); unclear whether revived under Starling Initiatives.

ReTooling Leadership Series

- A multi-article CMA Resources curriculum on leadership, primarily authored by **Ed Waken** (Cole's CMA colleague).
- Confirmed entries on legacy CMA Resources: ReTooling Leadership 3, 5, 7 (and presumably 1, 2, 4, 6).
- Status: dormant under the lapsed domain.

Foundations of Organic Leadership

- Audio set authored by **Neil Cole + Phil Helfer**; legacy CMA Resources URL cmareources.org/index.php?q=foundations-organic-leadership_Neil-Cole-Phil-Helfer.
- Status: dormant.

Apostolic Leadership in Organic Church Movements

- MP3 set authored by **Neil Cole + Ross Rohde**; legacy CMA Resources URL.
- Status: dormant.

Current Programs (Starling Initiatives, 2026)

Per starlinginitiatives.com:

- **Monthly live Zoom training sessions** — cadence and content topic UNKNOWN; presumably tied to the Starling community membership.
- **Mentorship from global leaders** — described in the "what we offer" section; specific mentors UNNAMED.
- **Regional meetups** — described as "coming soon" / extended platform.
- **On-site training for launching micro-communities** — bookable via the Starling site; format and pricing UNKNOWN.
- **Online courses** — described as "coming soon"; no specific course slated.

Compared with the legacy CMA Resources catalog, the Starling Initiatives training stack is **dramatically smaller** — consistent with the post-silence theology of obscurity and the small, quiet operational footprint.

Academic Teaching (separate from the training catalog)

Kairos Pacific University

- Role: **Professor of Church Development**
- URL: kairos.aeu.edu/team/neil-cole
- Specific courses taught, course catalog URL, and credit-hour load: **UNKNOWN — needs research**. Kairos Pacific University is a small, accredited graduate seminary in the Korean-American academic tradition (parent to America Evangelical University, where his DD was awarded).

DTS 2022 Missions and Evangelism Lectureship

- Three chapel sessions delivered (Nov 1, 3, 4, 2022) — see [content/articles.md](#).
- Not a "course" in the credit-bearing sense; a guest-lectureship series.

Other adjunct / guest-teaching engagements

- UNKNOWN — needs research. Cole's Organic Leadership would be a plausible course adoption at Fuller / Trinity / Asbury / Talbot / Western Seminary; specific syllabus inclusions are not catalogued in this audit.

External Adoption of Cole's Frameworks (third-party courses)

- **IMB (International Mission Board)** — LTG adapted as CHAT; trained globally.
- **Saddleback Church / PEACE Plan** — Curtis Sergeant adopted Cole's framework into Saddleback's church-planting strategy.
- **Disciple Making Movements (DMM) practitioners** — broad downstream adoption; cited in Steve Addison's books, Curtis Sergeant's The Only One, and the broader DMM training literature.
- **Verge Network curriculum** — Cole's "What Is a Missional Community?" printable is a Verge teaching asset.
- **House2House (Tony & Felicity Dale)** — Cole featured in the House2House Video Training Series.

Implications for Movemental

1. **The LTG card is one of the most reproducible discipleship tools in evangelical history** and is currently distributed via a dormant domain. A Movemental-hosted, modernized LTG kit (card + facilitator guide + audio walkthrough) would be a near-universal recruiting and discipleship asset.

2. **Greenhouse Story 1 / Story 2 deserves modern productization.** Recast as a 4-6-week cohort with Cole as anchor teacher and a few alumni co-teachers (Phil Helfer, Paul Kaak, Ed Waken — all still operationally connected) it would compete directly with Exponential's microchurch tracks and KC Underground's "Find Your Place" 4-session journey.
3. **A Starling Initiatives x Movemental online course bundle** is a natural co-pub opportunity — Starling does not have the platform infrastructure to launch online courses well; Movemental does.

Open Questions

1. Full Kairos Pacific University course list under Cole's name?
2. Greenhouse total alumni count across all cohorts 1999-2018?
3. Has any Greenhouse cohort run since 2018?
4. Does the Starling Initiatives "online courses coming soon" have a launch date?
5. What other third-party seminaries or training programs include Cole's books in their syllabus?

Organizations & Affiliations

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/neil-cole/network/organizations.md

Organizations: Neil Cole

Status: Complete

Last updated: 2026-04-29

Confidence: HIGH on the major affiliations; MEDIUM on current-status detail (CMA's exact legal status and the structure of Starling Initiatives are not fully public).

Founded / Co-founded

Awakening Chapel (1999)

- **Type:** Local church / first organic church plant
- **Location:** Long Beach, CA — launched in the smoking section of "The Coffee Tavern" (TCT)
- **Status:** Founding congregation of the Awakening Chapels network within CMA. Current operational status of any Awakening Chapel branch is UNKNOWN — no recent updates surfaced.
- **Significance:** The proof-of-concept that became CMA's flagship case study. Multiple "Awakening Chapel" plants spawned across Southern California through the early 2000s.

Church Multiplication Associates (CMA / CMAResources.org) — late 1990s

- **Type:** Non-profit church planting / training organization (501(c)(3))
- **Headquarters:** Signal Hill, CA
- **Founded:** Late 1990s (CMA's promotional copy says "the late 1990s," coterminous with the Awakening Chapel launch in 1999)
- **Founders / Co-founders:** Neil Cole, **Phil Helfer** (pastor of Los Altos Grace Church and Cole's primary co-founder); **Paul Kaak** also early-team
- **Founding role:** Founder & Executive Director (Cole)
- **Self-reported reach:** "Thousands of churches in fifty states and more than fifty nations" within ~20 years (per multiple Cole bios)
- **Key infrastructure:**
 - LTG (Life Transformation Group) framework — 1999
 - Greenhouse training cycles — Story 1 + Story 2
 - CMA Resources website (cmaresources.org) — historically the central content hub
 - "Greenhouse Happenings" event calendar

- ReTooling Leadership content series (Ed Waken)
- Multi-author training audio (Cole + Helfer; Cole + Rohde; Cole + Waken)
- **Current status: Effectively dormant.** The cmaresources.org domain has lapsed and now serves a Sydney-lottery prediction page (i.e., gambling-prediction parked content). The @CMAResources Twitter and Facebook page still nominally exist but recent posting cadence UNCONFIRMED. No formal dissolution announcement has been made publicly that this audit could surface.

Starling Initiatives (~2018)

- **Type:** Global collective + self-publishing imprint
- **URL:** starlinginitiatives.com
- **Mission (per about page):** "A global collective of Christ-followers seeking to build deeper relationships" with the foundational principle "listen to Jesus and do what He says"
- **Founded:** ~2018 (first Starling Initiatives Publication Series book — Rising Tides — released June 2018)
- **Cole's role:** Founder
- **Programs:** Private Facebook community group; monthly live Zoom training; mentorship from "global leaders" (unnamed); regional meetups (coming soon); on-site training; online courses (coming soon); books and audiobooks
- **Operational footprint:** Small and quiet, by design. No board, team page, or 501(c)(3) status visibly listed.
- **Significance:** Cole's **current** institutional anchor; a deliberately small, post-silence operation rather than a CMA scale-out.

Co-founded

100 Movements (2015)

- **Type:** Non-profit consultative training organization
- **URL:** 100movements.org
- **Co-founders / Design Team:** Alan Hirsch, Neil Cole, Dave Rhodes, Will Mancini, Jessie Cruickshank (Will Mancini blog post, Nov 28, 2015)
- **Cole's role:** Design team member; specifically called out by Mancini as "perhaps [having] led a multiplication movement more than any single practitioner in the United States."
- **Initial product:** Six "movement competencies"; first cohort program "Leap Year" launched spring 2016; first competency was "Identity Declaring."
- **Cole's current operational involvement:** UNKNOWN. The 100 Movements / Movement Leaders Collective public-facing pages do not visibly list Cole as ongoing leadership; the collaboration may be original-design only.

Movement Leaders Collective (MLC)

- **Type:** 501(c)(3) (per ProPublica Nonprofit Explorer)
- **URL:** movementleaderscollective.com
- **Cole's role:** Indirect — through 100 Movements co-founding. Not a current named MLC leader as of 2026.

Pastoral / Denominational Affiliations

Grace Brethren Church (Alta Loma, CA) — ~1989-1999

- **Type:** Local-church pastorate
- **Denomination:** Fellowship of Grace Brethren Churches (now "Charis Fellowship")
- **Cole's role:** Pastor
- **Status:** Cole left the pastorate in 1999 to launch Awakening Chapel.
- **Source:** GraceConnect / Charis Fellowship references; Charisma Magazine feature.

Charis Fellowship (Fellowship of Grace Brethren Churches)

- **Type:** Denomination
- **URL:** charisfellowship.com
- **Cole's relationship:** Originating denomination; M.Div. from the Grace Brethren seminary (Grace Theological Seminary, Winona Lake, IN). He has been featured by GraceConnect / Charis Fellowship publications multiple times.

Academic Affiliations

Kairos Pacific University

- **Type:** Graduate seminary (Korean-American academic tradition; affiliate of America Evangelical University in Gardena, CA)
- **Cole's role:** Professor of Church Development
- **URL:** kairos.aeu.edu/team/neil-cole

America Evangelical University (Gardena, CA)

- **Cole's relationship:** Alumnus (Doctor of Divinity)

Grace Theological Seminary (Winona Lake, IN)

- **Cole's relationship:** Alumnus (M.Div., New Testament)

California State University, Long Beach

- **Cole's relationship:** Alumnus (B.A., Fine Art); also the campus where he came to faith.

Dallas Theological Seminary (DTS)

- **Cole's relationship:** 2022 Missions and Evangelism Lectureship guest lecturer; DTS Voice contributor.

Publishing Partnerships

Publisher	Books	Era
Jossey-Bass / Wiley (Leadership Network Series)	Organic Church (2005), Church 3.0 (2010), Journeys to Significance (2011), Church Transfusion (2012)	2005–2012
Baker Books	Search & Rescue (2008), Organic Leadership (2009; Shapevine series), Ordinary Hero (2011)	2008–2011
Tyndale Momentum	Primal Fire (2014)	2014
Thomas Nelson	One Thing (2015)	2015
ChurchSmart Resources	Cultivating a Life for God (1999), Beyond Church Planting (2005, with Logan)	1999–2005
House2House / CreateSpace	The Black Swan Effect (2014, contributor)	2014
Starling Initiatives Publication Series (self-published)	Rising Tides (2018), Pray (2019/2022), VIRAL (2021), Journeys (2024), Primal Fire re-issue (2025)	2018–present

Conference Networks

- **Verge Network** — speaker (talks 2010–2013); listed at vergenetwork.org/speakers/neil-cole.
- **Exponential** — speaker at "Exponential 2011: On the Verge"; ongoing relationship (specific years post-2011 UNKNOWN).
- **Saturate / Soma** — adjacent (Cole + Vanderstelt overlap on Verge speaker rosters; specific Saturate appearances UNKNOWN).
- **Mosaix Global Network** — adjacent (multi-ethnic church-planting circuit; specific Cole appearances UNKNOWN).
- **Catalyst** — adjacent (specific Cole appearances UNKNOWN).
- **Simple Church Conference 2013** — speaker.
- **Organic Church Movements Conference 2007** — speaker ("Why Didn't I Take the Blue Pill? The Dark Side of Organic Church").
- **Frisco TX Greenhouse 2011, Virginia Mennonite Conference Greenhouse 2012** — trainer.

- **DTS 2022 Missions and Evangelism Lectureship** — guest lecturer.
- **KC Underground** — guest podcast 2025; speaker history at KCU events UNKNOWN.

Adjacent / Affiliated Organizations

- **House2House** — Tony & Felicity Dale's simple/house-church organization. Cole featured in their video training series; co-contributor with Felicity to Black Swan Effect.
- **CoachNet International** — Bob Logan's coaching organization; Cole's mentor relationship with Logan dates back to Beyond Church Planting (2005) and is named in his 2010 CT response.
- **Forge Mission Training Network** — adjacent via Hirsch / Frost / 100 Movements. Cole is **not** Forge faculty per the public Forge America page, but is a known peer.
- **NewThing Network** — adjacent via Dave Ferguson (named co-contributor with Cole on Black Swan Effect).
- **Underground Network** — adjacent via Brian Sanders (Cole was a named endorser of Underground Church 2019).
- **KC Underground** — adjacent via Rob Wegner (KCU hosted Cole on Upside Down Kingdom 2025).
- **DAWN Ministries / Saturation Church Planting** — adjacent via Michael Steele (former North American director); Steele was an early Organic Church recommender.
- **IMB (International Mission Board)** — adjacent via the LTG → CHAT adaptation.
- **Saddleback Church / PEACE Plan** — adjacent via Curtis Sergeant.
- **Charis Fellowship / GraceConnect** — original denominational tribe.

Org Chart Summary

Pre-1999 → Grace Brethren Church (Alta Loma) — Pastor
 1999 → Awakening Chapel (Long Beach) — Founder
 1999 → Church Multiplication Associates (CMA / CMAResources.org) — Founder, Executive Director
 2015 → 100 Movements — Co-founder (with Hirsch, Rhodes, Mancini, Cruickshank)
 ~2018 → Starling Initiatives — Founder
 Current → Kairos Pacific University — Professor of Church Development
 Current → DTS Voice — Contributor (lectureship)

Open Questions

1. Is CMA legally still a registered 501(c)(3) in California, or has it been dissolved?
2. Who else (besides Cole) is on the Starling Initiatives team or board?
3. Is Cole still operationally active in 100 Movements / MLC as of 2026, or was his role primarily original design?

4. Are any Awakening Chapel branches still meeting?
5. What is the formal relationship between Kairos Pacific University and America Evangelical University?

Audience & Reach

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/neil-cole/analysis/audience-analysis.md

Audience Analysis: Neil Cole

Status: Complete

Last updated: 2026-04-29

Confidence: HIGH on the structural composition of his audience; LOW on precise volumetrics (no email list, no central platform, no public analytics).

Audience Segments

Cole's audience splits into roughly five overlapping segments. Each segment relates to him through a different surface, has different intensity of engagement, and would respond to different Movemental on-ramps.

1. The "Organic Church" missional generation (2005-2014 trade-book readers)

- **Profile:** Pastors, church planters, missional / emerging-church-era practitioners who bought Organic Church, Church 3.0, and Primal Fire during the trade-publishing run.
- **Approximate count:** 50,000-150,000 lifetime book purchasers across major titles (extrapolating from cumulative Goodreads ratings of 2,062 — typical Goodreads-to-purchase ratio is 1:50 to 1:100).
- **Engagement intensity:** Variable; many will have read 1-2 books and not engaged further. A core ~5,000-10,000 are repeat-buyers across multiple Cole titles.
- **Where they live online:** Goodreads, Amazon, Audible, library systems; some on legacy missional blogs and Christianity Today reader bases.
- **Movemental on-ramp:** A Cole archive / hub + curated newsletter; the silence-story essay as lead magnet.

2. The CMA / Greenhouse / LTG practitioners (1999-2018)

- **Profile:** Pastors, lay leaders, church planters, and missionaries who were trained at a Greenhouse cohort, learned the LTG framework, or used CMA Resources curriculum.
- **Approximate count:** Cole's promotional copy claims "thousands of churches in 50 states and 50+ nations." Practitioners trained: low thousands; lay-level LTG users: tens of thousands.
- **Engagement intensity:** Deep — these are people who have run his discipleship technology in their own ministries.

- **Where they live online:** Largely offline / inside their own churches; some on the @CMAResources Facebook page, the dormant Cole-Slaw blog, and the legacy CMA Resources contact lists.
- **Movemental on-ramp:** A modernized LTG kit; a Greenhouse cohort relaunch; a "where are they now" alumni network feature.

3. The DMM / CPM / IMB ecosystem (global, 2005-present)

- **Profile:** Disciple-Making Movement and Church-Planting Movement practitioners — IMB strategists, Saddleback PEACE Plan operators, missionaries in CPM-receptive contexts.
- **Approximate count:** Tens of thousands globally — much larger than the North American direct readership; significantly under-counted in any English-language analytics.
- **Engagement intensity:** Functionally permanent — Cole's LTG framework is operationalized as the IMB's CHAT and used in field training.
- **Where they live online:** Steve Addison's Movements Lab, Curtis Sergeant's Metacamp, Saddleback PEACE Plan training, IMB internal training portals, Mission Frontiers magazine.
- **Movemental on-ramp:** A Cole-anchored DMM/CPM/microchurch elder-voice video series; partnership with Steve Addison and Curtis Sergeant.

4. The simple / house / underground / microchurch generation (2015-present)

- **Profile:** Brian Sanders' Underground Network (Tampa); Rob Wegner's KC Underground; Frank Viola's house-church readers; Felicity & Tony Dale's House2House network; the broader contemporary microchurch movement (Lucas Pulley, Tomy Wilkerson, Stacy Gaskins, Joel Repic, Brian Johnson).
- **Approximate count:** Low thousands of practitioners; tens of thousands of adjacent listeners through the Underground / KCU / Tampa Underground podcast ecosystems.
- **Engagement intensity:** Cole is treated as the **patriarch elder** of this generation. KCU's 2025 Upside Down Kingdom episode is the clearest signal — they don't introduce Cole; they receive him.
- **Where they live online:** Tampa Underground, KC Underground, Underground Network sites; Microchurches Podcast; Exponential Microchurch Next; the wider 100Movements / Movement Leaders Collective orbit.
- **Movemental on-ramp:** A Cole + Wegner + Sanders elder-and-inheritors podcast series; a 100 Movements 10-year reunion.

5. The 100 Movements / Hirsch / MLC / 5Q ecosystem

- **Profile:** Alan Hirsch's audience (Forge / 100 Movements / MLC / 5Q / Future Travelers); Will Mancini's Auxano audience; Dave Rhodes' coaching-and-training audience; Jessie Cruickshank's neuroscience-of-leadership audience.

- **Approximate count:** 50,000–200,000 missional readers and trainees globally.
- **Engagement intensity:** Cole is treated as a peer of Hirsch (mutual endorsement, co-design of 100 Movements). His direct visibility inside this audience has thinned during the silence period but the structural relationship remains intact.
- **Movemental on-ramp:** A Cole + Hirsch dual-author panel; positioning Cole alongside Hirsch as paired patriarch voices of the missional generation.

6. The Charis Fellowship (Grace Brethren) home tribe

- **Profile:** Cole's denominational home; Grace Theological Seminary alumni; Grace Brethren / Charis Fellowship pastors.
- **Approximate count:** Small (the denomination is small) but high-fidelity.
- **Engagement intensity:** GraceConnect has tracked Cole's career milestones with consistent attention since the early 2000s.
- **Movemental on-ramp:** A Charis Fellowship × Movemental partnership feature; recovery of the early-career biographical narrative.

7. The DTS / Kairos Pacific / academic-evangelical audience

- **Profile:** Seminary students, faculty, and graduates engaging Cole's work in coursework or lectureships.
- **Approximate count:** Small but institutionally placed.
- **Movemental on-ramp:** A Cole faculty profile; a Movemental Fellowship at Kairos Pacific or a DTS-style three-session lectureship.

Demographic Inference

Without access to first-party analytics, demographic inference is necessarily speculative. Working assumptions based on the segment composition above:

- **Age:** Cole's primary audience has aged with him. The 2005–2014 trade-book readers are now 50–75; the 2015+ microchurch generation is 30–55. There is a clear "missing middle" generation (2016–2022) that has neither been recruited nor retained.
- **Geography:** Heavily North American (US Southern California / Sun Belt / Bible Belt) for the trade-book audience; significantly more globally distributed for the DMM/CPM/IMB segment.
- **Gender:** Likely majority male given the typical evangelical pastor / church-planter demographic, but Cole's Black Swan Effect contribution and his egalitarian-friendly posture have probably skewed his audience more egalitarian than the median evangelical-pastor catalog.

- **Theological:** Broadly conservative-evangelical; Pentecostal-charismatic friendly (per Charisma Magazine reach); Reformed-skeptical (9Marks pushback); ecumenical-leaning on practical ecclesiology.

Volumetric Ceiling

A reasonable estimate for the total addressable Cole audience (people who would recognize his name and have engaged with his work or framework directly or indirectly):

- **Strong-engagement core:** 5,000–15,000 (CMA / Greenhouse / LTG practitioners + repeat-buyer core)
- **Medium-engagement:** 50,000–200,000 (one-time book buyers, podcast listeners, conference attenders, downstream framework adopters via DMM / Underground / KCU / 100M)
- **Weak-engagement / aware-of-name:** 500,000+ (anyone who has read about organic church in the missional canon since 2005)

If Movemental successfully consolidated Cole's surface, **a directly subscribed audience of 5,000–25,000 within 12 months is a defensible target.** That is small relative to a contemporary platform-author benchmark; it is large relative to what Cole's current Starling Initiatives footprint shows; and it is precisely the right size for the "trusted-voice elder, episodic feature" frame that fits him.

Audience Pain Points (from podcast and interview content)

Themes Cole's listeners and readers consistently surface:

1. **Disillusionment with attractional / megachurch / institutional models.**
2. **Hunger for reproducible, simple, low-overhead discipleship tools** (where LTG fits).
3. **Frustration with hierarchical church leadership** (where Organic Leadership and Primal Fire fit).
4. **Desire to understand how movements actually scale** without becoming dependent on celebrity pastors or programmed church-growth (where Organic Church, Church Transfusion, and 100 Movements competencies fit).
5. **Burnout** — a substantial proportion of Cole's contemporary listeners are post-burnout, post-disillusionment, post-deconstruction practitioners; the silence story is unusually well-suited to that audience.

Implications for Movemental

1. Cole's audience is **structurally aligned with Movemental's canonical doctrine** — the "trusted-voice / ecosystem-layer" framing is correct here.
2. The strongest single audience-bridging move is **a Cole + Wegner + Sanders multi-voice elder-and-inheritors series**, which would unify segments 4, 5, and 6 above.

3. The **silence story** is the lead asset because it speaks directly to the burnout pain-point that runs across most audience segments.
4. **Do not over-target the strong-engagement core.** They are already reading him. Movemental's value-add is making him newly visible to the medium- and weak-engagement segments who built on top of his work without ever having a guided introduction to it.

Open Questions

1. Total cumulative Audible listening hours (sales data login-gated)?
2. Greenhouse alumni network — how to reach them when CMA Resources is dormant and CMA's contact lists are not visible?
3. International audience — what is the Korean / Brazilian Portuguese / Mandarin / Spanish reach of Cole's translated work?
4. Generational breakdown — what percentage of contemporary Underground / microchurch leaders cite Cole as a foundational influence vs. cite Hirsch / Sanders / Wegner / Ford?

Websites

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/neil-cole/digital-presence/websites.md

Websites: Neil Cole

Status: Complete

Last updated: 2026-04-29

Confidence: HIGH on inventory; LOW on most-recent-update dates and traffic (analytics login-gated).

Owned / Authored Surfaces

Domain	Status	Role	Notes
starlinginitiatives.com	Active	Current organizational home (since ~2018)	Functions as Cole's de-facto author site — about page features his bio; private FB community link; monthly Zoom signups; "online courses coming soon"; Primal Fire audiobook promotion. Footprint is small.
cmaresources.org	Lapsed / hijacked	Was the primary CMA / Awakening Chapel content hub from ~2000 through ~2018; held thousands of articles, MP3s, videos, and the "Greenhouse Happenings" calendar	The domain now serves a Sydney lottery-prediction page ("Syair SDY"). Archive.org's Wayback Machine still preserves the legacy CMA content (referenced by URL patterns like /node/458 for the Awakening Chapel Long Beach page and /foundations-organic-leadership_Neil-Cole-Phil-Helfer).
cole-slaw.blogspot.com	Dormant since June 7, 2017	Personal blog 2007–2017	~250 posts; posting cadence thinned after 2013, terminated 2017. About-me reads "Follower of Jesus, father of three, husband of one, church planter, author and coach. Yikes, this reads like a tombstone!"
theneilcoleshow.com	Active or stub — status UNCLEAR	Listed in SERP under heading "BROADCASTER - neil cole"	Not directly verified in this audit; potentially an external producer's site rather than Cole's own. Needs follow-up.
neilcole.com / neilcole.org	UNKNOWN	A canonical author site under his own name has not been surfaced in this research	Likely does not exist as a maintained surface .

Indirect / Affiliated Surfaces

Surface	Status	Role
kairos.aeu.edu/team/neil-cole	Active	Faculty profile at Kairos Pacific University ("Professor of Church Development")
voice.dts.edu/contributor/neil-cole	Active	DTS Voice contributor page; hosts 3 articles from the 2022 Missions and Evangelism Lectureship
vergenetwork.org/speakers/neil-cole/	Active (legacy)	Verge Network speaker profile; hosts older talks ("What Is a Missional Community?", "Why Churches Grow")
100movements.org	Active	Sister organization Cole co-founded (2015); primary Movement Leaders Collective branding
movementleaderscollective.com	Active	Sister organization to 100Movements
churchplanting.com/team/neil-cole/	Active (legacy)	Older author bio / profile page
simplechurchalliance.com/tag/neil-cole/	Active	Aggregator tag page collecting Cole references
frankviola.org	Active (third-party)	Multiple Frank Viola posts feature joint interviews with Cole
christianitytoday.com/ct/2010/januaryweb-only/12-21.0.html	Active	His 2010 "Long Live the Organic Church: A Response" article
baker.com (Baker Publishing Group)	Active	Hosts Organic Church, Organic Leadership, Search & Rescue, Ordinary Hero author pages
tyndale.com	Active (legacy)	Primal Fire (2014) original author page
wiley.com (Jossey-Bass parent)	Active	Hosts Church Transfusion, Church 3.0, Journeys to Significance, Organic Church in the Leadership Network Series

Notes on Domain Hygiene

The cmareources.org situation is the single most painful piece of digital fragmentation in Cole's footprint. Because the original domain has been allowed to lapse (or has been domain-hijacked), **every legacy citation across the missional internet** — book footnotes, blog references, conference handouts from 2002–2018 — now either 404s or, worse, resolves to a Sydney-lottery prediction site. The Wayback Machine snapshots remain the only stable surface for the legacy CMA Resources archive.

A Movemental-hosted "Cole Hub" that consolidates his canonical content (with explicit permissions from Cole) would substantially repair this damage. It would also be the single highest-leverage curatorial move available for an author with his depth-to-fragmentation ratio.

Per-Domain Status Detail

`starlinginitiatives.com`

- **Active**, low-traffic, low-frequency-posting.
- Architecture: minimal (about/shop/contact/community).
- Books available: Primal Fire (audiobook), Rising Tides, Pray, VIRAL, Journeys.
- Linked off-site: YouTube `@starlinginitiatives` (UCx750SRUAGYM2g9DzINxBFg), private Facebook community group.
- No newsletter signup directly visible (open question).
- No public blog / journal section.

`cmareources.org`

- Status: **lapsed; serving non-CMA content** as of this audit.
- Wayback Machine archive is the last reliable historical surface.
- The CMAResources Twitter (`@CMAResources`) and Facebook page ("Church Multiplication Associates // CMA Resources.org | Signal Hill CA") still nominally exist but recent activity unverified.

`cole-slaw.blogspot.com`

- Status: **dormant since 2017-06-07**.
- Archive: ~250 posts from 2007 to 2017.
- Subdomain title and tagline: "Cole-Slaw: Cole — Raw, Shredded, Mixed-up, and served cold... with a short shelf life."
- About box: "Follower of Jesus, father of three, husband of one, church planter, author and coach. Yikes, this reads like a tombstone!"
- Recent posts (last 10 visible):
 1. "More Than Meets The Eye" (June 7, 2017)
 2. "A Kingdom Outpost: More Than A Meeting" (April 11, 2016)
 3. "A New Trend in the Kingdom of God" (April 4, 2016)
 4. "Finding My Cross With Another Man Upon It" (March 25, 2016)
 5. "0.01% of the Flesh is Deadly" (March 21, 2016)
 6. "Doing Good Can Be The Enemy Of Being Good" (March 17, 2016)
 7. "The Invasion Of Do-It-Yourself Spirituality" (March 15, 2016)
 8. (Posts continue into 2015 and earlier)

The 2007 → 2017 archive is one of the largest extant primary sources of Cole's mid-career thinking, and Movemental should consider whether to negotiate permissions to mirror or curate it.

`theneilcoleshow.com`

- SERP indicates this exists ("BROADCASTER - neil cole") but the audit did not directly fetch the page.
- May be an external producer's brand or a podcast aggregator. **Needs verification.**

Open Questions

1. Is there a `neilcole.com` or `neilrcole.com` registered to him personally that simply isn't surfacing?
2. What is the current legal owner of the `cmareources.org` domain? The hijacked-content state suggests an expired registration.
3. Does Starling Initiatives have a CRM / email-list / Mailchimp-style backbone?
4. Is the Cole-Slaw blog dormant by intention, or has Cole forgotten the password?
5. Is there any Substack, Beehiiv, Ghost, or independent newsletter under his name? **None surfaced in this audit.**

Publishing Platforms

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/neil-cole/digital-presence/platforms.md

Platforms: Neil Cole

Status: Complete

Last updated: 2026-04-29

Confidence: HIGH on platform inventory and architectural assessment; MEDIUM on recent-activity status (login-gated and silence-period-impacted).

Cross-Platform Snapshot

Platform	Surface	Status	Owns	Reach (rough)	Cole-controlled?
Owned domain (current)	starlinginitiatives.com	Active	Yes	Small	Yes
Owned domain (legacy)	cmareources.org	Lapsed/ hijacked	Yes (formerly)	Was large; now broken	No (domain control lost)
Personal blog	cole-slau.blogspot.com	Dormant since 2017	Yes	~250 posts archive	Yes (Google account)
Twitter / X	@Neil_Cole	Likely active	Borrowed platform	UNKNOWN	Yes
LinkedIn	/in/neil-cole-8462654	Active	Borrowed platform	UNKNOWN	Yes
Facebook (personal)	neil.cole.92	Likely active	Borrowed	UNKNOWN	Yes
Facebook (org)	CMAResources page	Nominal	Borrowed	~8,300 likes	Yes
Facebook (Starling community)	Private group	Active	Borrowed	UNKNOWN	Yes
YouTube (Starling)	@starlinginitiatives	Active	Borrowed	UNKNOWN	Yes
YouTube (legacy)	/user/neilcole	Legacy	Borrowed	UNKNOWN	Yes (probably)
YouTube (other channels hosting Cole)	KCU, Verge, DTS, reChurch	Third-party	Borrowed	Small per channel	No
Goodreads	author/249457.Neil_Cole	Active	Borrowed	2,062 ratings, 36 followers	Limited
Amazon (author)	/author/B001JSBY7A	Active	Borrowed	Significant; 17+ books listed	Limited
Audible (author)	/author/Neil-Cole/B001JSBY7A	Active	Borrowed	5 audiobooks	Limited
Goodreads / ThriftBooks / Waterstones / AbeBooks / Barnes & Noble	All standard retail surfaces	Active	Borrowed	—	No

Platform	Surface	Status	Owns	Reach (rough)	Cole-controlled?
Publisher author pages	Baker, Tyndale, Wiley/Jossey-Bass, Thomas Nelson, ChurchSmart	Active	Borrowed	—	No
DTS Voice contributor page	voice.dts.edu/contributor/neil-cole	Active	Borrowed	—	No
Verge Network speaker page	vergenetwork.org/speakers/neil-cole	Active (legacy)	Borrowed	—	No
Kairos Pacific University faculty page	kairos.aeu.edu/team/neil-cole	Active	Borrowed	—	No
100Movements / MLC about pages	100movements.org, movementleaderscollective.com	Active	Borrowed	—	No
Newsletters	None publicly visible	Absent	—	—	—
Substack / Beehiiv / Ghost / Patreon	None	Absent	—	—	—
Podcast (hosted)	None solo; appears as guest only	Absent	—	—	—

Platform Architecture Diagnosis

Cole's platform architecture is the **mirror image of a contemporary "build the platform" author's**. He has:

- **Many small surfaces, no central one.** 17+ books across 5 publishers; 250+ blog posts on a dormant blog; multiple YouTube channels; conference talks scattered across Verge, Exponential, KCU, DTS; podcast appearances on 8+ different shows. There is no [neilcole.com](#) that ties any of this together.
- **Owned-domain leakage.** The most-cited domain ([cmareources.org](#)) is not under his control anymore. The personal blog ([cole-slaw.blogspot.com](#)) is on Google's free infrastructure and dormant. Starling Initiatives is small and quiet by design.
- **Borrowed-platform dependence for retail and audio.** Books live on Amazon / Goodreads / publisher sites; audiobooks live on Audible. None of these are surfaces Cole shapes.
- **No central email list.** Removing the highest-leverage direct-relationship asset.
- **Episodic re-emergences** (KCU 2025, reChurch 2024–2025, Shifting Culture 2024, DTS Lectureship 2022) that succeed despite the absence of a feeder platform — because the strength of the underlying work and the network density of the host shows do the routing.

This pattern is consistent with a leader whose career arc was front-loaded into the trade-publishing era (2005–2014) and whose late career has deliberately rejected platform-building for theological reasons (the silence period). It produces **maximum fragmentation per unit of intellectual depth** — exactly the case Movemental's ecosystem layer is designed to serve.

Digital Presence Score

Score: 2.6 / 5.

Dimension	Score	Rationale
Owned-domain hub quality	2 / 5	Starling Initiatives is functional but minimal; no canonical author site
Authored content depth	5 / 5	17+ books, 250-post blog archive, 8+ podcast appearances, 5 audiobooks, multiple conferences
Discoverability of content	1 / 5	Fragmented across 12+ surfaces with no central index; lapsed CMA domain has broken thousands of legacy citations
Active social presence	2 / 5	Multiple handles exist; activity status post-silence UNKNOWN; intentionally small footprint
Newsletter / list ownership	1 / 5	No visible public newsletter
Multimedia (video / audio)	4 / 5	Strong audiobook catalog; multiple talks and podcast episodes; YouTube playlists exist
Cross-surface coherence	1 / 5	No "where to find Neil Cole" hub; bio metadata varies across surfaces
Search-engine recoverability	4 / 5	Despite the fragmentation, his name + "organic church" or "CMA" returns him reliably; Goodreads, Amazon, Wikipedia-adjacent pages, and publisher pages float to the top

(Compared with Lucas Pulley's 2.2 / 5 for similar reasons; compared with Brad Brisco's higher score because Brisco maintains an active newsletter and a contemporary primary site.)

Where Cole's Platform Most Dramatically Falls Short of His Influence

1. **No author site under his own name.** Hirsch has alanhirsch.org. Frost has michael frost.net. Brisco has bradbrisco.com. Cole has nothing comparable.
2. **The CMA archive is bleeding.** Every CMA Resources URL cited in the 2005–2018 missional literature now either 404s or routes to a gambling site. This is reputational decay that compounds with time.
3. **The Cole-Slaw archive has no SEO upkeep.** Blog posts are findable only via direct search; Google has nothing recent to index.

4. **No central catalog of his books.** The Goodreads page is the closest thing, and even Goodreads under-counts (60 distinct works listed; only ~17 are major books).
5. **No way for a stranger to subscribe to anything.**

These are precisely the things a Movemental-hosted Cole Hub solves.

Open Questions

1. Does Cole have a pre-existing relationship with any other content-management infrastructure (Squarespace, WordPress, Webflow) that could be migrated to a Movemental-hosted hub?
2. Is the Starling Initiatives team open to a partnership with Movemental on the curatorial side without ceding the brand?
3. Is the Wayback Machine archive of CMA Resources comprehensive enough to rebuild the canonical content from?
4. What is the current status of the Cole-Slaw blog's Google account (still in Cole's control? Lost credentials?)?

Newsletters

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/neil-cole/digital-presence/newsletters.md

Newsletters: Neil Cole

Status: Complete (with documented UNKNOWNs)

Last updated: 2026-04-29

Confidence: HIGH on what is publicly visible; LOW on what may exist behind the Starling Initiatives community wall.

Newsletter Inventory

Surface	Status	Notes
Personal Substack / Beehiiv / Ghost / Mailchimp under his own name	NONE FOUND	No <code>neilcole.substack.com</code> , <code>neilcole.beehiiv.com</code> , or equivalent surfaced in this audit.
Starling Initiatives newsletter	UNCONFIRMED	The <code>starlinginitiatives.com</code> homepage does not visibly surface a newsletter signup form in this audit; a private community newsletter (delivered via the FB group or by direct email) may exist but has not been verified.
CMA Resources newsletter	DORMANT — historical	The CMA Resources legacy infrastructure ran a Constant Contact newsletter ("Tools and Trainings from Church Multiplication Associates") — the SERP returns archived URLs at <code>archive.constantcontact.com</code> . This list is presumed inactive given the broader CMA lapse.
Cole-Slaw blog email subscription	DORMANT	The blog had a standard Blogspot RSS feed and email-by-post; with no posts since 2017-06-07 the list (if any) has been silent for nearly nine years.
Book launch / publisher email lists	INDIRECT	Tyndale Momentum, Baker, Jossey-Bass, and Thomas Nelson all maintain author lists, but Cole does not personally control them.
Cole-Slaw Records (linktr.ee)	UNRELATED	A SERP hit for "Cole Slaw Records" (<code>linktr.ee/coleslaw.records</code>) is a music-label namespace collision; unrelated to Neil Cole.

Volumetric Estimate

If we use an order-of-magnitude estimate from the Cole-Slaw blog activity (250 posts over ten years, with the post-2014 cadence drop) and the modest Starling Initiatives community footprint, the total subscriber-list reach Cole personally controls in 2026 is **almost certainly under 5,000** — probably substantially under. This is the single largest under-leveraged asset in the dossier:

- Cole has **20+ years of working relationships** with Greenhouse training alumni (Frisco, Virginia Mennonite, Long Beach cohorts, etc.).
- He has **17+ books' worth of buyers** scattered across Amazon, Barnes & Noble, Christianbook, Audible, and library systems.
- He has **direct access** to the 100 Movements / Movement Leaders Collective audience as a co-founder.
- He has the **post-silence interview audience** (KCU, Shifting Culture, reChurch) — a few thousand additional listeners per appearance.

A consolidated Cole newsletter (Movemental-hosted or Starling-hosted) could plausibly seed at 3,000–8,000 subscribers within 90 days of launch. **It does not currently exist in any visible form.**

Implications for Movemental

1. **A newsletter is the single highest-leverage move Movemental could make on Cole's behalf.** A weekly or monthly cadence is not necessary; a quarterly cadence ("From Neil's desk") with a single story, a single short framework recap, and a single recommended LTG/Greenhouse practice would be more than sufficient.
2. **The launch lead-magnet is obvious: the silence story.** A polished essay or short PDF — "13 Years of Silence: What I Heard When I Stopped Speaking" — would be a near-guaranteed signup driver, and would also serve as the doorway essay that introduces him to the post-2015 generation of practitioners (Wegner, Pulley, Brian Johnson, the post-Sanders Underground / Tampa cohort) who built on top of his work without ever working with him directly.
3. **A "best of Cole-Slaw" archive newsletter** (1 post per week from the legacy blog, curated and lightly re-edited with a 2026 framing introduction) would convert the dormant 250-post archive into a 250-week / ~5-year automated content engine.

Open Questions

1. Does Starling Initiatives currently operate a public-facing email list, even at low volume?
2. Did the historical CMA Resources Constant Contact list exceed 10,000 subscribers? Internal CMA records would settle this; public records do not.
3. Did Cole's silence rule include **email**, or only social media and blogging?

4. Does Cole personally maintain any direct-email correspondence list with Greenhouse alumni, LTG leaders, or 100 Movements peers? Email is a different category than newsletters and is plausibly ongoing even during the silence.

Social Media

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/neil-cole/digital-presence/social-media.md

Social Media: Neil Cole

Status: Complete (with login-gated UNKNOWNs flagged)

Last updated: 2026-04-29

Confidence: HIGH on handle inventory; LOW on follower counts and last-post dates (login-gated; Cole's own self-described 13-year silence makes activity status particularly unclear).

Platform Inventory

Platform	Handle / URL	Status	Followers	Last Activity	Notes
Twitter / X	@Neil_Cole	LIKELY ACTIVE	~10.6K posts (per SERP); follower count UNKNOWN — login-gated	UNKNOWN — login-gated	Bio reads: "Follower of Christ, husband, father and author of Organic Church and several other books."
Twitter / X (org)	@CMAResources	NOMINALLY EXISTS	UNKNOWN — login-gated	UNKNOWN — likely dormant given CMA's broader lapse	—
Facebook (personal)	facebook.com/neil.cole.92	LIKELY ACTIVE	UNKNOWN — login-gated	UNKNOWN — login-gated	Confirmed via SERP
Facebook (CMA)	facebook.com/CMAResources	NOMINALLY EXISTS (Signal Hill, CA)	~8,300 likes (per SERP); ~97 talking	UNKNOWN — login-gated	Last post date UNKNOWN
Facebook (Starling)	Linked from starlinginitiatives.com → private community group	ACTIVE	UNKNOWN — group is private	Active per Starling site	—
LinkedIn	linkedin.com/in/neil-cole-8462654	ACTIVE	UNKNOWN — login-gated	UNKNOWN — login-gated	Listed as "CMA"; cross-listed elsewhere as "Author at Tyndale House Publishers"
YouTube (org)	youtube.com/@starlinginitiatives (UCx750SRUAGYM2g9DzINxBFg)	ACTIVE	UNKNOWN — fetch failed	UNKNOWN	Linked from starlinginitiatives.com
YouTube (legacy personal)	youtube.com/user/neilcole	LEGACY	UNKNOWN	UNKNOWN	Hosts older Verge / Exponential talks
YouTube (teaching playlist)	Neil Cole Organic Church teaching playlist	ACTIVE (legacy)	N/A — playlist	N/A	Hosted on a different channel; total videos UNKNOWN
SoundCloud	soundcloud.com/neil_cole	LIKELY EXISTS	UNKNOWN	UNKNOWN	Direct fetch failed

Platform	Handle / URL	Status	Followers	Last Activity	Notes
Instagram	UNKNOWN — handle not surfaced	LIKELY DOES NOT EXIST	—	—	No verified handle in this audit; the silence period and his theology of obscurity make Instagram unlikely
Threads / Bluesky / Mastodon	UNKNOWN	UNKNOWN	—	—	No verified accounts
TikTok	UNKNOWN	UNKNOWN	—	—	No verified accounts
Patreon / Substack	UNKNOWN	UNKNOWN	—	—	No verified accounts; closest analog is the Starling Initiatives private FB group

Cross-Platform Analysis

What we can say with confidence

- Cole's **historical** social presence (2007–~2014) was non-trivial: a 250-post blog, a Twitter handle still showing 10K+ posts, a Facebook page with several thousand likes, and an active CMA Resources YouTube embed pattern.
- Cole's **current** social presence is **deliberately small and quiet**. Starling Initiatives is the operational hub but its public-facing footprint is intentionally modest — a private community group and a Zoom-training cadence rather than a follower-and-engagement game.
- The **CMA Resources** social handles still exist but appear effectively dormant. They map to a now-lapsed domain.

What we can't say without login

- Current follower counts on Twitter, Facebook (personal), LinkedIn, and YouTube.
- Most-recent-post dates on Twitter, Facebook personal, and LinkedIn.
- Engagement rates on any platform.
- Whether the silence period (~2012–2024) included or excluded social media. Cole has explicitly said it included social media; whether he has resumed posting since the 2024 Shifting Culture re-emergence is UNKNOWN.

Theology-of-obscurity caveat

Cole's own framing on KCU (Aug 2025) — "God told me to stop speaking publicly in the U.S., refrain from social media, and cease blogging" — is one of the strongest pieces of evidence that the social-media silence has been deliberate and coherent with his theology, not accidental. Movemental copy that benchmarks Cole against "leaders should have 50K Twitter followers" is mis-fitting the subject. **Treat the small, quiet social footprint as a feature, not a bug.**

Implications for Movemental

1. **Don't chase a handle takeover or growth play.** The lane that fits is "trusted-voice elder, episodic feature," not "build the brand."
2. **The 2024-2025 podcast cluster (Shifting Culture / reChurch / KC Underground) is the right kind of surface for Cole's voice now.** Movemental's own podcast / video / column program should pattern after those — long-form, listening-shaped, host-led.
3. **The most valuable single asset Movemental could host on his behalf is a curated archive of his canonical content** (Cole-Slaw blog selections; CMA Resources rescue; book excerpts; the silence-story interviews). Not a new social campaign.
4. **A respectful "where to find Neil Cole" page** is high-value low-effort. There currently is no single URL on the internet that lists his Twitter, his Starling Initiatives YouTube, his Cole-Slaw archive, his Goodreads, his Audible, his books-by-publisher, and his current podcast appearances.

Open Questions

1. Is the @Neil_Cole Twitter account currently active, or has Cole stopped posting there as part of his silence rule? Login-gated.
2. Is there a @neilcole or @neilrcole handle on Bluesky that he has migrated to? Not surfaced.
3. What is the canonical YouTube channel — @starlinginitiatives, /user/neilcole, or some other? Multiple channels exist and the relationship between them is unclear.
4. Does Starling Initiatives operate a public newsletter? The about page does not visibly surface a signup form in this audit.

The Fragmentation Story

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/neil-cole/fragmentation-story.md

Neil Cole: The Fragmentation Story

Generated 2026-04-29 by the `fragmentation-story` skill from existing research in `docs/movement_leader_research/neil-cole/`.

The Story

Neil Cole spent the late 1990s pastoring a Grace Brethren church in Alta Loma, California; in 1999 he walked away from that pastorate, walked into the smoking section of a Long Beach coffeehouse called The Coffee Tavern, and started **Awakening Chapel**. Out of that first congregation he built two operational technologies — the **Life Transformation Group (LTG)**: 2 or 3 people, weekly, Scripture and accountability and prayer for non-Christians; and the **Organic Church Planters' Greenhouse**, a two-stage cohort training. He wrapped them inside an organization called **Church Multiplication Associates (CMA)** and spent the next nineteen years sending the LTG card to every church planter who would take one. By the organization's own count it had helped start "thousands of churches in 50 states and 50+ nations." The IMB adapted his LTG into a tool called CHAT. Curtis Sergeant carried the framework into Saddleback's PEACE Plan. Steve Addison cited him as a foundational practitioner. Alan Hirsch wrote "Neil Cole is one of the foremost thinkers and practitioners [of] organic forms of church" on the back cover of *Organic Church*, and a year later Cole returned the favor on the back cover of *The Forgotten Ways*.

Between 2005 and 2015 he published **twelve trade-house books** across **five publishers** — Jossey-Bass, Baker, Tyndale Momentum, Thomas Nelson, and ChurchSmart. *Organic Church* (2005, foreword by Leonard Sweet); *Search & Rescue* (2008); *Organic Leadership* (2009); *Church 3.0* (2010, foreword by Francis Chan); *Journeys to Significance* (2011); *Ordinary Hero* (2011); *Church Transfusion* with Phil Helfer (2012); *Primal Fire* (Tyndale, 2014, with four co-thinkers); *One Thing* (Thomas Nelson, 2015). He spoke at Verge and Exponential and the Simple Church Conference. He ran Greenhouse cohorts in Frisco TX, Virginia Mennonite Conference, and across Southern California. He maintained the **Cole-Slaw blog** ("Cole — raw, shredded, mixed-up, and served cold") and produced ~250 posts. In November 2015 he co-founded **100 Movements** with Alan Hirsch, Dave Rhodes, Will Mancini, and Jessie Cruickshank. That is the part of the story that is searchable.

The rest is not. There is no `neilcole.com`. The `cmaresources.org` domain — for two decades the central content hub — has lapsed and now serves a Sydney lottery-prediction page. The Cole-Slaw blog goes dormant after a single post on June 7, 2017. His big-house publishing run ends with *One Thing* in November 2015 and there are no Jossey-Bass or Baker or Tyndale or

Thomas Nelson titles between 2015 and 2026. The reason, as Cole has explained on three different podcasts in 2024 and 2025: God told him to stop speaking publicly in the U.S., to refrain from social media, and to cease blogging. He calls it his **13-year season of silence**. "I never felt like Jesus left me. Everyone else did — but He never did."

What he did publish in that silence window — Rising Tides (2018), Pray (2019/2022), VIRAL (2021), Journeys (2024) — appears under his own self-publishing imprint, **Starling Initiatives**, on Amazon. He narrates the audiobooks himself. He teaches at Kairos Pacific University as Professor of Church Development. He delivered three chapel sessions at Dallas Theological Seminary's 2022 Missions and Evangelism Lectureship. In April 2024 he returned to Shifting Culture; in December 2024 and January 2025 he sat down with the reChurch Podcast; in August 2025 he sat down with Brian Johnson and Cory at **KC Underground's Upside Down Kingdom** podcast — Rob Wegner's organization receiving him as the elder voice of the framework Wegner inherited.

Neil Cole's fragmentation is not the fragmentation of a 30-book author whose work is scattered across 7 publishers — though the publisher dispersion is real (5 publishers in 10 years). It is the fragmentation of **a movement architect whose own primary domain has died, whose 250-post blog is frozen, whose CMA Resources canon is now Wayback-Machine-only, whose 17+ books have no central catalog page, whose social handles have unknown activity status, whose new home (Starling Initiatives) is a small private community group, and whose late-career theology of obscurity has structurally prevented him from solving any of this himself**. The corpus is large; the surface is small; the bridge is broken.

This is precisely what Movemental's ecosystem layer is built to repair.

Informational Fragmentation

Books

17+ confirmed; 60 distinct works listed on Goodreads (counts translations and study guides); 5 different trade publishers.

- **Cultivating a Life for God: Multiplying Disciples Through Life Transformation Groups** — ChurchSmart Resources, 1999. ISBN 978-1889638065. The LTG manual.
- **Beyond Church Planting** — with Robert E. Logan, Holly Morgan, Julie Becker, Michelle Dodd. ChurchSmart, Sept 2005. ISBN 978-1889638492.
- **Organic Church: Growing Faith Where Life Happens** — Jossey-Bass / Leadership Network Series, 2005. Foreword by Leonard Sweet. ISBN 978-0787981297.
- **Search & Rescue: Becoming a Disciple Who Makes a Difference** — Baker Books, April 2008. ISBN 978-0801013096.
- **Organic Leadership: Leading Naturally Right Where You Are** — Baker Books / Shapevine series, Feb 2009. ISBN 978-0801013102.

- **Church 3.0: Upgrades for the Future of the Church** — Jossey-Bass, Jan 2010. Foreword by Francis Chan. ISBN 978-0470529454.
- **Colonel Surrey's Insanity** (fiction) — 2010. Publisher UNKNOWN.
- **Journeys to Significance: Charting a Leadership Course from the Life of Paul** — Jossey-Bass, 2011. ISBN 978-0470529447.
- **Ordinary Hero: Becoming a Disciple Who Makes a Difference** — Baker, Jan 2011. ISBN 978-0801072772.
- **Stability in Mind** — 2012. Publisher UNKNOWN — likely self-published.
- **Church Transfusion: Changing Your Church Organically — From the Inside Out** — with Phil Helfer. Jossey-Bass Book 63, 2012. ISBN 978-1118131282.
- **The Black Swan Effect: A Response to Gender Hierarchy in the Church** — contributor; Felicity Dale ed. House2House / CreateSpace, 2014. ISBN 978-1497300187.
- **Primal Fire: Reigniting the Church with the Five Gifts of Jesus** — Tyndale Momentum, April 2014. ISBN 978-1414385501. Reissued under Starling Initiatives 2025 (ISBN 9798992152609).
- **One Thing: A Revolution to Change the World with Love** — Thomas Nelson, Nov 2015. ISBN 978-0718032869. **Last major trade-house book before the silence.**
- **Rising Tides: Finding a Future-Proof Faith in an Age of Exponential Change** — Starling Initiatives, June 2018. ISBN 978-0990660484.
- **Pray: Finding Ways for Ordinary People to Connect with God in All of Life** — Starling Initiatives, 2019/2022. ISBN 978-1792352003.
- **VIRAL: Hearing God's Voice in a Global Pandemic... and Beyond** — Starling Initiatives, Oct 2021. ISBN 978-0578257181.
- **Journeys: Discovering God's Paths of Spiritual Formation Building to a Strong Finish** — Starling Initiatives, 2024. ISBN 9798218377076.

Plus: **Truth Quest Facilitator's Guide, Raising Leaders for the Harvest** (with Logan), **Organic Church Planters' Greenhouse** (training manual with Paul Kaak), and a **Cherishing the Bride of Christ** title that appears in the dossier brief but was not surfaced in this audit and may be a working title or a misremembered reference — status UNKNOWN.

Academic Work

- M.Div. (New Testament) from Grace Theological Seminary, Winona Lake, IN — degree credentialed; thesis or capstone (if any) UNKNOWN.
- Doctor of Divinity from America Evangelical University, Gardena, CA — honorary or earned UNKNOWN.
- DTS 2022 Missions and Evangelism Lectureship — three chapel sessions; published as articles on DTS Voice.
- No peer-reviewed journal articles in Missiology, JETS, Themelios, Pneuma, Mission Frontiers, or similar — none surfaced in this audit.

PDFs & Documents

- **Legacy CMA Resources** had hundreds of articles, MP3s, video, training PDFs. The domain has lapsed; the Wayback Machine is the only stable access.
- **LTG card** — historically the single most-distributed Cole document; on a 3×5 paper card with a Bible reading plan, accountability questions, and prayer-for-non-Christian space.
- **Greenhouse training manuals** — Story 1 + Story 2 cohort handbooks; primary author Cole + Paul Kaak.
- **ReTooling Leadership series** — Ed Waken-led training PDFs on legacy CMA Resources.
- **Foundations of Organic Leadership** — Cole + Phil Helfer audio-and-document set.

Articles

- **3 DTS Voice articles** (Nov 2022 lectureship): "The Harvest Starts with Compassion and Prayer," "Jesus' Instructions for Global Missions," "Making Disciples Worth Multiplying."
- **1 Christianity Today article**: "Long Live the Organic Church: A Response" (Jan 12, 2010).
- **Charisma Magazine feature** (mid-2000s; exact issue UNKNOWN).
- **Leadership Network feature** (date UNKNOWN).
- **Outreach Magazine** "The Church Needs Skunk Works" (date UNKNOWN).
- **Faith Radio** author/contributor index (specific articles UNKNOWN).
- **Verge Network** printables and companion articles (e.g., "What Is a Missional Community?" Dec 2010).
- **Frank Viola joint Keith Giles interview** (frankviola.org, Sept 2010).
- **House2House** materials (Tony & Felicity Dale).
- **Multiple legacy CMA Resources articles** — broken-linked.
- **Many third-party reviews** (9Marks, ChosenRebel, Pneuma Review, etc.).

Blogs & Personal Writing

- **Cole-Slaw blog** (cole-slaw.blogspot.com) — ~250 posts across 2007–2017; **dormant since 2017-06-07**.
- About-me on the blog: "Follower of Jesus, father of three, husband of one, church planter, author and coach. Yikes, this reads like a tombstone!"
- The blog is one of the largest extant primary sources of Cole's mid-career thinking; its dormant state is the single largest piece of low-hanging Movemental curatorial fruit.
- **No personal Substack, Medium, Beehiiv, or Ghost surface** discovered.

Websites

- **starlinginitiatives.com** — current organizational home (~2018–); active but small. Hosts the about page with bio, the audiobook shop, monthly Zoom signups, the private FB community link.
- **cmaresources.org** — was the central CMA / Awakening Chapel content hub; **now lapsed and serving a Sydney lottery-prediction page**. Wayback-only.
- **cole-slaw.blogspot.com** — dormant since 2017.
- **theneilcoleshow.com** — surfaces in SERP under a "broadcaster" tag; Cole-controlled status UNCLEAR.
- **No personal author domain** under his own name (neilcole.com / neilrcole.com).
- **Indirect:** kairos.aeu.edu/team/neil-cole, voice.dts.edu/contributor/neil-cole, vergenetwork.org/speakers/neil-cole, churchplanting.com/team/neil-cole, simplechurchalliance.com/tag/neil-cole, baker.com / wiley.com / tyndale.com / thomas-nelson.com publisher author pages.

Social Media

- **Twitter / X:** [@Neil_Cole](https://twitter.com/Neil_Cole) — bio "Follower of Christ, husband, father and author of Organic Church and several other books." ~10.6K posts per SERP. Activity status post-silence UNKNOWN — login-gated.
- **Twitter @CMAResources** — nominally exists; activity status UNCONFIRMED.
- **Facebook personal:** facebook.com/neil.cole.92. Activity status UNKNOWN — login-gated.
- **Facebook CMA Resources page:** ~8,300 likes (per SERP); Signal Hill CA. Activity status UNKNOWN.
- **Facebook Starling Initiatives community:** private group; active per starlinginitiatives.com.
- **LinkedIn:** linkedin.com/in/neil-cole-8462654 ("CMA"); also titled "Author at Tyndale House Publishers" elsewhere. Activity status UNKNOWN.
- **YouTube:** youtube.com/@starlinginitiatives (channel ID UCx750SRUAGYM2g9DzINxBFg) + legacy [/user/neilcole](https://youtube.com/user/neilcole) + a "Neil Cole Organic Church teaching" playlist hosted on a different channel. Subscriber and view counts UNKNOWN.
- **SoundCloud:** soundcloud.com/neil_cole — likely exists; track count UNKNOWN.
- **Instagram:** UNKNOWN — handle not surfaced; presence may not exist.
- **Threads / Bluesky / Mastodon / TikTok:** UNKNOWN — none verified.
- **Patreon / Substack:** UNKNOWN — none verified.

Newsletters / Email

- **No personal newsletter** — no Substack, Beehiiv, Mailchimp, or ConvertKit list under his name surfaced.

- **Starling Initiatives newsletter** — UNCONFIRMED; the site does not visibly surface a signup form.
- **Legacy CMA Resources Constant Contact list** — historical artifact; presumed inactive.
- **Cole-Slaw blog email subscription** — silent since 2017.
- **No public lead magnet, no archive, no automation.**

Podcasts (Hosted)

None confirmed. Cole does not host a podcast under his own name. The theneilcoleshow.com SERP hit may be a third-party producer's branding — UNCONFIRMED.

Podcasts (Guest)

Catalogued in this audit:

1. **Shifting Culture** Ep. 178 — April 26, 2024 — Joshua Johnson host
2. **reChurch Podcast** Ep. 13 — Dec 31, 2024 — Justin and Brooke Knoop hosts
3. **reChurch Podcast** Ep. 14 — Jan 7, 2025 — same hosts
4. **KC Underground / Upside Down Kingdom** — Aug 2025 — Brian Johnson and Cory hosts
5. **The Church Digital Podcast** Ep. 269 — April 24, 2023 — Jeff Reed host
6. **The Team Leadership Podcast** — ~2022 — APEST and microchurches
7. **Dare to Multiply** Ep. 60 — APEST interview — Cynthia host
8. **The More Disciples Podcast** — Organic Leadership and Discipleship
9. **FUSE Life: 42** — Exploring Church as We Know It
10. **Special Guests Ep. 86** — Journeys to Significance

Plus presumably 10–20 additional pre-silence appearances on Exponential / Verge / Catalyst-adjacent podcasts that are not catalogued.

YouTube & Video

- **Multiple Cole-controlled channels** (Starling Initiatives + legacy [/user/neilcole](#)) with **subscriber and video counts UNKNOWN**.
- **"Neil Cole Organic Church teaching" playlist** on a third channel.
- **Verge Network YouTube** — hosts older talks ("How to Identify Good Soil That Produces Movements," "Why Churches Grow," "What Is a Missional Community?").
- **DTS Voice YouTube** — hosts the 2022 chapel sessions.
- **KC Underground YouTube** — hosts the 2025 Upside Down Kingdom episode.
- **reChurch Podcast YouTube** — hosts Eps 13–14.
- **Legacy CMA Resources video catalog** — broken-linked; Wayback-only.
- **2007 "Why Didn't I Take the Blue Pill? The Dark Side of Organic Church"** talk — broken-linked.

Sermons / Teaching Audio

- **Awakening Chapel sermons** (1999--~2014) — UNKNOWN. Likely substantial; no archive surfaced.
- **CMA / Greenhouse training audio** — large legacy library; broken-linked.
- **Audiobooks** (5 confirmed): Organic Church (2009, Marc Cashman), Church 3.0 (2020, Brad Smith), Pray (2022, Cole self-narrated), Journeys (2024, Cole self-narrated), Primal Fire reissue (2026, Cole self-narrated).

Talks / Conferences

- **Exponential 2011 ("On the Verge")** — speaker.
- **Verge Conference talks** (multiple, 2010-2013).
- **Simple Church Conference 2013** — speaker.
- **Organic Church Movements Conference 2007** — "Why Didn't I Take the Blue Pill?"
- **Greenhouse cohorts** — Frisco TX 2011 (~75 participants), Virginia Mennonite Conference 2012, multiple Long Beach / Southern California cohorts.
- **DTS 2022 Missions and Evangelism Lectureship** — three chapel sessions.
- **Many uncatalogued events 2005-2014** — likely 50-100 conference / training appearances total.

Courses

- **Organic Church Planters' Greenhouse Story 1 + Story 2** — primary CMA training cycle.
- **Life Transformation Group (LTG)** — discipleship cell technology.
- **ReTooling Leadership** — Ed Waken-led series.
- **Starling Initiatives "online courses coming soon"** — promised since at least 2020; no launch date.
- **Kairos Pacific University courses** — undergraduate / graduate teaching; specific catalog UNKNOWN.

Assessments & Tools

- **No named diagnostic instrument under Cole's name.** Unlike Hirsch (the 5Q assessment), Cole has not productized a self-assessment.
- The closest analog is the **LTG card** itself — an operational tool rather than a diagnostic.

Apps / Software

- **None.** No app, microchurch platform, or software product attributed to Cole.

Notes, Laptop, Unpublished

- UNKNOWN — likely substantial, not catalogued. A 25-year movement architect almost certainly carries: sermon manuscripts from Alta Loma + Awakening Chapel; Greenhouse cohort decks; CMA strategy memos; draft chapters that did not make the published books; private journals from the 13-year silence; correspondence with Helfer / Kaak / Logan / Hirsch.

Embodied / In Their Head

The largest single trapped pool in Cole's footprint:

- **The 13-year silence story** — Cole has told it three times publicly (Shifting Culture 2024, reChurch 2024–2025, KCU 2025). The fully extended version, with dates and specifics, lives mostly in his head and possibly in the Journeys (2024) book.
- **Greenhouse alumni network** — tens of thousands of practitioners in 50+ countries who have run an LTG, attended a Greenhouse, or used CMA Resources. Cole knows many of them by name. None of this is externalized as a network database.
- **The relational graph with Hirsch / Logan / Helfer / Kaak / Waken / Sanders / Wegner / Felicity Dale / Frank Viola / Curtis Sergeant / Steve Addison** — lives in his email, phone, and memory.
- **Pre-silence conference talk catalog** — hundreds of talks; only a small fraction recorded; only a tiny fraction discoverable.
- **Decades of Awakening Chapel and CMA stories** — anecdotes, case studies, failures, recoveries — most of which would be a goldmine for a Movemental-curated long-form interview series.

Relational Fragmentation

Organizations

- **Awakening Chapel** (Long Beach, 1999) — founding pastor.
- **Church Multiplication Associates (CMA)** (1999–~2018) — founder, executive director. **Effectively dormant** as of 2026 (domain lapsed).
- **Starling Initiatives** (~2018–) — founder; current organizational home. Small and quiet.
- **100 Movements** (2015) — co-founder with Hirsch, Rhodes, Mancini, Cruickshank.
- **Movement Leaders Collective** — adjacent through 100M.
- **Kairos Pacific University** — Professor of Church Development.
- **Charis Fellowship (Grace Brethren)** — denominational origin; pastor of Grace Brethren church Alta Loma 1990s.

Co-authors & Collaborators

- **Phil Helfer** — co-founder of CMA; co-author of Church Transfusion.
- **Paul Kaak** — co-author of Greenhouse manual; Primal Fire (Teaching).
- **Robert (Bob) E. Logan** — named mentor; co-author of Beyond Church Planting and Raising Leaders for the Harvest.
- **Ed Waken** — Greenhouse co-trainer; Primal Fire (Evangelistic).
- **Dezi Baker** — Primal Fire (Prophetic).
- **Ross Rohde** — co-author of Apostolic Leadership audio set.
- **Holly Morgan, Julie Becker, Michelle Dodd** — co-authors of Beyond Church Planting (2005).
- **Mike Perkinson, Tom Johnston** — contributing authors to Beyond Church Planting.
- **Reggie McNeal** — co-billed on Organic Leadership Shapevine paperback.
- **100 Movements design team: Alan Hirsch, Dave Rhodes, Will Mancini, Jessie Cruickshank.**
- **Black Swan Effect contributors: Felicity Dale, Tony Dale, Peggy Batcheller-Hijar, Jan Diss, Katie Driver, Dave Ferguson, Michael Frost, Alan Hirsch, Suzette Lambert, Floyd McClung.**

Networks & Movements

- **Organic / Simple / House Church stream** — foundational voice.
- **Disciple-Making Movement (DMM) / Church Planting Movement (CPM)** — bridge via LTG → IMB CHAT.
- **Underground Network / KC Underground / Tampa Underground / Microchurch movement** — patriarch elder via Sanders endorsement (2019) + KCU 2025 podcast.
- **APEST / 5Q / Five-Fold Ministry** — Primal Fire paired reading with Hirsch's 5Q.
- **Forge Mission Training Network** — adjacent via Hirsch, Frost, Halter; not Forge faculty.
- **NewThing Network** — adjacent via Dave Ferguson.
- **Exponential** — speaker 2011+; specific ongoing role UNCLEAR.
- **House2House** — featured in video training series; co-contributor with Felicity Dale.
- **Mosaix Global Network** — adjacent.
- **DAWN Ministries / Saturation Church Planting** — adjacent via Michael Steele.
- **IMB / Saddleback PEACE Plan** — downstream framework adoption.
- **Charis Fellowship** — denominational origin.

Academic Affiliations

- **Kairos Pacific University** — Professor of Church Development (current).
- **Dallas Theological Seminary** — guest lectureship (2022); contributor to DTS Voice.

- **Grace Theological Seminary** — alumnus (M.Div., NT).
- **California State University, Long Beach** — alumnus (BA, Fine Art).
- **America Evangelical University** — alumnus (DD).

Mentors, Protégés, Key Relationships

- **Mentors named:** Robert E. Logan (named directly in Cole's 2010 CT response).
- **Influences cited but not contemporary mentors:** Roland Allen, George Patterson, Wolfgang Simson.
- **Long peer relationships:** Alan Hirsch (mutual endorsement + 100M co-design), Phil Helfer (CMA co-founder), Paul Kaak (Greenhouse co-architect), Felicity Dale (Black Swan + House2House).
- **Conversation partners with friction:** Frank Viola (2010 joint interview).
- **Critical opposition:** 9Marks (Mark Dever / Jonathan Leeman ecosystem).
- **Downstream inheritors / mentees** (by structural debt or explicit reception):
 - Curtis Sergeant (LTG → CHAT at IMB)
 - Brian Sanders (Underground Network; Cole as endorser of Underground Church)
 - Rob Wegner (KC Underground; Cole hosted on Upside Down Kingdom 2025)
 - Lucas Pulley (Tampa Underground; indirect via Sanders)
 - Brian Johnson (KCU co-host; podcast-host relationship 2025)
 - Steve Addison (cited Cole as foundational)

Family

- **Wife:** Dana Cole (married ~1985, ~40 years as of 2026).
- **Children:** Three adult children.
- **Grandchildren:** Five (2026 count).

Where Relationships Are Actually Stored

- **CRM / formal contact system:** UNKNOWN — almost certainly absent at the personal level. CMA likely had a Constant Contact list; presumed inactive. Starling Initiatives presumably runs a simple list; not visible.
- **Personal address book / phone:** where the actual relational graph with Hirsch, Helfer, Kaak, Logan, Felicity Dale, Sanders, Wegner, Sergeant, and the Greenhouse alumni is stored. **Mental rolodex.**
- **Email history:** where most cross-org strategy lives.
- **Conference and event circuits** (pre-silence): where relationships were renewed in 2005–2014 — Exponential, Verge, Catalyst, Mosaix, Greenhouse cohorts.
- **The legacy CMA Resources contact lists:** historical; status UNKNOWN.

- **Starling Initiatives private Facebook group**: the live relational surface as of 2026; small.

The relational layer is, as expected, the **most fragmented**: high-trust connections (Hirsch, Helfer, Kaak, Logan, the Dales, Sanders, Wegner, the 100M co-design team, the Greenhouse alumni global network) live in personal memory, email, and event handshakes — not in any externalized graph.

Synthesis

Neil Cole is a **movement architect** whose externalized public footprint is approximately **one of the most-fragmented of any author with his citation density**. The math is striking. He has written roughly:

- **17+ books** (verified) plus contributions, training manuals, and translations
- **~250 blog posts** (Cole-Slaw, dormant)
- **~60 distinct works on Goodreads** (counts translations and short pieces)
- **~2,000 Goodreads ratings** at 3.99 average
- **Hundreds of legacy CMA Resources articles, MP3s, and videos** (Wayback-only)
- **5 audiobooks**
- **3 DTS Voice articles**
- **1 Christianity Today response article**
- **10 catalogued podcast guest appearances** (with 10–20 more uncatalogued)
- **50–100 conference / training appearances** (2005–2014; mostly uncatalogued)
- **~30+ Greenhouse cohorts trained**
- **Two operational frameworks** (LTG, Greenhouse) adopted internationally

Against that, his contemporary discoverable surface consists of:

- **One small, quiet website** (starlinginitiatives.com)
- **One dormant blog** (cole-slaw.blogspot.com)
- **One lapsed primary domain** (cmaresources.org → gambling-prediction page)
- **No author hub under his own name**
- **No active newsletter**
- **No solo podcast**
- **Multiple social handles whose activity status is opaque**
- **Multiple YouTube channels with unclear canonical relationships**
- **A small Starling Initiatives community group on Facebook**

Probably 5–10% of Cole's externalized output is currently discoverable through a single coherent surface. And **probably <2% is interconnected** — the books do not link to the blog do not link to the audiobooks do not link to the legacy CMA Resources canon do

not link to the contemporary podcast appearances do not link to the Kairos Pacific faculty page do not link to Starling Initiatives. The single largest pool of trapped value is the **embodied relational and conversational wisdom of a 25-year movement architect** — almost none of which has been written down by him in his own voice on a surface he controls — augmented by **the 13-year silence narrative** which has so far been told only in fragments across three podcast interviews.

The secondary trapped pool is **the legacy CMA Resources canon** — articles, audio, video, training manuals — which exists as files inside a now-lapsed organizational archive, accessible only via the Wayback Machine, and cited heavily in 2005–2018 missional literature whose footnotes now silently 404.

The tertiary trapped pool is **the Greenhouse / LTG alumni network** — practitioners across 50+ countries whose ministries were shaped by Cole's frameworks, whose names are in his email and his memory, and who have no shared post-CMA home.

This is exactly the case Movemental's ecosystem layer is designed to serve.

Research Provenance

- **Source folder:** docs/movement_leader_research/neil-cole/
- **Files synthesized:**
 - README.md
 - _tracker.md
 - profile/identity.md
 - profile/biography.md
 - profile/theology.md
 - profile/voice-analysis.md
 - digital-presence/websites.md
 - digital-presence/social-media.md
 - digital-presence/newsletters.md
 - digital-presence/platforms.md
 - content/books.md
 - content/articles.md
 - content/videos.md
 - content/audio.md
 - content/courses.md
 - content/academic.md
 - network/organizations.md
 - network/collaborators.md
 - network/endorsements.md

- `network/events.md`
- `media/press-coverage.md`
- `media/citations.md`
- `media/reviews.md`
- `analysis/audience-analysis.md`
- `analysis/content-analysis.md`
- `analysis/competitive-landscape.md`
- (staff-only analysis files excluded from leader-facing dossier)
- `network/network-summary.md`
- **Confidence: High** on bibliography, organizational arc, doctrinal frameworks, and the silence narrative. **Medium** on social-media activity status (login-gated) and on operational details inside Starling Initiatives. **Low** on volumetrics (subscriber counts, view counts, total Greenhouse alumni) and on the legacy CMA Resources article archive (Wayback-only and not exhaustively traversed in this audit).
- **Gaps requiring further research:**
 - CMA's current legal status (active 501(c)(3), dormant good standing, or dissolved)
 - Starling Initiatives team, board, funding model, 501(c)(3) status
 - Exact start date of the 13-year silence (~2011 vs ~2012)
 - Twitter / Facebook / LinkedIn / YouTube follower counts and most-recent post dates
 - Instagram presence (handle UNKNOWN; possibly nonexistent)
 - Total Greenhouse cohort count and alumni network size
 - Translation inventory across non-English languages
 - Comprehensive endorsement archaeology (Cole has likely endorsed 30+ books over 25 years; only a handful are catalogued)
 - America Evangelical University DD (honorary vs earned, date)
 - Frank Viola post-2010 relationship state
 - Awakening Chapel current operational status (still meeting? dissolved? absorbed?)
 - Whether `theneilcoleshow.com` is Cole-controlled or third-party
 - Wayback Machine completeness for the legacy CMA Resources archive

A Letter — Reflected Understanding

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/reflected-understanding/neil-cole.md

Neil Cole: Reflected Understanding

A concise reflection spoken back so the language could be endorsed — familiar, but with edges that deepen. (Leader-safe: audience-sizing and commerce analysis are kept in staff notes, not here.)

Calling

You're called to **make disciples who make disciples** — and to keep the unit small enough that they actually can. Not to build an institution, not to scale a brand, but to recover the church's smallest reproducible cell and release it to multiply. That instinct goes all the way back to the smoking section of The Coffee Tavern: a different kind of church, started low and built to reproduce. The Life Transformation Group is the clearest expression of it — two or three people, Scripture, confession, prayer for the lost — because the smallest viable cell already has to carry the whole DNA: Divine Truth, Nurturing Relationships, Apostolic Mission. Your conviction that "the highest potential of the church is in its smallest unit" is not a slogan; it's the load-bearing claim of everything from Cultivating a Life for God to Church 3.0. You lowered the bar of how church is done so anyone can do it, and raised the bar of what it means to be a disciple so that not just anyone will.

And then there's the second calling, which you didn't choose and which is harder to name: the long obscurity. Thirteen years told to stop speaking, stop blogging, stop posting. What you've said about that season — "I never felt like Jesus left me. Everyone else did — but He never did" — is itself a teaching. It means the platform was never the point; intimacy with Christ that bears fruit the platform can't is the point. The language you already use — organic, DNA, family on mission, listen to Jesus and do what He says — is the right language. It stays agricultural rather than industrial, decentralized rather than hierarchical, and tethered to the actual cost of leading from the edge rather than the center.

Existing Content (before the platform we're building)

Where it lives. Your content lives across a long trade-publishing run — Organic Church, Church 3.0, Search & Rescue, Organic Leadership, Church Transfusion, Primal Fire, and more, with Jossey-Bass, Baker, Tyndale, Thomas Nelson, and ChurchSmart — alongside the **Greenhouse** training materials and the LTG cards that traveled far beyond anything you published. It also lives in **Starling Initiatives** (your current collective, imprint, courses, and trainings), in the **Cole-Slaw blog** archive, in self-published audiobooks you narrate yourself,

and in your teaching at **Kairos Pacific University**. The 100 Movements work you co-founded with Alan Hirsch, Dave Rhodes, Will Mancini, and Jessie Cruickshank lives on its own org surface.

Credibility. It's high, and it's durable. You're one of the most-cited North American voices in the organic-church and church-multiplication conversation; your LTG was adapted by the International Mission Board, and practitioners like Curtis Sergeant and Steve Addison treat your work as foundational. The next generation of microchurch leaders now receives you as an elder voice. The issue was never authority — it's **visibility, connection, and reuse** after a long silence.

How it lives online now. As **scattered fragments**, and some of it has decayed. The CMA Resources domain lapsed; the blog has been dormant since 2017; the trade books sit on retailer and publisher pages; the Starling material is newer and not yet deeply interconnected; the talks and trainings live in many places at once. There is no single surface where "everything Neil has said and written about organic church, LTGs, DNA, and multiplication" is structured, linked, and easy to find — so the work doesn't **move** in the sense of circulating and compounding.

The NOTs the platform addresses directly. Your content is largely **not** structured and repurposed to live as findable digital content (talks and trainings → articles, book themes → courses); **not** reconnected after the lapse so the LTG, Greenhouse, DNA, and organic-church material visibly reference each other; **not** connected to a personalized assistant that reflects your voice and corpus; **not** optimized so searchers for "organic church," "Life Transformation Group," "disciple-making movement," or "house church" land on your material first; and **not** unified under one surface you own. The platform is built to speak to each of these — structure and repurpose, reconnection, an assistant that serves your voice, discoverability, and ownership — so the work can move again without asking you to rebuild a platform you deliberately set down.

Constraints

The constraints here are partly the ordinary ones — **time** is scarce because the work is in the room, with planters and disciples and students, not in content strategy — and partly distinctive to you. You spent thirteen years arguing, by your silence, that platform-building is not the point. So any work on visibility has to honor that conviction rather than contradict it: this is not "build your platform back." It's making the substantial body of work you've already given legible, connected, and findable for the people God is still sending to it, while you stay free to keep doing the quieter, more interior work — Pray, VIRAL, Journeys — that the late season has produced. Your decentralizing instinct is also a constraint in the best sense: anything that re-centers everything on a personality would cut against the grain of the LTG, the DNA, and the five gifts. A platform that reduces the lift — that structures, reconnects, and

amplifies what you already do, without re-centering it on you — addresses those constraints without asking you to become a different kind of leader than you've spent a lifetime refusing to be.

This document is a reflected understanding for Neil Cole, intended to be right to the point, true, and valuable. It is preliminary until reviewed and endorsed.

Welcome Letter

`docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/neil-cole/welcome-letter.md`

Neil

You have built one of the most operationally consequential bodies of work in North American church multiplication. Seventeen books across five trade publishers — Jossey-Bass, Baker, Tyndale Momentum, Thomas Nelson, and ChurchSmart Resources — anchored by Cultivating a Life for God, Organic Church, Church 3.0, Search & Rescue, Church Transfusion with Phil Helfer, and Primal Fire with Dezi Baker, Ed Waken, Helfer, and Paul Kaak. Twenty-seven years pastoring, planting, and training — from the Grace Brethren church in Alta Loma to Awakening Chapel in the smoking section of The Coffee Tavern to Church Multiplication Associates across fifty states and fifty-plus nations. Co-founder of 100 Movements with Hirsch, Rhodes, Mancini, and Cruickshank. Currently Professor of Church Development at Kairos Pacific University.

All of it is somewhere. None of it is in one place. The trade-house books live on the Jossey-Bass, Baker, Tyndale, and Thomas Nelson author pages, on Amazon, on Christianbook. The Starling Initiatives titles — Rising Tides, Pray, VIRAL, Journeys — sit on Amazon under their own imprint with self-narrated audiobooks. The 2010 Christianity Today response "Long Live the Organic Church" sits on the CT site. The 2022 Dallas Theological Seminary Missions and Evangelism Lectureship chapel sessions sit on DTS Voice as "The Harvest Starts with Compassion and Prayer," "Jesus' Instructions for Global Missions," and "Making Disciples Worth Multiplying." Recent guest appearances sit on each host's feed — Shifting Culture Episode 178 with Joshua Johnson, reChurch Podcast Episodes 13 and 14 with Justin and Brooke Knoop, KC Underground's Upside Down Kingdom with Brian Johnson and Cory, The Church Digital Podcast Episode 269 with Jeff Reed. The Verge talks sit on Verge Network. The Cole-Slaw blog sits at cole-slaw.blogspot.com with roughly two hundred and fifty posts, dormant since June 7, 2017. The relational layer is fragmented along the same seams — the Greenhouse alumni across fifty-plus countries live in your phone, the 100 Movements design-team correspondence lives in your inbox, the historical CMA Constant Contact list is presumed inactive, the Starling Initiatives private Facebook group is the one live small surface. Your co-design with Hirsch places you one collaborator-degree from most of the contemporary missional conversation, invisible to anyone reading cold. What is missing is the layer above all of this — the hub that lets a reader move from any one piece to every other, and that keeps people connected to your work when they leave the institutions that introduced them.

The largest pool of your work has never been published, and it is the pool most at risk of going unwritten. The judgment calls behind Greenhouse Story 1 and Story 2 — which case studies got cut, which moves you taught only in the room, which failures you let cohorts watch you name. The curation decisions behind the three DTS chapel sessions. The pastoral wisdom of twenty-five-plus years that began in Alta Loma and matured through Awakening Chapel. The thirteen-year season of silence in your own dates and specifics, with the parts you have not yet told on a podcast. This material lives in notebooks, in coaching calls, in the

back booths of coffee shops, in the same conversation having happened a thousand times with a thousand planters. For a practitioner whose formation has always happened in the room before it happened on the page, naming that recognition matters.

This is where Movemental's AI does work that was not previously possible. The research that produced this letter — the inventory just walked through — was compiled by AI sitting with your public corpus for the time it would have taken a human researcher weeks. The same approach now turns toward what is not yet public: AI-assisted interview transcripts, course-note extraction, conversation capture, dictation that becomes draft, draft that becomes essay. The tools are good enough now that the embodied layer can be surfaced at your pace rather than at the pace of a publishing house. The AI does not replace your voice. Every draft is yours to edit, refuse, or rewrite. The tools do the inventorying and the connective tissue. Authorship stays yours.

This is what the dashboard is built to do, and what we will do with you. First, aggregate. The seventeen books, the Christianity Today and DTS Voice articles, the podcast appearances, the Verge and Exponential talks, the legacy CMA Resources canon recovered from the Wayback Machine, the Greenhouse and LTG training materials, and the embodied material as you surface it — all pulled into one hub under your own name. Second, interconnect. Organic Church points at the LTG card points at the Greenhouse Story 1 outline points at the Upside Down Kingdom conversation with Rob Wegner's team and back at Organic Church, every connection a reader can actually follow. Third, repurpose. The Greenhouse becomes a public sequence; the dormant Cole-Slaw archive becomes a curated reader; the Primal Fire APEST material becomes a standalone pathway with Hirsch's 5Q beside it; the thirteen-year silence becomes a long-form essay series in your own voice rather than three scattered interview retellings. Fourth, amplify. SEO, network effects, the references that arrive once your work is findable in one place. The work this season is not authorship. It is translation of what you have already authored into a form practitioners can actually reach.

A year from now, <https://starlinginitiatives.com/about-us/> looks different. A topic hub on Organic Church gathers Organic Church, Church 3.0, Church Transfusion, the LTG card, the Greenhouse handbooks, and a current cohort sign-up under one heading. The Cole-Slaw archive sits curated and searchable under your name rather than dormant on Blogger. The Greenhouse exists as a public sequence with Cultivating a Life for God inside it as required reading. The DTS Voice articles cross-list back to your hub with pointers to the audio of each chapel session. A newsletter that did not exist before goes out monthly. A practitioner in Frisco, Texas, who has never heard of Church Multiplication Associates finds the LTG card on a Tuesday morning, starts a group of three that afternoon, and works back through Organic Church by the end of the month.

This is your next season. The work ahead is making the body of work you have already built reach the practitioners it was written for. Your role as Professor of Church Development at Kairos Pacific University does not contradict this; it is the reason this work has to happen now.

The undergraduates and graduate students you teach in Long Beach should be able to hand a younger planter a single link and know that what they find there is your actual voice, your actual frameworks, and your actual library. Right now they cannot.

— Movemental

Committed Voice

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/neil-cole/_misc/committed-voice.md

slug: neil-cole

display_name: Neil Cole

role: Founder, Starling Initiatives · Co-founder, 100 Movements

location_line: Long Beach, California

short_tagline: >-

Neil Cole wrote the books that put "organic church" into the missional vocabulary and built one of the most-cited church-multiplication networks in the U.S. before a thirteen-year silence.

themes:

- Organic Church
- Life Transformation Groups
- APEST & Five Gifts

credentials:

- Founder, Starling Initiatives — global collective and self-publishing imprint since 2018
- Founder, Church Multiplication Associates — twenty-year planting network across 50 states and 50+ nations
- Co-founder, 100 Movements — design team with Alan Hirsch, Dave Rhodes, Will Mancini, Jessie Cruickshank
- Professor of Church Development, Kairos Pacific University
- Founding Pastor, Awakening Chapel, Long Beach — 1999 organic-church prototype that seeded CMA

featured_works:

- Organic Church (Jossey-Bass, 2005)
- Church 3.0 (Jossey-Bass, 2010)
- Cultivating a Life for God (ChurchSmart Resources, 1999)
- Search & Rescue (Baker Books, 2008)
- Primal Fire (Tyndale Momentum, 2014)

primary_url: <https://starlinginitiatives.com/about-us/>

secondary_links:

- label: 100 Movements

href: <https://www.100movements.org/>

- label: Kairos Pacific University

href: <https://kairos.aeu.edu/team/neil-cole>

signature_frameworks:

- name: Life Transformation Group (LTG)

definition: A two-or-three-person, same-gender weekly unit built on Scripture reading, mutual confession, and prayer for the lost — Cole's foundational discipleship technology.

- name: DNA — Divine Truth, Nurturing Relationships, Apostolic Mission

definition: Cole's three-strand definition of a healthy church; any community carrying all three counts as church regardless of size or form.

- name: Organic Church Planters' Greenhouse

definition: A two-story training cycle Cole developed with Paul Kaak to incubate and multiply organic church planters.

- name: Five Gifts of Jesus (APEST)

definition: Cole's apostolic-chair reading of Ephesians 4's fivefold ministry, written into Primal Fire alongside Dezi Baker, Ed Waken, Phil Helfer, and Paul Kaak.

- name: Six Movement Competencies

definition: The original 100 Movements training stack co-designed in 2015 with Alan Hirsch, Dave Rhodes, Will Mancini, and Jessie Cruickshank.

lineage:

sources:

- Robert E. Logan

- Leonard Sweet

- Reggie McNeal

peers:

- alan-hirsch

- Phil Helfer

- Paul Kaak

- Dave Rhodes

- Will Mancini

- Jessie Cruickshank

- Felicity Dale

- Tony Dale

- Frank Viola

downstream:

- rob-wegner

- lucas-pulley

- Brian Sanders

- Steve Addison

- Curtis Sergeant

sources:

- README.md

- profile/biography.md

- profile/voice-analysis.md

- profile/identity.md

- network/organizations.md

- digital-presence/websites.md

research_completed_at: 2026-04-29

generated_at: 2026-05-20

Editorial bio

Neil Cole left a Grace Brethren pastorate in Alta Loma, California in 1999, started a church in the smoking section of a Long Beach coffeehouse called The Coffee Tavern, and named it Awakening Chapel. From that one community he and Phil Helfer built Church Multiplication Associates, the organization whose Life Transformation Group — a two-or-three-person Scripture, confession, and prayer unit — and Organic Church Planters' Greenhouse cycle shaped a generation of American church planters.

The nine-year publishing run that followed put him at the center of the missional conversation. *Organic Church* (Jossey-Bass, 2005) named the category; *Church 3.0* (Jossey-Bass, 2010), *Search & Rescue* (Baker, 2008), *Church Transfusion* (with Phil Helfer, Jossey-Bass, 2012), and *Primal Fire* (Tyndale Momentum, 2014) followed. In 2015 he co-founded 100 Movements with Alan Hirsch, Dave Rhodes, Will Mancini, and Jessie Cruickshank, the design team behind the six movement competencies.

Then, by his own account, God told him to stop. He kept the silence for thirteen years — no public speaking, no social media, no blogging — and re-emerged tentatively in 2024 on *Shifting Culture*, the *reChurch* Podcast, and KC Underground's *Upside Down Kingdom*. He continues to write quieter, more interior books — *Rising Tides*, *Pray*, *VIRAL*, *Journeys* — under his own Starling Initiatives imprint, and teaches Church Development at Kairos Pacific University in Long Beach.

Misc · Analysis-Content-Analysis

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/neil-cole/_misc/analysis-content-analysis.md

Content Analysis: Neil Cole

Status: Complete
Last updated: 2026-04-29
Confidence: HIGH on framework and theme extraction across the 17+ books and ~250 blog posts; MEDIUM on the legacy CMA Resources audio archive (much of which is now URL-broken).

The Three Layers of Cole's Body of Thought

Layer 1 — The Tools (operational frameworks)

The reproducible technologies Cole has placed into the hands of practitioners.

Tool	Year introduced	Primary book	Function
Life Transformation Group (LTG)	1999	Cultivating a Life for God	2-or-3-person discipleship cell; Scripture, accountability, prayer for non-Christians
Organic Church Planters' Greenhouse	early 2000s	Beyond Church Planting (2005) + training manual with Paul Kaak	Two-stage cohort training for organic church planters (Story 1 + Story 2)
DNA framework	early 2000s	Organic Church (2005)	The irreducible D / N / A package required for any "cell" of the church to be a church
Church 1.0 / 2.0 / 3.0 typology	2010	Church 3.0	Pre-Constantinian / post-Constantinian / contemporary-recovery typology
Five-fold APEST gift treatment	2014	Primal Fire	Apostle / Prophet / Evangelist / Shepherd / Teacher framework with five named co-thinkers
Six movement competencies	2015	(100 Movements design team)	Identity Declaring + 5 others
"Listen to Jesus and do what He says"	~2018	Starling Initiatives ethos	Foundational rule of the post-silence collective

Layer 2 — The Theological Spine

Theme	Key books	Anchor language
Christocentric ecclesiology	Organic Church, Church 3.0, One Thing	"The presence of Jesus among His people"
Multiplication-first sequencing	Organic Church, Search & Rescue, Cultivating a Life for God	"If we cannot multiply disciples..."
Anti-hierarchy leadership	Organic Leadership, Church Transfusion	"Leadership that rests on title is weak"
APEST / five-fold ministry	Primal Fire	Apostle / Prophet / Evangelist / Shepherd / Teacher
Egalitarian gender posture	Black Swan Effect contribution	Female apostolic and leadership inclusion
Spiritual formation / interior life	One Thing, Pray, VIRAL, Journeys	Love-shaped, intimacy-shaped, listening-shaped
Theology of obscurity	Pray, VIRAL, Journeys, post-silence interviews	"I never felt like Jesus left me. Everyone else did."
Pauline leadership development	Journeys to Significance, Journeys (2024)	Five-stage development; finishing well

Layer 3 — The Mature Voice (post-silence, 2018-present)

The Starling Initiatives publication series narrows the focus from movement-building to interior-listening:

- Rising Tides (2018) — navigating exponential change.
- Pray (2019/2022) — connecting with God in all of life.
- VIRAL (2021) — hearing God's voice in pandemic disruption.
- Journeys (2024) — discovering God's paths of spiritual formation; lessons from 13 years of silence.
- Primal Fire (2025 reissue) — bringing the APEST book back under his own imprint.

This third layer is **distinct in tone** from the first two and reflects a man who has become something other than the rapid-multiplication CMA executive director of 2008. The contemporary audience that picks up Cole today is most likely to enter through this layer first, and would be poorly served by a "buy Organic Church first" recommendation strategy.

Recurring Metaphor System

Metaphor	Where it shows up	What it does
Agriculture / farming / cultivation	Cultivating a Life for God, Organic Church, "good soil that produces movements" Verge talk	Slow, patient, life-shaped growth
Lifeguarding / search and rescue	Search & Rescue, Ordinary Hero	Disciple-making as urgent rescue, not church-growth
DNA / biology / genetic code	Organic Church, Primal Fire, Church Transfusion	Smallest reproducible unit must contain the whole
Fire / primal / elemental	Primal Fire	Recovery of original five-fold ministry
Tides / oceanography / exponential	Rising Tides	Future-proof faith in disruptive change
Family / household	"Family on mission together"	Ecclesial relational frame
Coffeehouse / Coffee Tavern	Founding of Awakening Chapel; Cultivating a Life for God origin story	Church happens where life happens
Coleslaw (raw, shredded, mixed-up, served cold)	Cole-Slaw blog tagline	Self-deprecating metabolism of his own thinking

Recurring Counterpoints

What Cole consistently argues against:

Counter-position	Where named
Attractional / megachurch / "Sundays as the metric"	Organic Church, Church 3.0, Church Transfusion
Hierarchy-as-leadership ("Senior Pastor" framing)	Organic Leadership, reChurch Ep. 14
Permanent institutional structures as the test of legacy	Church 3.0, 2010 Christianity Today response
Slow-multiplication / mature-disciples-first	Frank Viola joint interview 2010
CEO / corporation grammar for church leadership	Organic Church, Organic Leadership
Title-based authority	Organic Church, Primal Fire
Platform-building economy	Post-silence interviews 2024-2025
Cessationist readings of APEST	Primal Fire

Themes That Have Aged Well (worth surfacing for 2026 audiences)

1. **The "lower the bar of how church is done, raise the bar of discipleship"** framing. This sentence is 16 years old and still cuts.
2. **The Life Transformation Group.** Two or three people, weekly, Scripture + accountability + prayer for non-Christians. It works as well in 2026 as it did in 1999, and is structurally identical to what contemporary microchurch and DMM practitioners are recommending.
3. **The DNA framework.** Lightweight; memorable; reproducible.
4. **Theology of obscurity.** The single most-resonant theme for the post-burnout / post-deconstruction generation.
5. **The KCU + Cole bridge.** The 2025 Upside Down Kingdom episode is doing real generational repair-work and Cole's contribution to it is fresh.

Themes That Have Aged Less Well (handle with care)

1. **CMA's "thousands of churches in 50+ nations"** statistical framing reads as 2008-era megachurch-style PR-by-numbers; Cole's 2024–2025 voice has self-corrected away from this; Movemental copy should as well.
2. **The "Constantine was the fall, organic is the recovery"** historical sweep. The 9Marks critique on this point is fair.
3. **Some of the Church 3.0 polemic against the institutional church.** The 2024–2025 voice is gentler and more inviting; lifting the older polemic into contemporary copy would mis-fit the subject.
4. **The 2010 organic-vs-attractional dichotomy.** Church Transfusion (2012) already softened this; Cole now consistently positions as integrative rather than oppositional.

Content Velocity Across Eras

Era	Books / year	Blog cadence	Public-event cadence
1999	1 (debut)	none	low
2005–2010	~1.5	high (Cole-Slaw 2007–)	very high
2011–2014	~1.5	high	very high
2015	1 (last trade-house book)	declining	high
2016–2017	0	tail-end (last post 2017-06-07)	declining
2018–2022	~0.4 (Starling self-published only)	0	very low
2023–2025	1+ (Journeys 2024; Primal Fire reissue 2025)	0	rebuilding (DTS 2022, podcast cluster 2024–2025)

The visible "shape" of his content output is a **classic productivity bell curve with a long quiet tail and a recent re-emergence** — exactly the shape Movemental's ecosystem layer is designed to serve.

Implications for Movemental

1. **The right entry book for new readers in 2026 is Primal Fire or Organic Leadership, not Organic Church.** Organic Church is the historically important book; Primal Fire and Organic Leadership are the books that age best.
2. **The right secondary entry is Journeys (2024)** because it integrates the silence narrative with the Pauline-leadership-development frame.
3. **The most reproducible single asset is the LTG card.** Modernized, mobile-friendly, cross-platform, with a 5-minute video walkthrough by Cole — it is plug-and-play discipleship technology and would be a near-universal recruiting asset.
4. **The strongest editorial framing is "patriarch elder voice" not "next-generation thought leader."** Cole's contemporary voice is wisdom-toned, not platform-toned.

Open Questions

1. Are there published Cole frameworks beyond the catalog above that this audit has missed?
2. Is the "six movement competencies" of 100 Movements documented in a stable public-facing source, or only inside the 100 Movements training cohorts?
3. Has Cole written publicly about deconstruction or post-evangelicalism — themes adjacent to the burnout-recovery audience?
4. What does Cole's Journeys (2024) book say specifically about the silence period? (The book is the most likely place where the timeline and detail are written down in Cole's own voice.)

Misc · Media · Citations

`docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/neil-cole/_misc/media/citations.md`

Citations: Neil Cole

Status: Complete (with documented gaps)

Last updated: 2026-04-29

Confidence: HIGH on the major books and authors that cite Cole; MEDIUM on academic-journal-level citations (Cole is more cited in trade-published missional literature than in peer-reviewed journals).

Cole Cited In Major Trade Books

Citing book / author	How Cole is used
Alan Hirsch — The Forgotten Ways (2006, updated 2016)	Mutual endorsement; Cole's CMA referenced as paradigmatic missional / mDNA case
Lance Ford & Rob Wegner & Alan Hirsch — The Starfish and the Spirit (2021)	Decentralized leadership lineage downstream of Cole's Organic Leadership
Brian Sanders — Underground Church (Zondervan, 2019)	Cole as named endorser; structural debt to LTG and decentralized ecclesiology
Steve Addison — Movements That Change the World (IVP, 2011) and follow-ups	Cole as foundational disciple-making-movement practitioner
Curtis Sergeant — The Only One	LTG and reproducible-discipleship principles directly inherited
Felicity Dale (ed.) — The Black Swan Effect (2014)	Cole as named contributor
Frank Viola — Reimagining Church (2008) and Beyond Evangelical blog	Conversation partner; structural agreement and disagreement noted
Robert E. Logan — Beyond Church Planting (2005, with Cole)	Co-author
Phil Helfer co-authored materials	Co-author
Hugh Halter writings	Peer; co-endorser of Sanders' Underground Church
Will Mancini — Church Unique and Auxano writing	Co-design relationship via 100 Movements
Mike Breen / 3dM materials	Adjacent via Dave Rhodes (former 3dM national team leader, now 100 Movements co-founder)
Tony & Felicity Dale — Simply Church / An Army of Ordinary People	Peer; House2House network
Wolfgang Simson — Houses That Change the World	Cole's predecessor / contemporary in simple-church stream

Cole Cited In Critical / Reformed Reviews

Critic / outlet	Context
9Marks (Mark Dever / Jonathan Leeman ecosystem)	3 published critical reviews (Organic Church, Church 3.0, Church Transfusion) — see media/reviews.md
Mark Galli, Christianity Today	"Long Live Organic Church!" SoulWork column 2010 — Cole responded (see content/articles.md)
Various Reformed bloggers (chosenrebel.me, lifeandleadership.com book summaries)	Multiple book summaries / reviews

Cole Cited In Academic / Seminary Contexts

- **Dallas Theological Seminary 2022 Lectureship** — Cole as the lectureship voice (institutional citation by invitation)
- **Kairos Pacific University** — Cole as Professor of Church Development
- **D.Min. and Ph.D. dissertations** — comprehensive count UNKNOWN; Cole's work is regularly assigned in missional ecclesiology, simple/house church, and disciple-making movement courses at Fuller, Asbury, Talbot, Western Seminary, Trinity Evangelical, Bethel, and similar institutions
- **DAWN Ministries / Saturation Church Planting** — Michael Steele recommended Organic Church

Cole's Own Citation Practices

(Reverse direction — who Cole cites in his books.)

- **Roland Allen** (Missionary Methods: St. Paul's or Ours?, The Spontaneous Expansion of the Church) — foundational influence; cited across Organic Church and Cultivating a Life for God
- **Wolfgang Simson** — predecessor in simple-church
- **George Patterson** — CPM lineage
- **Robert E. Logan** — named mentor; cited in 2010 CT response
- **Ralph Winter** (missiologist) — quoted in 2010 CT response: "Risk is not to be evaluated in terms of the probability of success, but in terms of the value of the goal."
- **Alan Hirsch** — mutual citation
- **Frank Viola** — citation partner with public friction
- **T. Austin-Sparks** — historical "organic church" terminology source (per Viola interview)

Implications for Movemental

1. Cole is one of the **most-cited but least-curated** voices in the missional canon — heavy citation density, fragmented surface.
2. A canonical "Cole citations index" — every book, dissertation, article, and podcast that cites him, in one queryable surface — would serve both the academic and practitioner communities.
3. Cole's own citation practices reveal the **theological lineage** Movemental can responsibly hand him — Allen, Simson, Patterson, Logan, Hirsch, Winter — rather than benchmarking him against contemporary platform-author categories.

Open Questions

1. Comprehensive Google Scholar citation count for Cole's major books (Organic Church, Church 3.0, Primal Fire)?
2. Top 20 dissertations (D.Min. / Ph.D.) that cite Cole as a primary source?
3. Is there a CPM / DMM literature review that traces the LTG → CHAT → contemporary microchurch lineage?
4. International citations — has Cole's work been cited in non-English academic missiology (Korean, German, Brazilian Portuguese, Spanish, Mandarin)?

Misc · Media · Press-Coverage

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/neil-cole/_misc/media/press-coverage.md

Press Coverage: Neil Cole

Status: Complete (with documented gaps)

Last updated: 2026-04-29

Confidence: HIGH on the catalogued features; MEDIUM on the broader long-tail (Cole's 2005–2014 era likely produced 30–60 press hits across denominational and parachurch outlets; only the major ones surface easily).

Major Features

Charisma Magazine

Feature article on Neil Cole and Awakening Chapel / CMA — date approximately mid-2000s.

- Source confirmation: [GraceConnect / Charis Fellowship](#) — "Grace Brethren Pastor Neil Cole Featured in Charisma Magazine" (the GraceConnect post links to and summarizes the Charisma feature).
- Significance: This is the source for the widely-circulated "smoking section of The Coffee Tavern" Awakening Chapel founding story. The Charisma feature is the primary press source that put Cole's organic-church work in front of the broader Pentecostal / charismatic reading audience.
- **Exact issue date and article title:** UNKNOWN — needs research (the GraceConnect post archives the reference but the original Charisma article URL was not surfaced in this audit).

Leadership Network

Feature on Neil Cole — referenced via [GraceConnect](#) — "Neil Cole Featured by Leadership Network".

- Significance: Leadership Network is the parachurch body that owned the Jossey-Bass Leadership Network Series (publisher of Organic Church, Church 3.0, Journeys to Significance, Church Transfusion); a Leadership Network feature is roughly equivalent to a publisher-driven cover story.
- **Exact date and article URL:** UNKNOWN — needs research.

Christianity Today

Mark Galli — "Long Live Organic Church!" (SoulWork column, January 2010), followed by **Neil Cole** — "Long Live the Organic Church: A Response" (CT, January 12, 2010).

- URL: christianitytoday.com/ct/2010/januaryweb-only/12-21.0.html
- Significance: One of the most-cited public exchanges about the organic-church movement; Cole's response is one of the few Cole authored pieces that lives on a Tier-1 evangelical news outlet's website and is therefore one of the few stable archived articles in his footprint.

Outreach Magazine

"The Church Needs Skunk Works" — featured Cole's perspective.

- URL: outreachmagazine.com/features/5003-the-church-needs-skunk-works.html
- Topic: small experimental units of innovation inside larger institutions ("skunk works"); Cole's organic-church framework applied to conventional churches.

GraceConnect / Charis Fellowship

Multiple posts in the Charis Fellowship's GraceConnect publication tracking Cole's career milestones:

- "Grace Brethren Pastor Neil Cole Featured in Charisma Magazine"
- "Neil Cole Featured by Leadership Network"
- "Neil Cole Book on Organic Church Published" — charisfellowship.com/neil-cole-book-on-organic-church-published
- "People: Individuals Recognized for Outstanding Ministries"
- "The Weekend in Photos at Grace Brethren Churches"

These confirm Cole's denominational provenance (Fellowship of Grace Brethren Churches / Charis Fellowship) and demonstrate ongoing recognition by the denomination across his career.

Faith Radio

myfaithradio.com/authors/neil-cole/ — author/contributor index page; specific feature interviews UNKNOWN.

DTS Voice (Dallas Theological Seminary)

DTS Voice is institutionally a publication / video platform of DTS, not a press outlet per se; but the November 2022 lectureship coverage (voice.dts.edu/contributor/neil-cole) functions as institutional-academic press coverage.

Mention-Level Coverage (cited in third-party books, articles, and reviews)

Cole's books and frameworks are cited or reviewed in:

- **Steve Addison's books** (cited as a foundational practitioner)
- **Curtis Sergeant's The Only One** (downstream framework adoption)
- **Frank Viola's Beyond Evangelical blog** (joint Keith Giles 2010 interview)
- **Hirsch's Forgotten Ways** (mutual endorsement)
- **9Marks** (3 critical reviews, see [media/reviews.md](#))
- **Many D.Min. dissertations** at Fuller, Asbury, Talbot, Western Seminary (specific dissertations UNKNOWN)
- **Saturation Church Planting (DAWN)** literature
- **House2House** (Tony & Felicity Dale) materials
- **Verge Network** speaker rosters and printables

Pattern of Coverage

Press coverage parallels the books — 2005–2014 has the heaviest coverage; 2015–2022 is sparse; the 2022 DTS Lectureship and the 2024–2025 podcast cluster are the re-emergence.

No Tier-1 secular press coverage (NYT / WaPo / The Atlantic / Religion News Service profile) of Cole has been surfaced — his coverage is concentrated in evangelical-press circuits (Charisma, Leadership Network, Christianity Today, Outreach Magazine, Faith Radio, DTS Voice, GraceConnect).

Open Questions

1. Charisma Magazine feature — exact issue and article URL?
2. Leadership Network feature — exact date and content?
3. Has Religion News Service, The Christian Century, or Sojourners covered Cole? None surfaced in this audit.
4. Has any academic missiology journal (Mission Frontiers, International Journal of Frontier Missiology) profiled or interviewed Cole?
5. Has Cole appeared on any major secular religious-affairs media (NPR's On Being, BBC religion, etc.)? Almost certainly not given the silence period; pre-silence appearances UNKNOWN.

Misc · Media · Reviews

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/neil-cole/_misc/media/reviews.md

Reviews: Neil Cole

Status: Complete

Last updated: 2026-04-29

Confidence: HIGH on the major reviews catalogued; MEDIUM on the long-tail of blogger reviews from the 2008–2014 organic-church wave (hundreds exist; only the most influential are surfaced here).

Critical Reviews (Reformed / 9Marks angle)

The 9Marks ecosystem (Mark Dever / Jonathan Leeman / IX Marks publishing) reviewed three of Cole's books with consistent critique. The reviews are characteristically thorough and theologically explicit; they represent the **strongest substantive critique** of Cole's project from a confessionally Reformed angle.

9Marks — Organic Church (2005)

URL: 9marks.org/review/organic-church-neil-cole

Key critiques:

- **Weak biblical foundations** — Cole writes a chapter on church organization and leadership without engaging 1 Timothy 3 or other passages about church polity.
- **Historical oversimplification** — Paul's pattern of evangelism began in synagogues, not households; Cole's "early church was always organic" framing is not historically clean.
- **Definition of the church** — Cole's "presence of Jesus among His people, called out as a spiritual family to pursue His mission on this planet" is theologically partial; Protestant forebears would expect inclusion of right preaching, right administration of the sacraments, and church discipline.

9Marks — Church 3.0 (2010)

URL: 9marks.org/review/church-30

Key critiques:

- **Overstated historical claim** — Cole's framing that the organic church is "the biggest revolution since Constantine" is criticized as exaggerated.

- **Lowering the bar** — Cole's explicit "lowering of the bar of how church is done" allows high-school-students-in-a-living-room or small groups or campus fellowships to be classed as churches; the reviewer finds this a structural problem.
- **Disposability of churches** — Church 3.0 describes dozens of churches being planted and disbanded over a few weeks; the reviewer finds this incompatible with biblical ecclesiology.

9Marks — Church Transfusion (2012, with Phil Helfer)

URL: 9marks.org/review/church-transfusion

Key critiques:

- **Over-reliance on the DNA metaphor** — leaves no room for the role of polity, governance, and structured leadership.
- **Suspicion of preaching** — the reviewer reads Cole and Helfer as soft on the centrality of the preached gospel.
- **Doctrinal ambivalence** — the reviewer wants more doctrinal definition than Cole and Helfer offer.

Cole's response posture to the 9Marks reviews

Publicly **irenic and silent**. Cole has not, to public-record knowledge, written a sustained reply to 9Marks. His approach has been to keep doing the work and let the body of practice speak for itself. The 2010 Christianity Today response to Mark Galli is the closest Cole has come to a public-rebuttal posture, and even there his tone is gracious rather than polemical.

Mid-Range Critical Reviews (Reformed-adjacent / theologically engaged)

Reviewer / outlet	Book	Stance
Christopher Woznicki — cwoznicki.com	Primal Fire (2014)	Engaged; theologically careful
Tom Graves — tomgravesbookbites	Organic Church (2012)	Mostly favorable; descriptive
2timothy413ministry.wordpress.com	Organic Church (2014)	Favorable
The M Blog (Guy Muse)	Primal Fire (2014)	Favorable from a Latin American CPM perspective
Ten Filters	Primal Fire (2014)	Engaged
Coenology	Church 3.0 (2025 review)	Late-arriving review; Reformed angle
ChosenRebel's Blog	Organic Leadership (2010)	Reformed-skeptical
Pneuma Review (Michelle Vondey)	Organic Leadership	Pentecostal academic angle

Favorable Practitioner Reviews

Reviewer / outlet	Book	Stance
Jesus Dust (jesusdust.com)	Organic Church (2012)	Highly favorable
Kingdom Harbor	Organic Church (2010)	Favorable
Roger Thoman / Simple Church Journal	Organic Church (2006) and follow-ups	Highly favorable; insider-stream review
Simple Church Alliance	Multiple Cole titles	Favorable; ongoing aggregator
Justin Gravitt	Cultivating a Life for God	Favorable; named-mentor citation
Ivy Panda — student paper-style review	Organic Church	Favorable / academic-summary
Logan Leadership	Primal Fire	Favorable; co-author/co-publisher
Bookey, Life and Leadership, Eden	Multiple Cole titles	Summary / favorable retail-style

Goodreads Aggregate Sentiment

Book	Rating count	Avg rating
Organic Church (2005)	996	3.90
Cultivating a Life for God (1999)	164	—
Search & Rescue (2008)	71	—
Organic Leadership (2009)	164	3.83
Church 3.0 (2010)	223	4.00
Journeys to Significance (2011)	62	—
Ordinary Hero (2011)	17	—
Church Transfusion (2012)	37	—
Primal Fire (2014)	112	4.21 (highest)
One Thing (2015)	22	—
Rising Tides (2018)	16	—
PRAY (2019/2022)	29	—
VIRAL (2021)	2	—
Cumulative	2,062	3.99 avg across 60 distinct works

Source: [goodreads.com/author/show/249457.Neil_Cole](https://www.goodreads.com/author/show/249457.Neil_Cole) and [goodreads.com/author/list/249457.Neil_Cole](https://www.goodreads.com/author/list/249457.Neil_Cole).

Pattern of Reception

- **Practitioner reception:** Strongly favorable across the simple/house/organic-church and DMM/CPM streams. Cole's books are foundational reading inside these streams.
- **Reformed reception:** Consistently critical; concerns center on ecclesiology, sacraments, and the "lowering the bar" framing.
- **Mainstream evangelical reception:** Generally favorable; Christianity Today, Outreach Magazine, and Charisma all gave Cole positive coverage.
- **Mainline / progressive reception:** Sparse; Cole has not been a regular subject in Christian Century, Sojourners, or other mainline / progressive publications.
- **Academic missiology reception:** Cole is cited rather than reviewed; he is a practitioner-input to academic literature, not a target of peer-review.

Implications for Movemental

1. Movemental can lean confidently into Cole's **practitioner credentials** (large CMA reach, IMB/Saddleback adoption, three-decade running track record) without overselling him as an academic theologian.
2. The **9Marks critique is the most coherent counter-position** to Cole's framework and Movemental copy that wants to be honest should acknowledge it (rather than pretend it does not exist). The 9Marks critique strengthens, rather than weakens, the case for Cole as a serious thinker — these reviews are written precisely because Cole is taken seriously.
3. The **Goodreads pattern (4.21 on Primal Fire; 4.00 on Church 3.0; 3.90 on Organic Church)** suggests that Cole's later, more decentralized-leadership-focused work has aged better with readers than his early polemic-against-institutional work. This argues for re-anchoring contemporary Cole copy on Primal Fire / Organic Leadership / Church Transfusion rather than on Organic Church.

Misc · Network · Collaborators

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/neil-cole/_misc/network/collaborators.md

Collaborators: Neil Cole

Status: Complete

Last updated: 2026-04-29

Confidence: HIGH on direct co-authors and 100 Movements design team; MEDIUM on the broader collaborative network (much of it sits in personal correspondence and conference handshakes rather than published collaborations).

Direct Co-Authors

Phil Helfer

- **Relationship:** Co-founder of Church Multiplication Associates (CMA); pastor of Los Altos Grace Church.
- **Co-authored book:** Church Transfusion: Changing Your Church Organically — From the Inside Out (Jossey-Bass, 2012).
- **Other collaborations:** Foundations of Organic Leadership CMA Resources audio set; Primal Fire (2014) — Helfer carried the "Shepherding" gift in the five-author construct.
- **Significance:** Cole's longest and deepest co-authorship relationship.

Paul Kaak

- **Relationship:** Co-architect of the Organic Church Planters' Greenhouse curriculum.
- **Co-authored book:** Organic Church Planters' Greenhouse (training manual, with Cole).
- **Other collaborations:** Primal Fire (2014) — Kaak carried the "Teaching" gift.

Robert (Bob) E. Logan

- **Relationship: Cole's named mentor.** Logan is the former church-planter, Fuller Seminary teaching faculty, and executive director of CoachNet International.
- **Co-authored book:** Beyond Church Planting: Pathways for Emerging Churches (ChurchSmart, 2005), with Holly Morgan, Julie Becker, and Michelle Dodd; contributing authors Mike Perkinson and Tom Johnston.
- **Other collaborations:** Raising Leaders for the Harvest (also co-authored).
- **Quoted in:** Cole's 2010 Christianity Today response: "Success is finding out what God wants you to do and doing it." — attributed to Logan.

- **Significance:** One of the most-named relationships in Cole's public commentary; the elder/coach voice in his career.

Ed Waken

- **Relationship:** CMA-team trainer, based in Phoenix and Los Angeles.
- **Co-authored book:** Primal Fire (2014) — Waken carried the "Evangelistic" gift.
- **Other collaborations:** Greenhouse training co-trainer (Frisco 2011); ReTooling Leadership series author on legacy CMA Resources.

Dezi Baker

- **Relationship:** Five-author Primal Fire (2014) co-thinker — carried the "Prophetic" gift.

Ross Rohde

- **Relationship:** CMA-team partner.
- **Collaboration:** Apostolic Leadership in Organic Church Movements CMA Resources MP3 set with Cole.

Holly Morgan, Julie Becker, Michelle Dodd

- **Relationship:** Co-authors on Beyond Church Planting (2005). All three brought ChurchSmart / coaching / women-leadership perspectives to the Logan + Cole project.

Mike Perkinson

- **Relationship:** Contributing author on Beyond Church Planting (2005).

Tom Johnston

- **Relationship:** Contributing author on Beyond Church Planting (2005).

Reggie McNeal

- **Relationship:** Listed alongside Cole on the Shapevine paperback edition of Organic Leadership (Baker, 2010).
- **Significance:** McNeal's The Present Future and Cole's Organic Leadership sit in the same Baker / Shapevine series and are sometimes packaged together.

100 Movements Design Team (2015)

Name	Role	Cole connection
Alan Hirsch	Co-founder; primary thought leader for missional / mDNA framework	Mutual endorser of The Forgotten Ways and Organic Church (2005–2006); now formal co-design relationship from 2015
Dave Rhodes	Co-founder; "amazing toolmaker, trainer and coach"; former national team leader of 3dM (Mike Breen's missional-discipleship organization)	Brings the 3dM Forge-adjacent stream into the 100 Movements design
Will Mancini	Co-founder; brand / vision strategist (Auxano, Church Unique)	Brought the design / strategy framework
Jessie Cruickshank	Co-founder; Harvard-trained learning expert	Brought instructional-design rigor
Neil Cole	Co-founder; named "perhaps [having] led a multiplication movement more than any single practitioner in the United States"	Brought the multiplication / LTG / Greenhouse content

The Black Swan Effect (2014) Co-Contributors

Edited by Felicity Dale. Contributors include Cole + the following:

- **Felicity Dale** (House2House co-founder; editor)
- **Tony Dale** (House2House co-founder)
- **Peggy Batcheller-Hijar**
- **Jan Diss**
- **Katie Driver**
- **Dave Ferguson** (Community Christian Church / NewThing / Exponential)
- **Michael Frost** (Forge / Morling College / The Shaping of Things to Come)
- **Alan Hirsch**
- **Suzette Lambert**
- **Floyd McClung** (All Nations / formerly YWAM)

This 2014 volume is one of the densest single-source intersection points in Cole's collaborative network.

Long-Time Peers (no formal co-authorship; mutual referencing across decades)

Felicity Dale and Tony Dale (House2House)

- Co-contributors on The Black Swan Effect; Cole featured in House2House's video training series; both Dales are simple/house-church peers from the same era.

Frank Viola

- Joint Keith Giles interview, 2010 (frankviola.org); explicit conversation partner. Public friction over multiplication-speed (Cole rapid; Viola mature-first), described by Viola himself as: "Neil and I have a number of good mutual friends, and I have a lot of respect for him and am thankful for his contribution to the body of Christ."

Wolfgang Simson

- Houses That Change the World (1998) author. Endorsed Cole's organic-church work; predecessor voice in the simple-church stream.

George Patterson

- Pioneer of Church Planting Movements (CPM) thinking in Latin America; foundational influence on Cole's multiplication framework. (Direct collaboration UNKNOWN; lineage UNCONFIRMED but heavily implied by SERP and the broader missional-CPM literature.)

Roland Allen

- Early-20th-century missiologist (Missionary Methods: St. Paul's or Ours?; The Spontaneous Expansion of the Church). Not a contemporary, but a foundational influence cited across Cole's Organic Church. (Influence relationship, not collaboration.)

Steve Addison

- Cole peer in the disciple-making-movements / church-planting-movements stream. Cole's work cited across Addison's Movements That Change the World (IVP, 2011), Pioneering Movements, and Rise and Fall of Movements.

Curtis Sergeant

- Former Saddleback director of church planting; adapted Cole's LTG into the IMB's CHAT tool; Sergeant's The Only One draws extensively on Cole's reproducible-discipleship principles.

Brian Sanders

- Founder of Underground Network (Tampa). Cole was a named endorser of Sanders' Underground Church (Zondervan, 2019), alongside Dave Ferguson, Michael Frost, Linda Bergquist, Peyton Jones, Hugh Halter, and Felicity Dale.

Rob Wegner

- KC Underground founder. Hosted Cole on Upside Down Kingdom podcast in 2025. Wegner's Starfish and the Spirit (2021, with Hirsch and Ford) sits downstream of Cole's Organic Leadership and Church 3.0.

Brian Johnson (KCU)

- Co-host (with Cory) of KC Underground's Upside Down Kingdom — direct relationship with Cole established in 2025.

Hugh Halter

- Forge / Sentralized peer; co-endorser with Cole on Brian Sanders' Underground Church.

Dave Ferguson

- Community Christian Church / NewThing / Exponential founder; co-contributor on Black Swan Effect; co-endorser on Underground Church; long Exponential conference circuit overlap.

Michael Frost

- Forge / Shaping of Things to Come; co-contributor on Black Swan Effect; co-endorser on Underground Church; mutual endorsements across the missional canon.

Floyd McClung

- All Nations / formerly YWAM; co-contributor on Black Swan Effect.

Bill Hull

- Discipleship voice (The Disciple Making Pastor; The Complete Book of Discipleship); peer in the disciple-making conversation. Direct collaboration UNKNOWN.

Mike Breen

- 3dM founder. Indirect — Cole's 100 Movements co-founder Dave Rhodes was 3dM's former national team leader.

Bob Roberts Jr.

- Glocalnet / Northwood Church; peer in the church-planting conversation. Direct collaboration UNKNOWN.

Ed Stetzer

- Missiologist; peer in the missional / church-multiplication conversation. Direct collaboration UNKNOWN; mutual endorsement plausible but not confirmed in this audit.

Leonard Sweet

- Wrote the **foreword to Organic Church** (Jossey-Bass, 2005). Direct foreword relationship — significant.

Francis Chan

- Wrote the **foreword to Church 3.0** (Jossey-Bass, 2010). Direct foreword relationship.

Jim Montgomery / Michael Steele (DAWN Ministries)

- Steele was the North American director of DAWN; recommended Cole's Organic Church. Saturation-church-planting / DAWN tradition.

Dan Kimball, Reggie McNeal, Larry Walkemeyer, Todd Wilson, Bobby Harrington

- Plausible Exponential / 100M / Discipleship.org peers. Specific Cole-collaborator relationships UNKNOWN.

Long-Time Mentees

The clearest **downstream mentees / inheritors of Cole's framework** (by their own attribution or by structural derivation):

- **Curtis Sergeant** — IMB / Saddleback; direct framework adoption.
- **Brian Sanders** — Underground Network; structural debt to LTG and decentralized ecclesiology.
- **Rob Wegner** — KC Underground; structural debt to Organic Leadership and Church 3.0; explicit elder treatment in 2025.
- **Lucas Pulley** — Tampa Underground; indirect via Sanders.
- **Brian Johnson** — KC Underground co-host; podcast-host relationship in 2025.

Implications for Movemental

1. **The Helfer / Kaak / Waken / Rohde "CMA inner ring"** is the deepest reservoir of Cole-collaborator content. If Movemental wanted to extend Cole's reach, **bringing Helfer and Kaak into the conversation** would extend the surface area without asking Cole to carry it solo.
2. **The 100 Movements design team is a natural Movemental panel.** Hirsch + Cole + Rhodes + Mancini + Cruickshank, in conversation, would be a near-unprecedented missional-design intellectual gathering and is logistically achievable because the original 2015 collaboration is documented.
3. **The Cole + Hirsch dyad is undercounted in the master graph.** The mutual-endorsement edge is real but weak; the 100 Movements co-founder edge is strong (weight 5) and should be added. Black Swan Effect (2014) is a third co-publication edge.
4. **The Cole + Sanders endorsement chain + the Cole + Wegner KCU 2025 podcast + the Sanders → Pulley → KCU/Tampa Underground lineage** make Cole a cross-cluster bridge from the Hirsch/100M cluster (Cluster 1) to the Underground/Exponential cluster (Cluster 5) — a position the master graph currently does not capture.

Open Questions

1. Did Cole and Frank Viola maintain any working relationship after 2010? Their public friction is well-documented; current state UNKNOWN.
2. What is the current status of Phil Helfer's Los Altos Grace Church and his ongoing relationship with Cole?
3. Has Cole written or endorsed for Wegner's Starfish and the Spirit (2021)? Direct endorsement record UNKNOWN.
4. Where does Cole sit relative to **Discipleship.org** (Bobby Harrington's organization) and the broader disciple-making conversation today?
5. Beyond Bob Logan, who else does Cole publicly name as a mentor figure?

Misc · Network · Endorsements

`docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/neil-cole/_misc/network/endorsements.md`

Endorsements: Neil Cole

Status: Complete (with documented gaps)

Last updated: 2026-04-29

Confidence: HIGH on the major endorsements catalogued here; LOW on the long-tail of book blurbs (Cole has likely endorsed dozens of books over 25 years; only the highest-visibility ones have been surfaced).

Endorsements RECEIVED (on Cole's books)

Organic Church (Jossey-Bass, 2005)

- **Foreword:** Leonard Sweet.
- **Cover endorsement:** Alan Hirsch (then director of Forge Mission Training Network and author of *The Shaping of Things to Come*) — "Neil Cole is one of the foremost thinkers and practitioners [of] organic forms of church. His vision of the church is as new as it is ancient. Cole's story as well as the philosophy of Church Multiplication Associates is paradigmatic for the church as it seeks to negotiate its way faithfully into the twenty-first century."
- Other endorsements UNKNOWN — needs research; the back cover and front matter would yield the full set.

Church 3.0 (Jossey-Bass, 2010)

- **Foreword:** Francis Chan.
- Other endorsements UNKNOWN.

Primal Fire (Tyndale Momentum, 2014)

- Endorsed within the missional / APEST community; specific endorser list UNKNOWN.

Search & Rescue (Baker, 2008)

- Endorsements UNKNOWN.

Organic Leadership (Baker, 2009)

- **Reggie McNeal** is named as a contributing voice on the Shapevine paperback edition — closer to a co-billing than a blurb endorsement.

Beyond Church Planting (with Bob Logan, 2005)

- Co-authorship more than endorsement.

Endorsements GIVEN (by Cole, on others' books)

Alan Hirsch — The Forgotten Ways (original 2006 / updated 2016)

Cole has endorsed both editions. Verified language:

- Original 2006: "a seminal work that will change our thinking, our vocabulary, and hopefully our way of being the church in this new century" and "I have already read the book twice and will probably devour it again."
- Updated 2016: "a road map for missional movements... been updated with even more insight and ten more years of learning." (Cole identified as "Movement Catalyst and author of Organic Church, Church 3.0, and Primal Fire.")

Significance: One of the most-quoted Cole endorsements; appears in Hirsch's most-distributed book; serves as a mutual-endorsement anchor for the master network graph.

Brian Sanders — Underground Church (Zondervan, 2019)

Cole is one of seven named endorsers on the Underground Network book site (undergroundnetwork.org/undergroundchurchbook). The full endorser list:

- **Dave Ferguson**
- **Linda Bergquist**
- **Michael Frost**
- **Peyton Jones**
- **Neil Cole**
- **Hugh Halter**
- **Felicity Dale**

Significance: The Underground / Tampa Underground lineage that produced Brian Sanders → Lucas Pulley → Joel Repic → Tomy Wilkerson treats Cole as a foundational elder voice. This is the bridge edge into the Underground / KCU cluster.

House2House materials (Tony & Felicity Dale)

Cole featured in the House2House Video Training Series; relationship is closer to ongoing collaboration than one-off endorsement.

The Black Swan Effect (Felicity Dale, ed., 2014)

Cole as named contributor (a chapter is more than an endorsement; included here for completeness).

Other plausible endorsements (NOT VERIFIED in this audit)

Given Cole's stature in the missional canon, he has almost certainly written cover-blurb endorsements for many of the books in his network. Plausible candidates:

- Steve Addison's *Movements That Change the World* (IVP, 2011) and subsequent CPM titles
- Curtis Sergeant's *The Only One*
- Lance Ford / Rob Wegner / Hirsch's *The Starfish and the Spirit* (2021)
- Various 100 Movements Publishing titles
- Various Exponential / Discipleship.org / Verge co-authored church-planting books

None of these specific endorsements were directly verified by this audit. **The endorsement archaeology is a high-value low-effort research follow-up.**

Mutual Endorsement Pairs (verified)

Pair	Direction	Books
Cole ↔ Alan Hirsch	Both directions	Hirsch endorses <i>Organic Church</i> (2005); Cole endorses <i>Forgotten Ways</i> (2006, 2016)
Cole ↔ Felicity Dale	Both directions (mutual contributor)	<i>Black Swan Effect</i> (Dale ed., 2014); House2House video training series

Foreword Relationships (received)

Forewriter	Cole book	Year
Leonard Sweet	<i>Organic Church</i>	2005
Francis Chan	<i>Church 3.0</i>	2010

These are two highly visible foreword relationships — Sweet was Drew University's E.W. Hahn Distinguished Professor and a major emergent / postmodern-Christianity voice in the 2000s; Chan was at the height of *Crazy Love* (2008) cultural reach when he wrote the *Church 3.0* foreword in 2010.

Forewords / Introductions Given (by Cole)

UNKNOWN — needs research. Cole has plausibly written forewords for books by Helfer, Kaak, Waken, Rohde, or other CMA-team authors; for House2House volumes; or for 100 Movements Publishing titles. None directly verified.

Implications for Movemental

1. **The Hirsch + Cole mutual-endorsement edge is the single most important relational fact for any Movemental copy positioning the two leaders as peers, not as Hirsch-and-his-followers.** They have endorsed each other's signature books multiple times across two decades.
2. **The Cole + Sanders endorsement** is the most direct evidence of his bridge into the contemporary Underground / KCU / Tampa cluster.
3. **A complete endorsement-archaeology pass** (manually working through the front matter of every book in his network) would surface 10–30 additional edges and is high-value.
4. **The Sweet and Chan forewords** show that Cole's trade-publishing era reached well beyond the missional bubble — into emergent / postmodern (Sweet) and youth-revivalist evangelical (Chan) audiences.

Open Questions

1. Has Cole endorsed any of the following: Starfish and the Spirit, The Only One, Pioneering Movements, Underground Movement, any book by Wegner, Pulley, Sanders' subsequent works, or the 100 Movements Publishing list?
2. Did Cole contribute a foreword to any Helfer / Kaak / Waken book?
3. Full endorser list on Cole's own books (Organic Church, Church 3.0, Primal Fire) — currently only Hirsch (on Organic Church) and the Sweet/Chan forewords are verified.
4. Has Cole endorsed any of the recent Movement Leaders Collective publications or Bobby Harrington / Discipleship.org publications?

Misc · Network · Events

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/neil-cole/_misc/network/events.md

Events & Speaking History: Neil Cole

Status: Complete (with documented gaps)

Last updated: 2026-04-29

Confidence: HIGH on events with named primary sources; LOW on the long-tail (Cole has spoken at hundreds of events 1999–2014 and most are not catalogued in any public database).

Major Conferences (catalogued)

2007 — Organic Church Movements Conference

- **Where:** Likely Long Beach / Southern California
- **Cole's session:** "Why Didn't I Take the Blue Pill? The Dark Side of Organic Church" — a self-critical reflection on the failure modes of organic / simple-church practice
- **Where to find:** Legacy CMA Resources video (URL now broken; Wayback archive)
- **Significance:** Cole's most candid public self-critique; should be recovered.

2010 — Verge Network — "What Is a Missional Community?"

- **Date:** December 29, 2010 (printable + companion video)
- **Audience:** Verge Conference network
- **URL:** vergenetwork.org/2010/12/29/neil-cole-what-is-a-missional-community-printable/

2011 — Exponential 2011: "On the Verge" (Orlando)

- **Cole's role:** Speaker
- **Theme:** Encouraged leaders to help their people "see" the mission of Jesus
- **Significance:** Cole's most-cited Exponential appearance; Hirsch and Ferguson's On the Verge book also published 2011.

2011 — Frisco, TX — Organic Church Planters' Greenhouse 1

- **Date:** January 2011
- **Cole's role:** Co-trainer (with Ed Waken)
- **Attendance:** ~75 participants

- **Source:** brucedickey.wordpress.com/2011/01/21/organic-church-planters-greenhouse-1-frisco-tx/

2012 — Virginia Mennonite Conference — Greenhouse training

- **Source:** virginiaconference.org/2012/09/organic-church-planters-greenhouse/

2013 — Verge Network teaching segments

- Multiple segments referenced; specific event dates UNKNOWN.

2013 — Simple Church Conference

- Speaker; specific session UNKNOWN.

2015 — 100 Movements launch (announced Nov 2015 by Will Mancini)

- Co-founder / design-team appearance; specific public events UNKNOWN.
- First "Leap Year" cohort scheduled for spring 2016.

2022 — Dallas Theological Seminary, Missions and Evangelism Lectureship

- **Dates:** November 1, 3, 4, 2022
- **Three chapel sessions:**
 - "The Harvest Starts with Compassion and Prayer"
 - "Jesus' Instructions for Global Missions"
 - "Making Disciples Worth Multiplying"
- **All three published as articles + chapel videos:** voice.dts.edu/contributor/neil-cole
- **Significance:** First major institutional academic engagement post-silence; signals re-emergence beginning around 2022.

Additional Contemporary / Recent Engagements (re-emergence era)

Event / Show	Date	Format
Shifting Culture podcast Ep. 178	April 26, 2024	Podcast guest
reChurch Podcast Ep. 13	December 31, 2024	Podcast guest
reChurch Podcast Ep. 14	January 7, 2025	Podcast guest
KC Underground Upside Down Kingdom	August 2025	Podcast guest
The Church Digital Ep. 269	April 24, 2023	Podcast guest
The Team Leadership Podcast	~2022	Podcast guest
Dare to Multiply Ep. 60	UNKNOWN	Podcast guest
More Disciples Podcast	UNKNOWN	Podcast guest

Likely / Plausible Events Not Yet Catalogued

Given Cole's stature 2005–2014, these conferences almost certainly include him on their historical roster but specific dates / sessions are UNKNOWN in this audit:

- **Catalyst Conference** (Atlanta) — likely speaker 2006–2014
- **Mosaix Global Network** events
- **Saturate / Soma** events
- **Forge Mission Training Network** Australia / U.S. events (likely as adjacent peer not Forge faculty)
- **Sentralized Conference** (Brisco / Ford / Kansas City) — peer adjacency
- **Lausanne Movement** consultations
- **Movement Day (NYC)** — likely speaker
- **Saddleback Church / PEACE Plan** training
- **3dM (Mike Breen) "Learning Communities"** — peer adjacency via Dave Rhodes
- Multiple **NewThing / Exponential / Discipleship.org / Verge** annual events 2008–2014

A canonical conference catalog for Cole would require manually scraping the Wayback Machine archives of the legacy CMA Resources "Greenhouse Happenings" calendar plus the Exponential / Verge / Mosaix conference rosters.

Pattern of Engagement

The events catalog reveals the same arc as the books:

- **2005-2014:** Heavy public conference + training-cohort cadence. Mass-trained at Greenhouse cohorts (Frisco 2011, Virginia 2012, plus many uncatalogued); spoke regularly at Verge and Exponential and Simple Church Conference.
- **2015-2021:** Visible thinning. The 100 Movements launch (Nov 2015) is the last public-cadence high; afterward, public events are very few in the catalogued record.
- **2022 onward:** Re-emergence beginning at DTS (Nov 2022), then podcast cluster (2023 → 2025).

Implications for Movemental

1. **A Movemental annual or biennial cohort gathering with Cole as anchor teacher** would slot naturally into his current re-emergence cadence — small, conversational, listening-shaped, host-led.
2. **A 100 Movements 10-year reunion / panel** (Hirsch + Cole + Rhodes + Mancini + Cruickshank, 2025-2026) is logistically feasible and would be a near-unprecedented missional-design event.
3. **Recovering and re-publishing the 2007 "Dark Side of Organic Church" talk** is a high-value low-effort archive move.
4. **The DTS Lectureship template** is the right model — three sessions, conversational, published as articles afterward — for a future Movemental academic engagement.

Open Questions

1. Full Greenhouse cohort calendar 1999-2018 — total cohort count, geographic distribution, alumni network size?
2. Full Exponential / Verge / Catalyst / Mosaix appearance roster?
3. Has Cole spoken internationally (Australia, UK, Asia, Latin America)? CMA's "50+ nations" claim implies international travel; specific events UNKNOWN.
4. What was the last major in-person conference where Cole was the headline speaker before the silence? (Tentative answer: Exponential 2014 or Tyndale Momentum's Primal Fire book launch tour 2014; needs verification.)

Misc · Network · Network-Summary

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/neil-cole/_misc/network/network-summary.md

Network Summary: Neil Cole

Generated 2026-04-29 by the `network-map` skill. Edges sourced from docs/movement_leader_research/network/network-map.md, the master TAM list, and verified against docs/movement_leader_research/neil-cole/.

TAM rank: 6 of 146 (score 92, cluster: organic-church)
Connections (currently mapped in master graph): 1 edge (Hirsch mutual endorsement, weight 3)
Connections surfaced by this dossier: ~25 candidate edges; ~15 high-confidence to add
Primary cluster: Organic Church / Simple Church / 100 Movements — bridges Cluster 1 (Hirsch constellation), Cluster 5 (Exponential / Underground / Microchurch), and the simple/house/DMM stream that the master map treats as adjacent rather than as a numbered cluster.
Bridge status: Major bridge — connects Cluster 1, Cluster 5, the DMM/CPM ecosystem, and the simple/house/Underground stream

Currently in the Master Graph

Connected To	Type	Wt	Evidence
Alan Hirsch	Book endorsement (mutual)	3	Hirsch endorses Organic Church (2005); Cole endorses Forgotten Ways original (2006) and updated edition (2016).

Total weight currently: 3.

Proposed Additions (high-confidence, ready to commit to graph)

Connected To	Type	Wt	Evidence
Alan Hirsch	Co-founded org	5	100 Movements design team, Nov 2015 (Will Mancini blog post). This upgrades the existing weight-3 endorsement edge to a stronger combined relationship.
Alan Hirsch	Co-contributor (volume)	3	The Black Swan Effect (Felicity Dale ed., 2014) — Cole and Hirsch both contributed chapters.
Phil Helfer	Co-founder of CMA + co-author	5	Co-founder of Church Multiplication Associates; co-author of Church Transfusion (Jossey-Bass, 2012); co-author of Foundations of Organic Leadership CMA Resources audio set; co-thinker (Shepherding) on Primal Fire (2014).
Paul Kaak	CMA partner + co-author	5	Co-architect of Organic Church Planters' Greenhouse (training manual); co-thinker (Teaching) on Primal Fire (2014).
Robert (Bob) E. Logan	Co-author + named mentor	5	Beyond Church Planting (ChurchSmart, 2005); Raising Leaders for the Harvest (also co-authored). Logan named as mentor in Cole's 2010 Christianity Today response .
Ed Waken	Co-trainer + co-thinker	4	Greenhouse co-trainer (Frisco TX 2011); co-thinker (Evangelistic) on Primal Fire; ReTooling Leadership series author at CMA Resources.
Dezi Baker	Co-thinker	3	Primal Fire (Prophetic).
Ross Rohde	CMA co-creator	3	Apostolic Leadership in Organic Church Movements CMA Resources MP3 set with Cole.
Dave Rhodes	100 Movements co-founder	5	Nov 2015 100M design team; brings 3dM lineage.
Will Mancini	100 Movements co-founder	5	Nov 2015 100M design team.
Jessie Cruickshank	100 Movements co-founder	5	Nov 2015 100M design team.
Felicity Dale	Co-contributor + ongoing peer	4	The Black Swan Effect (Felicity Dale ed., 2014); House2House video training series; long-time simple-church peer.
Tony Dale	Co-contributor	3	The Black Swan Effect (2014).
Michael Frost	Co-contributor	3	The Black Swan Effect (2014).
Dave Ferguson	Co-contributor + co-endorser	4	The Black Swan Effect (2014); both endorsers of Brian Sanders' Underground Church (2019).
Floyd McClung	Co-contributor	3	The Black Swan Effect (2014).
Brian Sanders	Endorsement (Cole endorses Sanders)	3	Cole named endorser of Sanders' Underground Church (Zondervan, 2019).
Hugh Halter	Co-endorser	2	Both named endorsers of Sanders' Underground Church (2019).
Peyton Jones	Co-endorser	2	Both named endorsers of Sanders' Underground Church (2019).

Connected To	Type	Wt	Evidence
Linda Bergquist	Co-endorser	2	Both named endorsers of Sanders' Underground Church (2019).
Rob Wegner	Hosted/featured on KCU podcast	3	KC Underground Upside Down Kingdom podcast, August 2025 — KCU receiving Cole as elder voice; Wegner's organization.
Brian Johnson	Podcast host of Cole	3	Co-host of KCU Upside Down Kingdom (Aug 2025).
Leonard Sweet	Wrote foreword	3	Foreword to Cole's Organic Church (Jossey-Bass, 2005).
Francis Chan	Wrote foreword	3	Foreword to Cole's Church 3.0 (Jossey-Bass, 2010).
Reggie McNeal	Co-billed contributor	2	Organic Leadership Shapevine paperback (Baker, 2010).
Curtis Sergeant	Downstream framework adoption	2	Cole's LTG → IMB CHAT; Sergeant's The Only One.
Steve Addison	Foundational citation	2	Multi-book citation lineage.

Estimated additional weight to add: ~70 across these edges. **New total weight:** ~73 (vs. current 3) — a 24× increase in mapped relational density.

Proposed Additions (medium-confidence, candidate but verify before commit)

Connected To	Type	Confidence	Evidence
Wolfgang Simson	Predecessor / endorser	MEDIUM	Houses That Change the World (1998) author endorsed Cole's organic-church work (per SERP).
Frank Viola	Conversation partner with friction	MEDIUM	2010 joint Keith Giles interview; mutual public reference; current state of relationship UNKNOWN.
Mike Breen	Adjacent via Dave Rhodes	MEDIUM	Indirect — Rhodes was 3dM national team leader.
Bob Roberts Jr.	Peer	LOW	Plausible peer in church-planting; specific tie UNKNOWN.
Ed Stetzer	Plausible peer	LOW	Stetzer is a known endorser elsewhere in the Hirsch orbit; specific Cole tie UNKNOWN.
Bobby Harrington (Discipleship.org)	Peer	LOW	Discipleship.org adjacency; specific tie UNKNOWN.

Shared Organizations

Organization	Other Mapped Leaders	Cole's Role
Church Multiplication Associates (CMA)	Phil Helfer, Paul Kaak, Ed Waken, Dezi Baker, Ross Rohde (none currently in master TAM list)	Founder & Executive Director (1999~2018)
Awakening Chapel	(founding congregation)	Founding pastor
Starling Initiatives	(small team; UNKNOWN)	Founder (~2018-)
100 Movements	Alan Hirsch, Dave Rhodes, Will Mancini, Jessie Cruickshank	Co-founder / design team (Nov 2015)
Movement Leaders Collective	Hirsch, Robinson, Woodward, Cotterills	Adjacent through 100M
Kairos Pacific University	(academic role; no other mapped leaders)	Professor of Church Development
Charis Fellowship (Grace Brethren)	(denominational origin)	Pastor of Grace Brethren church Alta Loma 1990s

Cluster Position

Cole sits at the **intersection of four clusters**:

1. **Cluster 1 — Hirsch Constellation**: Cole is a peer of Hirsch via mutual endorsement (2005–2016) and via co-design at 100 Movements (2015). The 100M tie should be a primary edge in the master graph.
2. **Cluster 5 — Exponential / NewThing / Underground**: Cole is an elder voice via the 2025 KCU appearance (Wegner / Brian Johnson), the 2019 Sanders endorsement, and the broader Underground Network lineage.
3. **Simple / House / DMM stream (not formally numbered)**: Cole is foundational via the LTG framework, the IMB CHAT adaptation (Curtis Sergeant), the DAWN recommendation (Michael Steele), and the Felicity & Tony Dale relationship.
4. **APEST / 5Q ecosystem (Cluster 6 in master)**: Cole's Primal Fire (2014) sits as paired reading with Hirsch's 5Q (2017); five-author APEST construct is unique to Cole's contribution.

His unique cluster position: **patriarch elder of the organic-church / simple-church / multiplication stream, who also bridges into the Hirsch missional / 100M / APEST stream, the Underground / KCU / Tampa microchurch generation, and the IMB / Saddleback / DMM-CPM operational stream**. No other figure on the TAM list bridges these four streams as cleanly.

Bridge Analysis

Bridge	Strategic Implication
Cluster 1 ↔ DMM/CPM stream	Cole's LTG → IMB CHAT is one of the few documented operational adoptions of a Cluster-1 framework into the IMB / Saddleback / Sergeant / Addison stream.
Cluster 1 ↔ Cluster 5 (via Underground / KCU 2025)	Cole's 2025 KCU appearance + 2019 Sanders endorsement = cross-cluster bridge that the master graph currently does not capture.
Cluster 1 ↔ Simple / House church (Dales / House2House)	Cole's Black Swan Effect contribution (2014) and ongoing Felicity Dale relationship.
Cluster 1 ↔ APEST / 5Q (Cluster 6)	Cole's Primal Fire (2014) sits as paired reading with Hirsch's 5Q; same five-fold framework; complementary not redundant.
100 Movements design team (latent edges)	Adding Hirsch + Cole + Rhodes + Mancini + Cruickshank as a four-co-founder cluster around 100M would strengthen the master graph's representation of the missional design / training stack.

Research Gaps

These are the highest-value additions to Cole's network entry that this dossier surfaces but does not commit:

1. **Frank Viola** — current state of their working relationship since 2010 friction. Direct outreach needed.
 2. **Wolfgang Simson** — endorsement and ongoing relationship. Direct verification needed.
 3. **Felicity & Tony Dale** — depth of post-2014 collaboration. Direct verification needed.
 4. **Curtis Sergeant** — has Sergeant publicly named Cole as a foundational mentor? Direct citation needed.
 5. **Steve Addison** — book endorsements between Cole and Addison (likely exist but not catalogued).
 6. **Bobby Harrington / Discipleship.org** — adjacency depth.
 7. **The Phil Helfer / Paul Kaak / Ed Waken / Ross Rohde "CMA inner ring"** — none are in the master TAM list; should they be added as their own dossiers, or as Cole-adjacent nodes?
 8. **The 100 Movements Publishing author roster** — adjacent to Cole through Hirsch / Mancini / Rhodes.
 9. **International network** — does Cole have working relationships with practitioners in Africa, India, China, Brazil whose Greenhouse / LTG adoption is documented?
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Edges Proposed for Direct Application to Master Graph

The 27 high-confidence edges in the "Proposed Additions" table above are recommended for direct application to `docs/movement_leader_research/network/network-map.md` and `network-graph.json`. They are sourced from book front-matter, conference rosters, public endorsements, podcast episode pages, and the 2015 Will Mancini 100 Movements announcement. Each carries an evidence line in the table above.

Provenance

- **Source files read:**

- `docs/movement_leader_research/network/network-map.md`
- `docs/movement_leader_research/tam-search/01-MASTER-RANKED-LIST.md`
- `docs/movement_leader_research/neil-cole/profile/identity.md`
- `docs/movement_leader_research/neil-cole/profile/biography.md`
- `docs/movement_leader_research/neil-cole/network/organizations.md`
- `docs/movement_leader_research/neil-cole/network/collaborators.md`

- docs/movement_leader_research/neil-cole/network/endorsements.md
- docs/movement_leader_research/neil-cole/content/books.md
- docs/movement_leader_research/neil-cole/sources.md
- **Edges added in this run:** 0 (the master graph file should be updated by the human in a separate pass; this summary surfaces the candidates).
- **Edges proposed for commit:** 27 high-confidence (see "Proposed Additions" table).
- **Edges proposed but flagged for verification first:** 6 medium-confidence + 9 research gaps.
- **Confidence:** **High** on the 100 Movements co-founder edges, the CMA-team co-author edges, the Black Swan Effect contributor edges, the foreword relationships, and the Sanders-endorser edge. **Medium** on the downstream framework-adoption edges (Sergeant, Addison) — these are real but harder to assign a precise weight.